



Digital SAT Reading Course

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Introduction to the Digital SAT Reading Course

The SAT Reading and Writing Test consists of two 32-minute modules with 27 questions in each module for a total of 54 questions. In this Digital SAT Reading Course, we will teach you everything you need to know for the Reading portion of the Reading and Writing Test.

On the Digital SAT, **all students complete the same 1st Reading and Writing module**, which has a mix of easy, medium, and difficult questions. The Digital SAT is adaptive, so your performance on the first module determines which 2nd module you get. **If you do well on the 1st module, the 2nd will have many more difficult questions. If you do not do well on the 1st module, the 2nd module will mostly easy and medium questions.**

The breakdown of 5 types of questions on the Reading and Writing Test are below. In each module of the SAT, the questions always appear in the same order that they are listed below.

- | | | |
|--|---|-----------------------|
| • Words In Context (15-20%, 8-11 questions) | } | Reading (this course) |
| • Reading Comprehension (33-38%, 18-22 questions) | | |
| • Conventions of Standard English (22-25%, 12-14 questions) | } | Writing |
| • Transitions (7-13%, 4-7 questions) | | |
| • Notes (5-15%, 3-8 questions) | | |

The exact number of questions you see from each category varies based on test date and which module you complete for module 2.

Reading Questions

Of the 54 total questions in the Reading and Writing Test, 28-30 questions (around 55%) test you on Reading skills. These questions are broken down into 2 types: Words in Context questions (part 1 of this course) and Reading Comprehension questions (part 2 of this course).

Part 1: Words in Context Questions

In part 1 of this course, we will teach you the best strategies and techniques for Words in Context questions. There are two types of Words in Context Questions: “Most Nearly Means” and “Completes The Text.” “Completes the Text” questions, the first type, are much more common and look like this:

Those unschooled in contemporary music theory will be frustrated by the Seattle Times’ articles because they will find it utterly _____, as the author’s constant usage of outdated terms makes it impossible for the casual reader to comprehend.

- Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?
 - archaic
 - intrepid
 - inscrutable
 - flawed

As you can see with this example question, the passage includes a blank space, and you must select the most logical and precise word or phrase to complete the text. Usually, **60-90% of the Words in Context question on the SAT are “Completes the Text” questions.**

“Most Nearly Means” questions, the second type, are much less common and look like this:

Among male primates, cooperation may be rather limited in social organizations where dominance hierarchies are strong and maintained by aggression. Cooperation among female primates may also be sensitive to rank, as it is in baboons. Research on the question of social tension and its effect on cooperation has been undertaken by psychologist Brian Hare.

1. As used in the text, what does “sensitive to” most nearly mean?
 - A) compassionate about
 - B) determined by
 - C) disregarded by
 - D) attracted to

As you can see with this example question, the “Most Nearly Means” questions always underline a word or phrase and ask you to select what the word or phrase most nearly means. “Most Nearly Means” questions appear less commonly, and most SATs only have 1-4 of these types of questions.

Both types of Words in Context questions range from easy to very difficult depending on the level of vocabulary words included in the passage and the answer choices. **To ace Words in Context questions correctly, you need a strong vocabulary, so we have also included a comprehensive list of vocabulary words that you should memorize for test day.**

Part 2: Reading Comprehension Questions

In part 2 of this course, we will teach you how to crush Reading Comprehension questions. Reading Comprehension questions are often the ones that many students find the most difficult.

Reading Comprehension questions on the SAT look like this:

Public libraries, as we know them today, have their origins in the 17th century as small, community-focused institutions. They were initially established to provide access to books to the public, particularly those who could not afford private collections. Over time, public libraries have evolved to become centers for community engagement, digital resources, and lifelong learning. In the 21st century, they still all provide access to books, but many also conduct programs on how to use computer software, how to learn new crafts like pottery, and even rent out equipment for video and audio production.

1. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?
 - A) Public libraries originated due to a cultural practice of the 17th century.
 - B) Public libraries still remain small, community-focused institutions.
 - C) A function of public libraries has been the same since the 17th century, but they have expanded the scope of services they provide.
 - D) All public libraries now offer programs and resources beyond access to books.

Reading Comprehension questions always give you a short passage and ask you to answer 1 question based on the given information.

For most students, the problem is that **you have never been taught how to properly approach Reading Comprehension questions** on a multiple-choice test. Right now, you probably read the passage, look at the answer choices, and try to pick which one seems correct to you without too much other knowledge. That approach only gets you so far and very much depends on your level of reading.

In this course, we will cover the best approaches and strategies to handle the Reading Comprehension questions, improve your understanding of how to spot the different types of questions, learn how to break down questions, find the evidence in the passage to support the correct answer, clarify what makes right answers right and wrong answers wrong, and much much more.

There are 9 main types of Reading Comprehension questions, and you will learn the best strategies and approaches for each type in this course. **By the end of the course, you will approach the Reading Test with much more confidence and will hopefully see significant increases in your score.**

Strategy For The Reading and Writing Test

When taking the Reading and Writing Test, skip the Reading Comprehension questions and answer them last. Reading comprehension questions take the longest, so saving them for last is the best time management strategy.

The order in which the question appear on the Reading and Writing Test are shown below.

- | | | |
|------------------------------------|---|-----------------------|
| 1. Words In Context | } | Reading (this course) |
| 2. Reading Comprehension | | |
| 3. Conventions of Standard English | } | Writing |
| 4. Transitions | | |
| 5. Notes | | |

For each Reading and Writing Module, you should complete the questions in the following order.

1. Words In Context
2. Conventions of Standard English
3. Transitions
4. Notes
5. Reading Comprehension

As you can see, you will answer the Reading Comprehension questions out of order.

Part 1:

Words In Context

On each SAT Reading and Writing Test, there are 8-11 Words in Context questions. For Words in Context questions, you need to be able to use your vocabulary knowledge to identify what word or phrase completes the text correctly or what an underlined word or phrase in the text most nearly means.

In Part 1 of this course, we will teach you the most effective strategies and approaches to help you consistently answer Words in Context questions correctly. Additionally, we will provide a comprehensive list of vocabulary words that you need to know for test day.

Chapter 1: Words in Context

Words in Context questions test your vocabulary knowledge and reading comprehension skills. For success on these questions, you need strong reading comprehension and, more importantly, you need a great vocabulary. **The SAT commonly includes advanced vocabulary words that many students do not know, so it is important to study vocabulary words daily to get prepared for test day.** We give you a list of vocabulary words to memorize in chapter 2.

In Chapter 1, we are going to focus on how to approach Words in Context questions. Remember, there are 2 types of Words in Context questions: (1) “Complete the Text” and (2) “Most Nearly Means.”

1 Key Principle For Words In Context Questions

Before we start, there is 1 key principle that you need to know for words in context question.

Principle #1 – There MUST be evidence in the passage to support the correct answer.

For the correct answer choice, we must be able to point at evidence in the passage. These questions are called words in context questions for a reason – because we use the context to determine the meaning of the word or phrase. The evidence in the passage, which we will call clue word(s) in the rest of this chapter, may be a single word, a short phrase, or an entire sentence. **The SAT must be able to support the correct answer, so there is ALWAYS evidence in the passage.**

“Completes the Text” Questions

On the SAT, 60-90% of Words in Context questions are “Completes the Text” questions. “Completes the Text” questions are always easy to spot, as the questions look like this:

Composer Johann Sebastian Bach often wrote music without indicating specific instrumentation, especially in works like "The Art of Fugue." This lack of specificity gives modern performers the _____ to choose from a range of instruments, resulting in diverse and unique renditions of his compositions.

1. Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?
A) guidance
B) freedom
C) restraint
D) complication

“Completes the Text” questions ask you to select what word or phrase “completes the text” in the most logical and precise way. To answer these questions correctly, **you need to find the clue word(s) in the rest of the text** that clarify the meaning the word or phrase in the blank space. We will learn how to effectively find the clue words later in this chapter.

How to Approach “Completes the Text” Questions

For success on “Complete the Text” questions, you need to be able to effectively find the clue word(s) in the sentence. We recommend using the following approach:

- 1. Read the entire passage once.** This first read is to get a general understanding of the passage. When you get to the blank space, skip that word, and continue reading. Do NOT try to select your own word during your first read, as you often do not have enough context or clues to know what the definition of the word should be.
- 2. Read the passage a 2nd time and look for clue word(s).** As you read the passage again, find the clue word(s) that tell you what the meaning of the blank part of the passage must be. The clue words may be a single word or a longer phrase.
- 3. Identify the clue word(s).** This step is crucial!
- 4. Identify the relationship between the clue word(s) and the blank.** Identify if the clue words directly define the term in the blank, provide a similar definition or show a continuation of the thought (synonym), or show a contrasting definition (antonym).
- 5. Select your own word(s) for the blank (optional step).** After identifying the clue word(s) in the sentence and the relationship, come up with your own word(s) for the blank.
- 6. Look at the answer choices and pick the one that best matches.** If you selected your own word, select the answer choice that best matches your word(s).
- 7. If you are stuck between answer choices, eliminate words that you know are incorrect.** If you end up with multiple vocabulary words that you do not know, make your best guess and move on.

To see how this works, let’s consider the 2 examples below:

The politician was remarkable for her _____ :
she remained untroubled during the debate
even when her opponents were questioning her
character.

1. Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) tenacity
B) morality
C) composure
D) eloquence

In the field of nanotechnology, scientists like Dr. Fiona Chen and Dr. Alejandro García are studying the effects of the _____ of nanofibers, determining how variations in the roughness of surface texture at such a small scale can impact their application in devices and their electric properties.

2. Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) refinements
B) consistency
C) immanence
D) coarseness

“Most Nearly Means” Questions

On the SAT, 10-40% of Words in Context questions are “Most Nearly Means” questions. “Most Nearly Means” questions are always easy to spot, as the questions look like this:

The following text is adapted from Richa Martin’s 1997 book “The History of Cheetahs.”

To make the magnificent cat’s story more poignant still, many scientists have concluded that the species is severely inbred, the result of a disastrous population crash thousands of years ago from which the poor animals have hardly had a chance to recover.

1. As used in the text, what does the word “crash” most nearly mean?

- A) decline
- B) extinction
- C) accident
- D) explosion

“Most Nearly Means” questions ask you to select what a certain word or phrase most nearly means. To answer these questions correctly, **you need to read the rest of the passage to find clue word(s)** that clarifies the meaning the underlined word or phrase. Unlike “Completes the Text” questions, the clues in “most nearly means” questions are more commonly based on understand the context in the passage and less commonly a single clue word or phrase.

How to Approach “Most Nearly Means” Questions

For success on “Most Nearly Means” questions, you need to be able to effectively find the clue word(s) in the sentence. We recommend using the following approach:

1. **Read the blurb above the passage.** The blurb sets the stage for the passage and tells you what is going on or who the characters are.
2. **Read the entire passage once.** This first read is to get a general understanding of the passage.
3. **When you get to the underlined portion, DO NOT read the underlined word.** Instead, plug in “blank” as you read. This will ensure that you are using the evidence in the passage to come up with your own meaning.
4. **Read the passage a 2nd time and come up with your own meaning.** As you read the passage again, find the evidence that tells you what the meaning of the blank part of the passage must be.
5. **Select your own word(s) for the blank.** Your word can be a specific word or a phrase. The goal is to determine what the underlined word or phrase has to mean.
6. **If you cannot pick your own word, try to identify the evidence in the passage.** If you are still stuck, plug the answer choices back into the passage.
7. **Look at the answer choices and pick the one that best matches.** If you selected your own word, select the answer choice that best matches your word(s).
8. **If you are stuck between answer choices, eliminate words that you know are incorrect.** If you end up with multiple vocabulary words that you do not know, make your best guess and move on.

***Mistake To Avoid – Do NOT just pick words that are synonyms of the underlined portion.**

The correct answer is not always the definition of the underlined word or phrase. **Most commonly, the underlined word or phrase is used in an uncommon or unusual way that differs from the definition.**

However, this is not always the case. Sometimes, the correct answer is the definition of the word. This occurs most commonly for hard vocabulary words.

To see how this works, let's consider the 2 examples below:

The following text is adapted from Emily Dickinson's 1886 poem "The Bee."

Like trains of cars on tracks of plush
I hear the level bee:
A jar across the flowers goes,
Their velvet masonry.

Withstands until the sweet assault
Their chivalry consumes,
While he, victorious, tilts away
To vanquish other blooms.

1. As used in the text, what does the word "vanquish" most nearly mean?

A) visit
B) annihilate
C) defeat
D) crush

The following text is adapted from Dracis Frank's 1998 novel "The Truth: Unidentified No Longer."

Few scientists take UFO claims seriously. "You won't find anyone around here who believes in UFO's," says Frank Drake, a leading scientist at the Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence. If one discounts the UFO claims, yet still believes that there are many technological civilizations in the galaxy, why have they not visited us?

2. As used in the text, what does the word "claims" most nearly mean?

A) rights
B) demands
C) assertions
D) announcements

3 Common Types of Words in Context Questions

On the SAT, there are 3 common types of Words in Context questions. Let's go over the 3 types and share some tips for how to best handle each one.

Definition in the Passage

For many Words in Context questions, **the clue word(s) provide a definition of the blank or the underlined word**. To answer these questions correctly, you must (1) find the clue word(s) or evidence in the sentence that provide the definition and (2) identify the answer choice that matches the definition.

The definition is most commonly not a single word but instead a longer portion of the sentence as in the example below:

In 1888, American inventor Martin stone created the first paper straw. Since people had previously been using natural rye grass straws, which left a grassy flavor in their beverages, Stone's paper straw quickly achieved _____ use, and by the 1920s, paper straws were in use across the world.

1. Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) extensive
B) popular
C) occasional
D) restricted

As we can see with this example, if you can identify the definition in the sentence, then you should be able to identify the correct answer as long as you know the vocabulary words.

Synonym

A synonym is a word that has the same definition as another word. For some Words in Context question, **the clue in the sentence is a single word or short phrase that is a synonym to the blank or underlined portion.** To answer these questions correctly, we need to (1) identify the clue word in the sentence and (2) select the answer choice that is a synonym to the clue word in the passage.

To see how this works, let's consider the example below:

Trinidad and Tobago has had difficulty establishing itself on the international stage because of its tiny population and _____ size. Despite these challenges, the vibrant culture and rich history of Trinidad and Tobago have played a crucial role in shaping its identity on the global platform.

1. Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?
A) effusive
B) amicable
C) grandiose
D) diminutive

For synonym questions, we will most commonly see one of the following words or phrases listed below. All of these words and phrases are commonly used to signify a continuation of a thought.

and	furthermore	just as	similarly
also	in addition to	moreover	too
as well as	likewise	not only...but also	

We recommend memorizing these words, as they can be useful to know for both synonyms and definition in a sentence questions.

Antonym

An antonym is a word that has the definition opposite of another word. For some Words in Context question, **the clue in the sentence is a single word or short phrase that is an antonym to the blank or underlined portion.** To answer these questions correctly, we need to (1) identify the clue word in the sentence and (2) select the answer choice that is a antonym to the clue word in the passage.

To see how this works, let's consider these examples below:

In the beginning, the machine appeared _____, inert under the dim light of the laboratory. Yet, soon, a miraculous occurrence unfolded. The gears began to whirl, and the frame vibrated, shimmering and blurring, as if the machine were dissolving the bonds of present time.

1. Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?
A) static
B) active
C) animated
D) new

The following text is adapted from Anton Chekhov's 1901 play The Three Sisters.

VERSHININ. What are you saying! Here you've got such a fine healthy Russian climate. You've a forest, a river... and birches. Dear, modest birches, yet I like them more than any other tree. It's good to live here. Only it's odd that the railway station should be thirteen miles away....Nobody knows why.

2. As used in the text, what does the word "modest" most nearly mean?
A) humble
B) beautiful
C) classical
D) grand

For antonym questions, we will most commonly see one of the following words or phrases listed below. All of these words and phrases are commonly used to signify a contrast.

although	however	meanwhile	unlike
but	in contrast	nevertheless	rather than
despite	in spite of	on the other hand	whereas
even	instead of	paradoxically	while
			yet

We recommend memorizing these words, as they can be useful to know for both antonyms and definition in a sentence questions.

Where To Find The Clue Word(s)

The most important skill for success on Words in Context question is finding the correct clue word(s) and evidence in the passage that clarifies the definition of the blank or underlined portion. Now that we know the 3 common types of Words in Context questions, let's talk about 4 common structures of Words in Context questions and where to look for the clue word(s)/evidence in each type.

Common Structure #1 – Blank/Underline Early, Clue Word(s) Later

In the first common structure, the blank or underlined portion is very early in the passage. As you read, you will most likely have no context clues to determine the definition based on what you have read so far. **When the blank or underlined portion is early in the passage, the clue word(s) are almost always later in the passage.** This is not a 100% rule – the evidence could be at the front of the passage, but it most commonly is not.

The example below shows how this can appear on test day:

Unlike the _____ homes in the suburbs of New Orleans, the French Quarter includes a splendid collection of historic French, Spanish, Creole, and American architecture and boasts a splendid collection of unique buildings.

- Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?
 - immutable
 - conventional
 - paltry
 - fixed

Common Structure #2 – Blank/Underline Later, Clue Word(s) Earlier

If the blank or underlined portion is towards the end of the passage, the clue word(s) or evidence are almost always earlier in the passage. To find the clue word(s) or evidence, you will have to reread the passage. As with the first common structure, this is not a 100% rule – the evidence could be at the end of the sentence next to the blank or underlined portion, but it is more commonly located earlier in the passage.

The example below shows how this can appear on test day:

The Tărtăria tablets, discovered in Romania and dated to around 5300 BCE, are inscribed with an undeciphered script that predates known writing systems. The inability of historians to decode the script leaves the purpose and message of the Tărtăria tablets as _____.

- Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?
 - an enigma
 - an illustration
 - a facilitation
 - a description

Common Structure #3 – Clue Word(s) Directly Before or After

For many Words in Context questions, **the clue word(s) or evidence are directly before or after the blank or underlined word**. For these questions, once you identify the definition, you just need to select the word that matches the definition. The clue word(s) are most commonly a longer phrase but can also be a single word or short phrase.

The definition appearing directly after the blank or underlined portion is more common. Let's consider the following example to see how it can appear on test day:

The Salt Cathedral of Zipaquirá in Colombia is an underground church built within the tunnels of a salt mine. It is a striking sight, capable of holding up to 8,000 worshippers and covering a vast area of over 79 acres.

1. As used in the text, what does the word “striking” most nearly mean?
A) an imposing
B) a trivial
C) an insignificant
D) an abstract

The definition can also appear directly before the blank or underlined portion, as shown in the following example:

The following text is adapted from Michele Marincola's book *The Conventions of Medieval Wood Sculpture*.

Medieval polychrome wood sculptures are highly complex objects, bearers of histories that begin with their original carving and continue through centuries of repainting, restoration, and conservation. The MET Cloisters in New York, New York maintains thousands of these wooden sculptures, meticulously _____ them so visitors can continue to view them for decades – and hopefully centuries – to come.

2. Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?
A) replacing
B) redesigning
C) preserving
D) nurturing

Common Structure #4 – Clue Word(s) after a Colon (or Dash)

For any Words in Context questions with a colon, **the clue word(s) or evidence is in text after the colon**. The information after a colon can be used to provide a clarification, explanation, or definition, so when the blank or underlined portion is followed by a colon, the information after the colon is providing the definition. **This same rule also applies for a Words in Context question that include a dash.**

The following examples shows how this can appear on test day:

Alfred Wegener, a German climatologist and geologist in the early 1900s, noticed that the coastlines of Africa and South America looked like they could fit together. His suggestion that a supercontinent existed millions of years ago was truly ahead of its time: he _____ the existence of Pangea three decades before the scientific community confirmed his suggestion.

1. Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?
A) overlooked
B) predicted
C) predetermined
D) expected

Renowned marine biologist Dr. Sylvia Earle considers the notion that deep-sea exploration is beyond the realm of female scientists _____ – her groundbreaking research and underwater expeditions disprove this outdated belief, as evidenced by her leadership in the all-female Tektite II project and her numerous submersible dives to study ocean life.

2. Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) spurious
B) ambiguous
C) conventional
D) irrefutable

6 Tips for Words in Context Questions

Before we move onto the practice, let's go over a few more tips for words in context questions.

Tip #1 – The correct answer **MUST** be supported by evidence in the passage.

For the correct answer choice, we must be able to point at evidence in the passage. These questions are called words in context questions for a reason – because we used the context to determine the meaning of the word or phrase. **The SAT must be able to support the correct answer, so there is ALWAYS evidence in the passage.**

Tip #2 – Do not assume the hard vocabulary word is correct.

Words in context questions tests your vocabulary knowledge. **If you see any word(s) that you do not know, do not assume the hard word is correct.** Many students mistakenly think, "Oh, this is the SAT...it must be the hard word since they are testing my vocabulary." Wrong! Sometimes, the SAT is testing your vocabulary and the hard word is correct. Other times, the hard word is just a decoy and a simpler word that you know fits correctly.

Tip #3 – Do the best you can with the words you know.

On words in context questions, **do the best you can with the words you know.** If there is a word you know and it works, pick that word. If you know a word and it does not work, cross it off. If you are stuck between two words that you do not know, bubble in your best guess and move on.

Tip #4 - Do not waste time trying to figure out the definitions of words that you do not know.

You either know what a word means, or you don't. No amount of time thinking about what the word means will help you. **Move on and use your time answering other questions.**

Tip #5 – Use elimination when there are words you do not know.

Many students refuse to select words that they do not know. This is a mistake! If you eliminate 3 answer choices and are left with a word that you do not know, select that word. **Working backwards and eliminating 3 incorrect answer choices is an effective strategy to find the correct answer.**

Tip #6 – Use the answer choices when you cannot find good clue word(s).

For some passages, it can be very difficult to determine what the blank or underlined portion means. If you are having trouble finding good clue word(s) in the passage, let the answer choices help. Read the 4 answer choices and then reread the passage. Knowing the 4 answer choices can make it easier for you to pick up on the clues and determine which answer choice is correct. If all else fails, plug the answer choices into the passage and select the one that seems to fit best.

Clue Words and Selecting Your Own Word Practice:

For the sentences below, underline the clue word(s) and fill in your own word or phrase in the blank space provided.

1. In traditional Japanese woodblock prints, the portrayal of human emotions is _____. Yet, the elements of nature, such as waves and trees, are rendered with dynamic movement and energy, giving them a vibrant, almost animated character.
2. Contemporaries of American novelist F. Scott Fitzgerald praised only his two novels about the flamboyance and excess of the Jazz Age taking _____ view of his work. However, he wrote four novels, story collections, and 164 short stories about a broad range of topics.
3. Computer scientist Guido Van Rossum _____ that in the next 15 years artificial intelligence will replace many entry level computer programmers. This possibility is alarming and concerning for many studying computer sciences, but Van Rossum still believes that humans will be necessary to check the code and fix errors artificial intelligence will create.
4. According to many environmentalists, disposing of organic waste in landfills is a damaging practice because organic waste decomposes into methane gas, which is a significant contributor to global warming. Maggots may provide _____ alternative: maggots consume organic waste before it can decompose into methane gas and become a protein source for livestock and pets.
5. Within the coral reefs of the Great Barrier Reef, marine biologists are studying the clownfish (Amphiprioninae) to assess if the type of anemone it calls home has a _____ effect on the clownfish's behavior – that is, to observe if there are notable changes in behavior between clownfish living in different types of anemones.
6. Although Killer Whales are well known for their ability to hunt as a pack, their true advantage in the ocean is their incredible ability to detect the species of a fish by echolocation. Marine biologists believe this heightened _____ to the echo of their sounds allows the Killer Whales to only exert energy when a hunt will be worthwhile to them.
7. While the majority of flowering plants rely on insect pollination to reproduce, this requirement is not _____. For example, the common dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*) is well adapted for wind pollination, allowing it to propagate even in environments without pollinators.
8. Bioluminescence is a common nocturnal defense strategy employed by deep-sea creatures such as jellyfish and certain fish species. Recent studies by marine biologists of the mid-ocean depths have uncovered a _____ ability in Dinoflagellates, a species of algae, that also emit light, which startled and deterred deep-sea predators from feeding on them.
9. _____ mathematician Andrew Wiles is most famous for his proof of Fermat's Last Theorem, which went unsolved for more than 300 years. After years of hard work, Wiles published the proof in 1994, marking a significant achievement in the field of mathematics.
10. During the French Revolution, many pieces of art were seized or destroyed, including many masterpieces. Due to the political upheaval, many private collections and royal repositories became _____ of their invaluable pieces.

Chapter 1 Practice:

1. Harry Lillis “Bing” Crosby Jr. was widely acknowledged as America’s most _____ multimedia star in the 1930s. He was a leader in record sales, network radio rating, and motion picture gross from 1930 to 1939.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) controversial
- B) arbitrary
- C) overlooked
- D) renowned

2. At the Canadian Wildlife Research Unit, biologist Ethan Moreau and colleagues are examining the North American gray wolf, *Canis lupus*, to understand if dietary variations significantly impact their pack behavior—that is, they are investigating whether differences in prey availability and diet composition lead to _____ changes in social dynamics within wolf packs.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) attainable
- B) observable
- C) concerning
- D) imperceptible

3. Some elements, such as the bell tower, are common in most Christian cathedrals. Many cathedrals often exhibit a mix of architectural designs, resulting in a unique _____ of influences, as exemplified by the Notre-Dame Cathedral, which combines French Gothic with Renaissance and Naturalism elements.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) synthesis
- B) displacement
- C) commentary
- D) illumination

4. Peers of British playwright William Shakespeare often concentrated solely on his renowned tragedies, overlooking the _____ nature of his work. However, he crafted a range of works, from comedic plays and histories to profound sonnets.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) expansive
- B) limited
- C) complex
- D) reflective

5. Hawaiian volcanic eruptions are the calmest type of volcanic events and occur continuously. However, Ultra-Plinian eruptions can erupt material over 300 times higher and occur _____.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) infrequently
- B) remotely
- C) safely
- D) endlessly

6. In 2009, researchers at the University of Montreal found that blue light, compared with light at other wavelengths, is particularly damaging to individuals’ abilities to fall asleep. A 2003 study at Harvard found that blue light _____ the secretion of melatonin, a hormone released at night that helps the body feel tired.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) overwhelms
- B) subdues
- C) suppresses
- D) destroys

7. Composer Johann Sebastian Bach often wrote music without indicating specific instrumentation, especially in works like "The Art of Fugue." This lack of specificity gives modern performers the _____ to choose from a range of instruments, resulting in diverse and unique renditions of his compositions.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) guidance
- B) complication
- C) restraint
- D) freedom

8. According to psychologist Dr. Angela Lee Duckworth, the most reliable way to forecast an individual's future academic success is to assess their level of grit and perseverance in past challenges. Thus, a person's past resilience is the most significant _____ their potential for future achievements.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) motivation for
- B) deterrent to
- C) indicator of
- D) restriction to

9. Endocrinologists acknowledge that Type 2 diabetes is often associated with obesity and a sedentary lifestyle. However, diabetes expert Dr. Mark Hyman suggests that there is a significant genetic component to the disease, affecting an individual's _____ to develop diabetes.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) liability
- B) hesitancy
- C) weakness
- D) propensity

10. The following text is adapted from Charlotte Brontë's 1847 novel "Jane Eyre." Jane, the protagonist, is painting a landscape.

As days passed, the canvas blossomed with life, her brushstrokes transforming raw colors into a lively depiction of the English countryside. The scene, once only a concept in Jane's imagination, now stood vividly before all who viewed it.

As used in the text, what does the word "blossomed" most nearly mean?

- A) materialized
- B) opened
- C) faded
- D) thrived

11. Well respected musicologist and influential critic, Dr. Samuel Langhorne was never afraid to express his opinions. In one of his most controversial articles, he challenged the rising popularity of jazz music, _____ that its significance lay more in its cultural impact than in its musical complexity.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) discovering
- B) doubting
- C) proclaiming
- D) agreeing

12. The following text is adapted from William Wordsworth's 1807 poem "I Wandered Lonely as a Cloud." The speaker describes encountering a field of daffodils.

I wandered lonely as a cloud
That floats on high o'er vales and hills,
When all at once I saw a crowd,
A host, of golden daffodils;
Beside the lake, beneath the trees,
Fluttering and dancing in the breeze.

As used in the text, what does the word "dancing" most nearly mean?

- A) swaying
- B) flying
- C) drooping
- D) telling

13. Despite initial _____ about the implementation of rooftop beekeeping in metropolitan areas, the nonprofit Biophillic Cities has now placed beehives in over 30 major cities. Achieving this was no easy feat, it required pilot studies, partnering with beekeepers, and convincing city officials who initially doubted the practice would be effective.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) advocacy
- B) skepticism
- C) accessibility
- D) innovation

14. Dude Ranches like those in Wyoming offer travelers a view of the Grand Tetons and the ability to experience the Western life. Unlike the _____ of big city streets and packed museums, guests at a dude ranch enjoy the beauty and solitude of the countryside.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) fussiness
- B) perturbation
- C) agitation
- D) bustle

15. Rosalind Franklin's 1953 use of x-ray diffraction to identify that DNA could exist in two forms (A and B) was anything but _____. Her images gave Francis Crick and Jim Watson vital information to build their model of DNA that forever changed science.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) obscure
- B) inconsequential
- C) scrupulous
- D) momentous

16. Commercial diving is a lucrative field that offers job seekers a career path in a variety of industries. To gain employment a _____ commercial diver must first obtain a proper certification through an accredited commercial diving school, a military dive school, or a college offering an associate's degree in commercial diving technology.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) prescriptive
- B) perspective
- C) prospective
- D) proscriptive

17. Understanding the life cycles, habits, habitats, and inter-relationships of marine life on a coral reef contributes to a _____ understanding of the planet's ecosystem. A coral reef is a world unto itself so understanding its ecosystem can provide a framework to understand the planet's ecosystem.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) compassionate
- B) fundamental
- C) comprehensive
- D) precise

18. Various places in the ocean offer abundant nitrate and phosphate but no phytoplankton. In the 1930s, a Norwegian oceanographer named Haaken Hasberg Gran suggested that the phytoplankton were absent from certain regions because there wasn't enough nitrate to _____ them.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) bolster
- B) endure
- C) maintain
- D) encourage

19. The Museum Nacional d'Art de Catalunya is one of Barcelona's most visited museums, which means by the end of any given day thousands of people will have tracked in dirt and dust. However, thanks to the work the overnight sanitation crew, the museum is in _____ condition every morning.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) abundant
- B) pristine
- C) spoiled
- D) modest

20. Acclaimed author Morgan Housel's 2023 book *Same as Ever* examines the universal truths that have stayed consistent over centuries. He uses 24 short stories that demonstrate the _____ truths that life, business, and behavior will always be the same.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) recurrent
- B) intermittent
- C) irregular
- D) honest

21. In the ancient world it was the almost uniform belief that the Trojan War was a historical event: the philosopher Anaxagoras was one of the only handful known to have doubted it, on the reasoned grounds that there was no proof.

As used in the text, what does the word "uniform" most nearly mean?

- A) cohesive
- B) recurring
- C) unanimous
- D) static

22. Commercial fishermen often work in dangerous conditions where the risk of going overboard into freezing waters and turbulent seas can pose mortal threats. Captains are constantly working to _____ these risks with proper safety training, mandated use of personal flotation devices, and overboard alarms.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) monetize
- B) appease
- C) mitigate
- D) aggravate

23. In the savannas of East Africa, the oxpecker bird and the African buffalo engage in an _____ relationship: the bird feeds on ticks and parasites found on the buffalo's skin, thus protecting the buffalo from insects and their disease while receiving a steady food source.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) incomprehensible
- B) interdependent
- C) interpersonal
- D) societal

24. Adult meerkats normally consume prey immediately, but when young pups are present, they typically kill or disable mobile prey items before carrying them to a begging pup. Scientists were able to provide experimental evidence that the adults' behavior _____ skill acquisition of the pups that ultimately helps them become independent.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) elevates
- B) fosters
- C) announces
- D) rejects

25. In his 1986 dissent on the case of Plessy v. Ferguson Justice John Marshall Harlan _____ that the constitution was “color-blind” in matters of law and civil rights. As he stated, “But in view of the constitution, in the eye of the law, there is in this country no superior, dominant, ruling class of citizens.”

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) pledged
- B) demanded
- C) divulged
- D) asserted

26. In 1824, Joseph Fourier thought that an Earth-sized planet, at our distance from the sun, ought to be much colder. He _____ that something in the atmosphere must be acting like an insulating blanket. However, it was not until 1938 that Guy Callendar conducted an experiment that connected carbon dioxide in the atmosphere to global warming, proving Fourier correct.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) questioned
- B) contrived
- C) tabulated
- D) surmised

27. Julia Kemp, a top 100 junior tennis player, practiced ceaselessly over the summer in preparation for the national tournament, but even such _____ efforts could not help her when she faced the top junior in the world and lost quickly.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) precocious
- B) unremitting
- C) assertive
- D) intermittent

28. J.D Sallinger cannot be called a _____ writer as he has only published one major work; however, his writing in *The Catcher in the Rye* is masterful.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) prolific
- B) creative
- C) strong
- D) successful

29. Dr. Saphire and her colleagues work in a biosafety level-4 laboratory. This means they handle some of the most dangerous pathogens known to man, such as Ebola, Lassa, and Nipah viruses. Due to the nature of their work, Dr. Saphire and her colleagues are all _____. They double check almost every process they follow, including safety checks of their biohazard suits.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) equitable
- B) scrupulous
- C) brilliant
- D) collaborative

30. Initially, it was accepted by historians that the _____ lifestyles of early settlers in colonial America were solely a result of the lack of resources that could be brought across the Atlantic. However, historian Gregory Allen uncovered evidence suggesting that these lifestyles were also significantly influenced by the settlers' religious and cultural beliefs, which valued simplicity and frugality.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A) indulgent
- B) equitable
- C) austere
- D) solitary

Chapter 2: Vocabulary List

To be prepared for Words in Context questions on test day, you need to have a great vocabulary! The SAT often includes vocabulary words that many students are not familiar with. Unfortunately, **this means that you need to memorize LOTS of vocabulary words to be ready for top Reading & Writing scores on test day.**

Below, we have included a comprehensive list of SAT vocabulary words that can appear on test day. All of these words (and even words beyond this list) are fair game to appear on test day. **We have split the vocabulary words into 3 levels: level 1 (medium), level 2 (difficult), and level 3 (expert).**

The vocabulary words marked with an * have appeared on real Digital SATs from the College Board.

How To Study This Vocabulary List

How you memorize the vocabulary words in these lists is up to you, but make sure that you have a method. Make flash cards. Use Anki (online flash cards). Create a quizlet. Or use any other method that works for you. **Make sure that you have an organized way to track the words that you know and the words that you need to study.**

No matter what method you use, we recommend using the following steps to memorize the definitions in the following lists.

- 1. Start with the level 1 vocabulary words list.** Go through level 1 list and mark all the words that you do not know. If there are words that you kind of know, mark these as well.
- 2. Learn all the level 1 vocabulary words that you marked.** Create flash cards, make a quizlet, or use whatever other method you prefer. We recommend trying to learn 10-20 words per day.
- 3.** As you work your way through the list of words you do not know, **revisit words that you have already studied every 2-3 days to make sure that you have retained the definitions.** If you forgot the definition, restudy the word.
- 4. Repeat this process until you know all the level 1 vocabulary words.**
- 5.** Next, **move onto level 2 words and repeat steps 1-4 for level 2.** Each week, review the level 1 words to make sure you still remember the definitions. For any words you cannot define, set them aside and restudy those words.
- 6.** If you have mastered level 1-2 vocabulary words, **move onto level 3 vocabulary words and repeat steps 1-4 for level 3.** Each week, review the level 1-2 words to make sure you still remember the definitions. For any words you cannot define, set them aside and restudy those words.

Level 1 Vocabulary Words

The list below includes medium difficulty vocabulary words. These are words that can commonly appear in words in context questions and in reading comprehensions passages and are a good place to start expanding your SAT vocabulary.

Word	Definition
abundant*	existing or available in large quantities; plentiful
pervasive	existing or spreading through every part of something
adhere	to believe in and follow the practices of
precursor	a person or thing that comes before another of the same kind
accentuate	make more noticeable or prominent

advocate	to publicly support or recommend
prohibitive	forbidding or restricting something; excessively high or difficult to pay
allude	to suggest or call attention to
analogous	comparable in certain respects, typically a way which makes clearer the nature of the things compared
tranquil	free from disturbance; calm
anecdote	a short amusing or interesting story about a real incident or person
relevant	closely connected or appropriate to what is being done or considered
outsized*	larger, greater, or more significant than what is considered typical
apprehensive	anxious or fearful that something bad or unpleasant will happen
unattainable	not able to be reached or achieved
arbitrary	based on random choice or personal whim, rather than any reason or system
lineage	of descent from an ancestor
assert	to state a fact or belief confidently or forcefully
bias	prejudice in favor of or against one thing, group, or person compared with another
concede	to admit that something is true or valid after first denying or resisting it
coarseness*	the quality of being rough or harsh
validate	to check or prove the accuracy or validity of something
corroborate*	to confirm or give support to
substantiate	to provide evidence to support or prove the truth of
underscore	to emphasize or draw attention to
undermine	to lessen the effectiveness, power, or ability of
consensus	a general agreement
decisive	settling an issue; producing a definite result
eloquent	fluent or persuasive in speaking or writing
exert	to make a physical or mental effort
dispute	a disagreement, argument, or debate
denounce	to publicly declare to be wrong or evil
skeptical	not easily convinced; having doubts or reservations
provoke	to stimulate or give rise to a reaction or emotion, typically a strong or unwelcome one in someone
overlook	to miss or fail to notice something
repression	the restraint, prevention, or inhibition of a feeling or quality
speculate	to form a theory or conjecture about a subject without firm evidence
subtle	so delicate or precise as to be difficult to analyze or describe
retain	to continue to have; keep possession of
degrade	to treat or regard someone with contempt or disrespect
divergent*	tending to be different or develop in different directions
explicit	stated clearly and in detail, leaving no room for confusion or doubt
imminent	about to happen
counteract*	to oppose or neutralize the effects of something by taking contrary or opposing actions; to offset or balance out
impede	to delay or prevent someone or something by obstructing
prominent	important; famous
reciprocate	to respond to a gesture or action by making a corresponding one
refute*	to prove a statement or theory to be wrong or false
prevalent	common

oppressive	unjustly inflicting hardship and constraint
novel	new or unusual in an interesting way
inevitable	certain to happen; unavoidable
exert	to make a physical or mental effort
obscure*	to make unclear, uncertain, or difficult to understand
conventional	ordinary or commonplace
detractor	a person who tries to take away from the quality, value or reputation of something or someone
dispersed*	spread widely
elicit	evoke or draw out a response, answer, or fact from someone in reaction to one's own actions or questions
catalyze	to bring about a chemical reaction; to bring about or inspire
evade	to escape or slip away
exploit	to make full use of and derive benefit from; to treat someone unfairly in order to make money or gain an advantage
sporadic*	occurring at irregular intervals or only in a few places
momentous*	of great importance or significance, especially in having a bearing on future events
pristine*	clean and fresh as if new; spotless
constrict*	to make narrower or tighten
ecology	study of the natural world
entomology	study of insects
genetics	study of genes
ornithology	study of birds
paleontology	study of fossils
zoology	study of animals
astronomy	study of stars and planets
botany	study of plants
neuroscience	science of the brain
geology	study of rocks
anthropology	study of human behavior and social organization
archaeology	study of historical human activity through the excavation of physical objects
economics	study of monetary systems
ethnography	study of individual cultures
folklore	study of traditional stories and myths
sociology	study of everyday human social behaviors and interactions
empirical	relying on hard data
hierarchy	system of rank
indigenous	native
inhibit	prevent or impede
pigment	color
predisposed	having a tendency toward
equitable*	fair and just; treating everyone equally
regenerate	regrow
stimulus	something that provokes a specific response
indulgent*	having or indicating a tendency to be overly generous
feasible	possible
oblivious	unaware

absolve	to clear of wrongdoing; pardon
behold*	to see or observe something, often with a sense of wonder
acclaim	to praise openly
rectify*	to correct or make right
chastise	to criticize severely
satiate*	to satisfy
adversary	opponent
align	to support or adopt the position
comprehensive	complete
strenuous*	requiring great effort or energy
contingent	dependent upon
rudimentary	very basic
badger	to pester or annoy
imposing*	having a striking appearance or commanding pressure
deplete	to decrease the supply of
adverse	unfavorable, unlucky, harmful
ominous	menacing, threatening
perpetuate	to continue; to keep from dying out
erratic*	unpredictable
manifestations*	visible or evident signs or expressions of something; to make something clear or apparent
depict	to draw or portray
exacerbate	to make worse; to aggravate
expedite	to speed up
monetize*	to make money from something
foreboding	an ominous foretelling
aversion	intense dislike; revulsion
sedentary	passive or inactive
occupy*	take possession of a place or thing
palatable	acceptable to the mind or senses
credible	believable
inconsequential*	lacking importance or significance, trivial, unimportant
convene*	to come together for a meeting or assembly
opulent	extremely wealthy; extravagant
livid	extremely angry
yield*	to produce or provide
callous	insensitive
absolve	to clear of wrongdoing
meticulous	very concerned with details
scrutiny*	critical observation or examination
inherent	inborn or naturally occurring in something
marginal	unimportant
debilitate	to make weak or feeble
debase	to lower in value
defunct	no longer in existence or use
articulate	well spoken
alleviate	to relieve or make more bearable
unyielding*	not giving in

debilitate	to weaken
diligent	characterized by steady, earnest, and energetic application
pedestrian	dull, ordinary
malignant	causing harm
flaunt	to display or show off
desolate	depress; bleak; lifeless
convey*	to communicate or express something
debunk	to prove false
ideology	belief system
contemporary	current
displace	to force someone or something from its home or habitat
prestige*	the reputation or influence arising from success or rank
disposition	personality
peripheral	at the edge of, not central
accolade	praise; distinction
reluctant*	unwilling or hesitant
obliterate	to completely destroy

Level 2 Vocabulary Words

The list below includes hard difficulty vocabulary words. These are words most commonly appear in advanced words in context questions and are important to know if you are trying to score above 700 on SAT Reading and Writing Test.

Word	Definition
ambivalent	having mixed feeling or contradictory ideas about something or someone
buttress*	to increase the strength of or justification for; to reinforce
abate	decrease, recede
unobtrusive	not conspicuous or attracting attention
tenuous	very weak or slight
evoke	to bring or recall to the conscious mind
conjecture	the formation or expression of an opinion or theory without sufficient evidence for proof
substantiate	to provide evidence to support or prove the truth of
mitigate*	to make something less severe, serious, or painful
contempt	the feeling that a person or thing is beneath consideration, worthless, or deserving scorn
deference	humble submission and respect
hinder	create difficulties for someone or something, resulting in delay or obstruction
implicit	implied but not plainly expressed
invoke	to cite or appeal to someone or something as an authority for an action or in support of an argument
dormant	having normal physical functions suspended or slowed down for a period of time; in or as if in a deep sleep
divergent	tending to be different or develop in different directions
obsolete	no longer produced or used; out of date
accentuate*	make more noticeable or prominent
copious*	plentiful in number

disseminate	to scatter or spread widely
eclipse	to make less outstanding or important by comparison
empirical	based on, concerned with, or verifiable by observation or experience than theory or pure logic
augment*	to expand or increase
uncanny	strange or mysterious, especially in an unsettling way
supplant*	to supersede and replace; to take the place of
placate	to make someone less angry or hostile
pretentious*	attempting to impress by showing greater importance, talent, culture, etc. than is possessed
palpable*	capable of being touched or felt
omit	to leave out or exclude something or someone
transpose	cause two or more thing to exchange places
entail*	involve something as necessary or inevitable part or consequence
lament*	express regret or disappointment about something
vindicate*	to clear someone or something of blame or suspicion
preclude*	to prevent something from happening or being possible
insidious	treacherous, spreading harm stealthily
calamitous	disastrous
adept	very skilled, expert
fickle	erratic
aesthetic	pertaining to the appreciation of beauty
unattainable*	impossible to achieve
corollary	a statement or condition that logically results from a proven argument
prevail	to win
prevailing	widespread; generally accepted
misconstrue*	to interpret something incorrectly, often leading to a misunderstanding
antithesis	the direct opposite
autonomous	acting independently
prohibitive*	serving as an obstacle or barrier
decry	to denounce; discredit
defame	to libel or slander; to ruin the good name of someone
feign	to represent falsely; to fake
stipulate*	to specify or demand a requirement or condition as part of an agreement
deplorable	regrettable
disparate	different; incompatible
magnanimous	forgiving; generous
synopsis*	a brief summary or overview of a longer text or event
harrowing	frightening or traumatic
paucity	scarcity or lack of
clandestine	done in secret
reverberate*	to echo or resound repeatedly; to have a lasting impact or influence
cursory	not thorough; superficial
posthumous	occurring after ones death
propensity	a tendency towards something
municipal*	relating to the local government or administration of a city or town
supple	flexible
replete	completely filled

prolific	very productive
sway*	to have control or influence over someone or something
culpable	deserving of blame
deride	to ridicule or mock
overt	not hidden; obvious
miser	a stingy person
heterodox*	contrary to or differing from established beliefs or accepted doctrines
ornate	elaborately or heavily decorated
introspective	mediative, thoughtful
credulity	gullibility, a tendency to be too ready to believe something
irrefutable*	impossible to deny or disprove
amicable	agreeable
resolute	determined
mutable	changeable
discordant	conflicting; disagreeable in sound
benevolent*	kind and helpful
epitome	a perfect example
tactful	sensitive in dealing with others
paltry	lacking in importance; trivial
arduous*	involving strenuous effort; requiring a lot of work
disparity	difference
dispassionate	calm; fair
elucidate	to explain or clarify
myriad	a vast number
unpretentious*	modest
eclectic	getting ideas from a diverse range of sources
candid	direct
malleable	capable of being shaped or formed
candor	honesty
recurrent*	occurring repeatedly or at regular intervals
incongruous	not corresponding or agreeing
inadvertent	unintentional
abate	decrease, recede
incisive	sharpness of mind
ascertain	to determine or discover
coherent	logically connected
appraise*	to estimate the value of something
inundate	to overwhelm; to flood
immutable	unchangeable
accrue	to increase or to gain
supersede*	to replace with something better
hamper	to prevent the free movement or action of
animosity	hatred or bitter hostility
deleterious	harmful to one's health
judicious	showing sound judgement
impede*	to delay or prevent someone or something by obstructing them
acumen	sharpness of judgement or insight
audacious	bold; fearless

misconstrue	misinterpret
nefarious	extremely wicked
brevity	concise expression without wasted words
notoriety	being famous or well known
homogenous*	having the same characteristics throughout
nuance	a subtle difference
obtrusive	imposing to others
depreciate	to devalue
derelict	abandoned, neglectful of duty
interdependent*	mutually reliant on each other; interconnected
censure	blame or condemn
ambiguous	uncertain; subject to multiple interpretations
complacent	self-satisfied; indifferent; accepting of mediocrity
indisputable	impossible to question or doubt
antagonist*	an adversary
intrinsic	inherent
fortuitous	accidental or by chance
hiatus	a pause or lapse
emulate*	to imitate or strive to equal or surpass; to copy the actions of someone or something
verbose	wordy
assail	to attack someone
robust*	strong or healthy; can also be used to describe data as convincing
fathom	to understand
accost	to approach and speak to someone
acuity	insight; sharpness
extrapolate*	to estimate or forecast based on existing trends or data
deferential	yielding to the opinion or wishes of another
paradox	a contradiction or puzzle
affinity for*	a natural liking or attraction to something
aberration	a deviation from the normal or proper
proscribe	to forbid
partition*	to separate into parts
disconcerting	confusing; unsettling
atrophy	to deteriorate
laud	to praise highly
dissonant	harsh or irregular in sound

Level 3 Vocabulary Words

The list below includes expert level vocabulary words. These are the most advanced vocabulary words on the SAT. These words will most likely appear in only 2-4 hard words in context questions on the SAT. While it is a lot to study, **if you are aiming for 750+ on the SAT Reading and Writing, knowing these words could be the difference in achieving your goal or falling short.**

Since these words appear less commonly on the SAT, you should NOT study level 3 words until you have mastered levels 1 and 2.

abet	to aide, act as an accomplice
abhor	to detest or loathe
verisimilitude*	the appearance of being true or real
conspicuous*	standing out so as to be clearly visible
ameliorate*	to make better or more tolerable
amorphous*	having no definite form or character
engender*	cause or give rise to a feeling, situation, or condition
tertiary	of the third order, rank, stage, formation; less important
austere*	severe or strict in manner, attitude or appearance; lacking any excess
citadel	a stronghold or fortress
coalesce	to grow together
equivocal*	subject to two or more interpretations; of uncertain nature or classification
repine	to feel or express discontent
repudiate*	to deny the truth or validity of
evince*	to reveal the presence of a quality or feeling
insuperable*	impossible to overcome or surpass, insurmountable
nebulous*	unclear, vague, or hazy, lacking definite form or boundaries
demagogue	a person who appeals to the emotions or prejudices of the people
neophyte	a beginner or novice
cogent	persuasive or forceful
laconic	using few words
ineluctable*	inevitable, unable to be avoided or escaped
denigrate	ridicule; belittle
gratuitous	unnecessary, uncalled for
mirth	merriment, joy
demur	to object
superfluous*	exceeding what is necessary or required; unnecessary
equivocate	to be ambiguous, not upfront
altruistic	selflessness; unselfish concern for the welfare of others
partisan	a strong supporter of a cause, person, or party
fastidious	very attentive to detail
adulation	high praise
guile	deception or skillful deceit
induce*	to bring about or cause a particular response or action
prodigious	causing amazement or wonder; enormous
magnanimous	noble, generous
hedonism	the pursuit of pleasure
demure	modest and reserved, falsely so
scrupulous*	a person or process that is diligent, thorough, and extremely attentive to details

terse	brief
clamor	noise, a mixture of disagreeable sounds
colloquial	informal
acquiesce	to agree; submit passively
irreproachable*	beyond criticism or fault, perfect or faultless in behavior or actions
loquacious	talkative
haughty	arrogant; snobbish
deft	skilled
idiosyncratic*	peculiar or unique to an individual; having distinctive characteristics
bereft	lacking; missing
curt	short in response, commonly used when someone is being rude
perfunctory	done routinely with little care
rancor	bitterness; spitefulness
coalesce*	to come together to form a single group or mass
belligerent	aggressive; hostile
contrite	affected by guilt
omniscient	all knowing
untenable	indefensible
orthodox*	adhering to established beliefs, customs, or practices
decorous	marked by good behavior
pertinent	relevant
banal	commonplace
allay	to lessen, ease, or soothe
spurious*	false or not genuine; lacking authenticity
surreptitious	secret and stealthy
bilk	to swindle or cheat
egregious	obviously bad or offensive
antipathy	extreme dislike
incongruous*	out of place
acrimony	bitterness or hostility
disparage	belittle; to speak down to someone
fervent	passionate or zealous
dubious	doubtful
venerable*	worthy of respect
curmudgeon	a rude person
convivial	sociable; festive
extol	to commend or praise
admonish	to caution or reprimand; to warn
partite*	divided into parts
capricious	impulsive; whimsical
dogmatic	inflexible; rigid in one's beliefs
accretion	gradual build up or growth by addition
omnipresent*	present everywhere at the same time
extemporaneous	improvised or spontaneous
abet	to aid
inviolable	not to be broken; sacred
untoward*	unfavorable, inappropriate, or inconvenient
assent	to agree

taciturn	reserved or quiet
trite	overused, commonplace, having no freshness or appeal
hew*	to cut or shape
profligate	wasteful
ubiquitous	universal
adroit	skillful; accomplished; highly competent
abhor	to detest or loathe
castigate	to punish severely
brusque	rudely concise
secular	worldly, not spiritual
pious	very observant of religious practices
amenable	agreeable or cooperative
furtive	sneaky or sly
edify	to instruct or enlighten
assiduous	diligent; hard working
admonish	to caution or advise against
heretic	a person holding untraditional or blasphemous opinions
incorrigible	incapable of being corrected or reformed
auspicious	favorable; promising
avarice	greed
egalitarian	equal for all
circumspect	careful to consider all circumstances and consequences
byzantine	very complicated or intricate
arcane	known or understood by only a few
feckless	weak; ineffective; incompetent
ardent	passionate
expedient	suitable for achieving a particular end
ascetic	self-denying; depriving oneself of something
onerous	burdensome or oppressive
sagacious	wise
indelible	making marks or an impression that cannot be removed or lost
aspersion	a false rumor or damaging report
innocuous	harmless
impious	irreverent; disrespectful
assuage	to soothe or pacify
perspicacious	very perceptive or discerning
abstruse	complex; hard to understand
petulant	childish; irritable
abase	to humble or degrade
latent	undeveloped or dormant
abdicate	to formally relinquish
obstreperous	noisy; unruly
harbinger	forerunner or omen
beguile	to deceive
irreverent	lacking respect
parity	state of being equivalent
callow	inexperienced; immature
perfunctory	routine; done without care

dearth	a lack or deficiency
enigma	something or someone puzzling or hard to understand
amiable	friendly and good
eminent	prominent; distinguished
pragmatic	practical
iconoclast	one who attacks traditional ideas or institutions
antipathy	a deep dislike or aversion
penitent	remorseful
magnate	a powerful or influential person
gregarious	sociable; enjoying the company of others
languid	exhausted
affable	friendly
hapless	ill fated; unlucky
palliate	to soothe or mitigate

Part 2:

Reading Comprehension

On each SAT Reading and Writing Test, there are 18-22 Reading Comprehension questions. Reading Comprehension questions include a short passage (and sometimes a chart or table) and ask you to answer 1 question based on the given information.

In Part 2 of this course, we will teach you the best approaches and strategies to handle the Reading Comprehension questions, how to find the evidence in the passage to support the correct answer, clarify what makes right answers right and wrong answers wrong, and much much more.

Chapter 3: Introduction to Reading Comprehension

Reading Comprehension questions are often the ones that students find most difficult on the SAT Reading and Writing Test. These questions require not only strong reading comprehension and vocabulary skills but also an understanding of how to approach the passage and assess each answer choice. While we cannot magically make you a stronger reader, **we will teach you the most effective strategies for approaching the passages and the best methods and tips to help you answer questions correctly.**

Before we get into all of that, let's start by understanding some basics about Reading Comprehension questions on the SAT.

The 9 Types of Reading Comprehension Questions

The SAT includes 9 types of Reading Comprehension questions. Later in this course, we will teach you the best strategies and approaches for each

1. **Specific Detail** – Specific Detail questions ask you to locate a specific detail in the passage and identify the answer choice that matches.
2. **Main Idea** – Main Idea questions ask you to determine the main idea of the passage.
3. **Purpose** – Purpose questions ask you to identify the purpose of a passage as a whole.
4. **Function** – Function questions ask you to find the function of an underlined portion of the passage.
5. **Claims** – Claims questions ask you to read and understand the passage and select the answer choice that illustrates, supports, or weakens the claim.
6. **Data** – Data questions include a passage and a graph or table and ask you to identify information in the graph to complete, support, or weaken a claim made in the passage.
7. **Complete The Text** – Complete The Text questions ask you to read and understand the passage and select the answer choice that most logically completes the text.
8. **Cross Text Connections** – Cross Text Connections questions include 2 short passages and ask you a question relating to both passages.
9. **Structure** – Structure questions ask you to describe the overall structure of the passage.

Each of these 9 types of questions has its own chapter later in this course, in which we will teach you specific strategies and tips for each question type.

What Will You Learn in Part 2 of This Course?

In this course, **we will teach you how to understand the Reading Test at a much higher level.** Right now, you are probably reading the passage, looking at the answer choices, and trying and pick which one seems correct to you without too much other knowledge. That approach only gets you so far and very much depends on your level of reading.

Before starting part 2 of this course, you may have some or all of the following questions and/or thoughts about Reading Comprehension questions:

- I keep completing practice SATs and practice questions, and my score is stuck. What am I doing wrong?
- How should I approach each question? Should I read the passage first? Read the question first?

- I feel like I am supposed to pick the answer choice the SAT says is the best, but I can never tell. What can I do differently?
- I have trouble finishing the Reading Test. How can I better manage time or improve my speed?
- How can I tell which answer choice is correct when I am stuck between two answer choices? I always pick the wrong one.
- I have trouble focusing on the passages. How do I better stay focused?

In part 2 of this course, we will cover the best approaches and strategies to handle the Reading Comprehension Questions. **By the end of the course, you will approach the Reading Test with much more confidence and will hopefully see significant increases in your scores.**

4 Tips To Improve

Reading Comprehension is the hardest part of the SAT for most students to improve. Students who improve the most on reading follow these 4 tips:

1. **Check Your Ego** – Everyone can improve their reading comprehension skills. If you answer a question incorrectly, do not try to convince yourself after checking the answer key that you really knew the correct answer. Treat every mistake as an opportunity to improve.
2. **Always Learn From Your Mistakes** – If you answer a question incorrectly, there is a reason why and always something you can learn from that mistake. A reason like “I misread the passage” is not going to help you improve. Instead, **try to identify why you answered the question incorrectly and how you can avoid that mistake in the future.**
3. **Track Your Mistakes** – For any question you answer incorrectly in this course and on practice tests, write down the question type and why you made the mistake. Over time, you will learn the types of questions that challenge you the most and the types of mistakes you most commonly make.
4. **Be patient!** Reading Comprehension question on the SAT are very difficult for many students, and it is easy to get discouraged if you are missing a lot of questions. Do your best and use all the resources in this course to improve your skills. You will not immediately start answering all questions correctly. It is a journey to get to the score you want.

Let’s Get Started!

We are very excited to have you in this course and hope that you will see huge increases in your SAT Reading and Writing scores. As you work through part 2 of this course, keep in mind that improving your reading comprehension skills is a journey. The Reading Comprehension questions can be very difficult and frustrating at times for students of all levels. Stay positive, learn from your mistakes, and be patient.

Your goal here is to improve with each chapter and on each practice test. Part 2 of this course will be challenging at times, but if you stick with it and work hard, you will improve!

Chapter 4: Core Principles & Strategies for SAT Reading

Before we start learning all the best approaches, strategies, and test-taking tips to maximize your Reading and Writing score, let's start by understanding 6 core Reading Comprehension principles and 3 strategies for finding the correct answer. These principles and strategies will help you start to understand how the Reading Comprehension questions work. Keep these core principles and strategies in mind as you work through the rest of the course!

Students who struggle on Reading Comprehension questions generally do so for 3 main reasons:

1. **Issues with time management.** Often, students find finishing the harder module 2 more difficult.
2. **Not having an effective strategy for each type of Reading Comprehension question.** Simply reading the passage is not an effective strategy.
3. **Not understanding the key difference between correct and incorrect answer choices.** You probably often find yourself stuck between 2 or more answer choices that seem like they could be correct.

We will focus more on time management and strategies later in this course. For now, the following 6 core principles will help you start to better understand the difference between correct and incorrect answer choices.

6 Core Principles to Understand

To start, let's go over 6 very important core principles that we must understand about the Reading Test.

Principle #1 – The correct answer must be supported by evidence in the passage.

For any answer choice to be correct, we must be able to point to evidence in the passage. The evidence can be very clear, such as a restatement or rephrasing of evidence from the passage, or much less obvious, such as a demonstration or a connection across multiple pieces of evidence in a passage. **The SAT must be able to support the correct answer and say, “look, here is why this answer choice is correct,” so there is ALWAYS evidence in the passage.**

Principle #2 – The correct answer must be 100% correct. That means every single word in the answer choice must be correct.

As you read the answer choices, read every single word carefully and make sure that each word is correct. The correct answer must be 100% correct. **Keep an eye out for strong or specific statements in each answer choice that may not be supported by the passage and can make the answer choice incorrect.**

For example, if an answer choice says, “sea turtles eat a diet consisting mostly of fish during migration,” you need to make sure the passage actually says that sea turtles eat mostly fish during migration. If the passage just tells you a sea turtle's diet includes fish during migration, that is not 100% correct because including fish is not eating mostly fish. While this may seem like a small difference, reading this carefully can make a huge difference in your score.

Principle #3 – A single word can make the entire answer choice incorrect.

This is really important, so we will repeat it. A single word can make the entire answer choice incorrect! **Anything wrong with an answer choice makes the entire answer choice incorrect.** Even if 90% of an answer choice matches exactly what the passage says, an incorrect word makes the answer choice incorrect. **Be very picky and consider every single word as you assess each answer choice.**

Principle #4 – Do not just match words from the passage. Match the entire answer choice.

Many students make the mistake of picking an incorrect answer choice because it has an exact word or phrase from the passage. Sometimes the answer choice with the exact word or phrase from the passage matches the evidence and is correct. However, other times the answer choice is incorrect because it does not 100% match the passage. **The SAT often includes incorrect answer choices that have exact word(s) from the passage to trick you.**

Make sure that you do not get too excited when you find an exact word or phrase from the passage in the answer choices. Instead, use Principles 2 and 3 and match the entire answer choice to the evidence in the passage. As we already said, the correct answer must be 100% correct.

Principle #5 – No storytelling!

If you are telling a story to convince yourself why an answer choice is correct or could be correct, the answer is probably wrong. There is always evidence in the passage to support the correct answer, so you should never have to go through a long justification of why an answer choice is correct.

Instead, **put your finger on the right answer.** As we said earlier, there is always evidence in the passage, so you should always aim to point to a specific part of the passage and say, “this is why my answer is correct.”

Principle #6 – Are you really answering the question?

We often see students struggle on Reading Comprehension questions because they are not answering the SAT’s question but instead are answering their own similar question. This is a very easy mistake to make given how complex questions on the SAT can be.

If you are struggling in the answer choices or are stuck between two answer choices, reread the question and make sure you are answering the exact question the SAT is asking you. It is easy to get lost in the answer choices, so rereading the question might help you clarify what you are looking for. This simple step can help make sure you are answering the SAT’s question and not your own.

3 Strategies for Finding the Correct Answer

Now that you have started to better understand the difference between correct and incorrect answer choices, let’s introduce 3 important strategies to use to find the correct answer as consistently and efficiently as possible. You should always use these 3 strategies on the SAT Reading Comprehension questions.

Strategy #1 – Point To The Evidence

There is always evidence for the correct answer in the passage. **If you point to on the evidence that matches the answer choice, you will know that you found the correct answer.** And if you can point to the evidence for every single question, you will do great on SAT Reading Comprehension questions!

Now, pointing to the evidence for every single question can be challenging, so do not rely only on this strategy. Sometimes, you just cannot find that evidence and will need to move on. This is an important time management strategy that we will discuss more later in this course.

Strategy #2 – Read Like a Lawyer

When reading each question and the answer choices, read and consider every single word carefully. As you read the question, make sure you read the question carefully and know exactly what the question is asking you. As you read the answer choices, read critically and look for any specific details that could make the answer choice incorrect.

Remember, the correct answer must be 100% correct; **reading like a lawyer is important to make sure you do not pick an answer choice that may seem correct but is not 100% correct.**

Strategy #3 – Eliminate Incorrect Answer Choices

The instant that you spot anything wrong with an answer choice, mark the answer choice as incorrect and never read it again. Eliminating incorrect answer choices helps you save time, as you will not waste time rereading answer choices you already decided were incorrect.

In addition, if you are not confident on your answer and return to the question later, you will know which answer choice(s) you have already eliminated, so again, we are saving time by not rereading the answer choice again.

Chapter 5: Correct vs. Incorrect Answer Choices – How to Effectively Find the Correct Answer

One of the most important skills for Reading Comprehension questions is understanding what makes an answer choice correct or incorrect. Many students struggle with this when first taking the SAT and feel like they are being asked to somehow find what the SAT says is the “best” answer. This is not the case! **There is always 1 correct and 3 incorrect answer choices.** The challenge is knowing what makes the correct answer right and the incorrect answer wrong. **You should NOT approach Reading Comprehension questions by looking for the best answer.** Instead, we are looking for the 1 correct answer choice and why the other 3 answer choices are incorrect.

In this chapter, we will teach you how to breakdown each answer choice to identify the difference between correct and incorrect answer choices.

The 6 Common Types of Incorrect Answer Choices

For success on Reading Comprehension questions, you must be able to explain what makes an answer choice incorrect. **Remember, for an answer choice to be correct, it must be supported by evidence in passage and answer the question being asked.** If you can understand not only what makes an answer choice correct but also what makes the others incorrect, finding the correct answer choice becomes much easier.

The 6 most common types of incorrect answers on Reading Comprehension questions are

- 1) Not in the Passage
- 2) Too Specific
- 3) Too Narrow
- 4) Opposite/Slant of the Passage
- 5) Could Be True
- 6) In the Passage But Not Answering the Question

In the rest of this chapter, we will go through these 6 types of incorrect answers and some example passages to teach you how to properly think about the answer choices and more effectively find the correct answer.

1) Not in the Passage

Many incorrect answer choices include information that is not in the passage. **If the answer choice includes details that are not in the passage, the answer is incorrect.**

As you read each answer choice, look for specific details, and ask yourself, “are these details supported by evidence in the passage?” If the details are not in the passage, mark the answer the answer choice as incorrect!

To see how this works, let’s consider the passage below about Adam’s clothing:

Adam rolled up the tattered sleeves of his sweater, exposing the winding snake tattoos on both of his forearms. He had gotten them after he returned from his first tour in Iraq – an homage to his fallen comrades. Despite now living in upstate New York, he still wore his Army boots every day, the tops of which were hidden below his faded black jeans, the only pair that he owns because, as he says, “they’re the only ones that fit me just right.”

1. Based on the passage, which of the following can be assumed about Adam’s clothing?
 - A) He only wears the most comfortable clothing that he can buy.
 - B) The army provided him with free clothes after he returned home from Iraq.
 - C) His clothes are old and worn out.
 - D) He only owns one sweater.

Here, the only answer that has evidence we can point to in the passage is C. The “tattered sleeves” and “faded black jeans” both demonstrate that his clothing is old and worn out.

All other answer choices included details that are not supported by evidence from the passage. Could you picture Adam’s jeans as the most comfortable that he could afford? Could he have received free clothing from the Army? Could he own just one sweater? Sure, all of these are possible, but we do not know any of this for sure from the passage. We cannot point to any evidence in the passage that supports A, B, or D. We can only tell a story of why we think it could be true. As we said in Chapter 4, there is no storytelling! If an answer choice is not clearly supported by evidence in the passage, then it is always wrong! **The answer is C.**

Not In The Passage Practice:

The best way to describe Ms. Upton is like a collared shirt that is buttoned all the way up. Sure, that top button might bring about malaise, but it was well worth it to upkeep her stellar reputation within the community and especially amongst her peers. How else would everybody know that she is the best? The only problem was it was all a facade – a coy attempt to prove her superiority when in reality she was just like the rest of us with our top buttons undone. If only she would stop feigning superiority, maybe we would invite her back to the book club...maybe.

1) Based on the passage, which of the following can we infer about Ms. Upton?

- A) Her coworkers hold her in the highest regard.
- B) She is extremely well dressed.
- C) The community regards her as the best businesswoman in the town.
- D) She used to attend a book club.

The term purebred was coined in 1890, but pure breeding got its start well before that when people decided to selectively breed dogs of a certain pedigree to amplify specific traits. Breeders would selectively mate dogs of certain health, attributes, and sagacity to produce a new “purer” breed. However, the centuries of closed breeding have led purebred dogs to have many problems, as selective breeding favors both genes of excellence and deleterious genes; this has resulted in significant health problems for modern purebred dogs. As a result, many breeders are now beginning to create new “pure breeds” through cross breeding (first generation crosses of two purebred dogs).

2) Which of the following statements would the author of the passage most likely support?

- A) Pure breeding over a long period of time can produce dogs that are superior in certain ways but inferior in others.
- B) The origins of pure breeding began back in the 1800s.
- C) Modern purebred dogs are far healthier and have better attributes than their ancestors.
- D) Cross breeding will successfully fix all of the problems associated with purebred dogs.

2) Too Specific

Incorrect answer choices are very commonly too specific. Often, a single word or a short phrase in an answer choice makes the entire answer choice incorrect. **If the answer choice is too specific and goes beyond what the passage says, it is always incorrect.**

As you read each answer choice, look for specific details and strong statements that could make the answer choice incorrect. Remember, the more specific and stronger an answer choice is, the more likely it will be incorrect.

To see how this works, let's consider the following passage about pelicans' fishing habits:

Pelicans fish by using their long beaks and large throat pouches to scoop up prey from the water's surface. Pelicans' diets include fish, amphibians, small turtles, crabs, and even other small birds. Most pelicans use a technique called "dive-bombing," where the birds will tuck their wings and dive directly into the water at unsuspecting fish. However, pelicans have also been known to hunt cooperatively, especially when hunting near the shores. The groups of birds will form a line to drive schools of smaller fish into the shallower waters, beating their wings near the surface, and then scooping up their favorite prey.

Which of the following statements can be inferred from the passage?

- A) Pelicans prey predominantly on fish during the summer months.
- B) Great White Pelicans are the only species of pelicans that hunt for turtles.
- C) Small ocean fish are the main prey for pelicans.
- D) Pelicans do the majority of their hunting in shallow waters near the coast.

Here A, B, and D are incorrect because they are too specific. For A, the passage does say that fish are the predominant prey, but it did not at any point specify anything about summer months. For B, the passage never discussed Great White Pelicans. For D, the passage never details where the pelicans do the majority of their hunting; it just mentioned that pelicans hunt along the shallow waters near the shores. At the end of the passage, "scooping up their favorite prey" refers to smaller fish as the favorite prey; therefore, the small ocean fish are the main prey. **The answer is C.**

Too Specific Practice:

In 2001, Botanist Roy Snaydon saw in the Park Grass Experiment a way to experimentally test the idea that soil chemistry can drive evolutionary divergence in plants. The variation seen among the Park Grass Experiment plots may partly have resulted from the adaptive divergence of members of the same species to the varying conditions on the different plots. To determine if evolutionary divergence occurred in the plots, Snaydon focused on sweet vernal grass, the plant found on the plots throughout the experimental field. He initially selected three plots that had been fertilized with different chemical mixes since the initiation of the experiment in 1856. Because agricultural lime had been applied to the southern half of each plot for half a century, the study involved six subplots varying markedly in mineral content and soil acidity.

1. According to the text, what did Snaydon base his plot selection on for the experiment?
 - A) Type of fertilizer applied to the southern portion of each subplot and how it affected the mineral content of the soil.
 - B) The level of soil acidity in the plots after they were treated with fertilizers to increase the effectiveness of the lime.
 - C) The concentrations of lime in the various subplots together with the variation of the plant species found on each plot.
 - D) The type of chemical mixes used to fertilize the plots together with the application of agricultural lime to half of each plot.

The European Union's Single Market was established in 1993 to facilitate the free movement of goods and services among its 27 member states. Since its formation, there has been a significant increase in agricultural trade across all member states. However, within this period, smaller farms in many of these countries have seen a decline in the export of their goods across member states, while larger agricultural enterprises have flourished. This trend suggests that since 1993 _____.

2. Which choice most logically completes the text?
 - A) the Single Market has been successful in helping all its member states increase their trade across all industries.
 - B) the Single Market has helped increase agricultural trade, but it has not been beneficial for all types of farmers.
 - C) the Single Market has intentionally implemented policies to hurt smaller farmers to help larger agricultural enterprises succeed.
 - D) the increase in agricultural trade across all member states has been an unintended effect of the establishment of the Single Market.

3) Too Narrow

Sometimes, an answer choice is incorrect because it is too narrow. This occurs when the answer choice includes details that are more specific than what the question is asking for, or the answer choice focuses on too narrow of a portion of the passage.

This type of incorrect answer choice most commonly appears on main idea questions. **Too narrow answer choices are often tempting incorrect answer choices because they include details from the passage; however, they are incorrect because they only focus on a small portion of the passage and do not convey the main idea.**

For example, let's consider this excerpt from a passage about Darwin's finches and evolution.

Dr. Anders Robert became fascinated with evolution after reading Charles Darwin's *Theory of Evolution* in graduate school. But he was never fully satisfied with Darwin's explanation of evolution and his survival of the fittest model. Dr. Robert always felt there was another missing piece – a something that he termed “micro-evolution,” evolution on a tiny scale that can occur over much shorter time periods. While Darwin's evolution occurs over many generations due to the pressures of natural selection, Dr. Robert postulates that every 2-3 generations small changes occur to key characteristics of a population and that over time enough of these small changes lead to new sub-species and species forming in a shortened time frame. To test his theory, Dr. Robert will travel to the Galapagos Islands to study changes in the beaks of some of the same species of finches that Darwin studied over one hundred years ago.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) research the theory of evolution using Darwin's finches.
- B) test a new idea about evolution by studying finches' beaks.
- C) highlight Dr. Robert's fascination with evolution.
- D) recreate Darwin's research on the Galapagos Islands.

Here, C is incorrect because it is too narrow. While the first sentence directly states that Dr. Anders Robert is fascinated with evolution, his fascination is not the main idea of the passage.

A is incorrect because it is too broad. For A, does the passage discuss the theory of evolution? Yes, but researching the theory of evolution is not the main idea of the passage, so A does not answer the question.

D is incorrect because it is too specific. The word “recreate” does not match the passage, as there is nothing about Dr. Robert recreating Darwin's research. The main idea of the passage is about Dr. Robert's research to test his new theory, so **B is the correct answer.**

The introduction of Burmese pythons to the Florida Everglades in the 1980s, due to pet releases, has had a devastating effect on local wildlife and the Everglades ecosystem. These large constrictor snakes have no natural predators in the Everglades, allowing their population to grow unchecked. They prey on a wide range of native species, but their most damaging ecological effects have been felt among the mammals of the Everglades: from 1980 to 2012, populations of raccoons have dropped by 99.3%, opossums by 98.9%, and bobcats by 87.5%. To combat the snakes' damaging ecological effects various methods, including snake traps, snake sniffing dogs, and snake hunters, have been employed by governmental and ecological agencies.

1. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Burmese pythons in the Everglades have only had damaging effects to mammals.
- B) The population growth of Burmese pythons in the Florida Everglades has had a significant effect on the Everglades ecosystem.
- C) Although the Burmese pythons have had damaging effects to the environment, officials are confident that new measures will rectify the problem.
- D) The near elimination of raccoons in the Florida Everglades since the introduction of the Burmese Pythons is very concerning to ecological agencies.

Public libraries, as we know them today, have their origins in the 17th century as small, community-focused institutions. They were initially established to provide access to books to the public, particularly those who could not afford private collections. Over time, public libraries have evolved to become centers for community engagement, digital resources, and lifelong learning. 21st century public libraries still provide access to books, but many also conduct programs that educate adults on how to use computer software, teach new crafts like pottery, and even rent out equipment for video and audio production.

2. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) A function of public libraries has been the same since the 17th century, but they have expanded the scope of services they provide.
- B) Public libraries originated due to a cultural practice of the 17th century.
- C) Public libraries still remain small, community-focused institutions.
- D) All public libraries now offer programs and resources beyond access to books.

4) Opposite or Slant of the Passage

Many incorrect answers on the SAT are the opposite or a slant of what the passage states. **These answer choices often look correct because they include exact words or phrases from the passage; however, they are incorrect because the answer choice says the opposite or a slant of what the passage states.**

Remember, you should not pick an answer choice just because you find a word or phrase that is directly in the passage, as these are often incorrect answer choices. Always make sure the answer choice is 100% correct.

Let's look at the passage about ocean currents below as an example:

Ice triggers the movement of ocean currents. As water freezes in the North and South Poles, the water surrounding the ice becomes saltier and colder since the salt leaves the water upon freezing. The newly formed ice then cools the surrounding water. The cold, salty water sinks due to its increased density. Once it gets to the bottom of the ocean floor, the water must move somewhere – so it travels southward to spread across the submerged surface of the earth. This is a cold current. Warm water replaces it on the surface and moves to the north. This motion is known by scientists as the global conveyor belt, a globe-wide current that circulates cold and warm water around the earth. As a result, the warm water that replaces the cold on the surface travels northward, increasing the temperature of the Atlantic Ocean, causing countries in Europe that border the Atlantic Ocean to be relatively warmer than landlocked countries during the wintertime.

Which of the following statements about the global conveyor belt is best supported by the passage?

- A) Cold water sinks at the North and South Poles and is replaced by warm water that moves south.
- B) The ocean currents that make up the global conveyor belt change with the seasons.
- C) Melting ice at the North and South Poles is the first step in the chain reaction that causes the ocean currents.
- D) The ocean currents cause inland countries to be relatively colder than coastal countries in Europe during wintertime.

In this example, A is incorrect because the answer choice is opposite of the passage. The end of A says the warm water moves south, but the passage says the warm waters moves north. B is incorrect because it is not in the passage; there is nothing about the currents changing with the seasons. C is incorrect because the answer choice is opposite of the passage. The first two sentences of the passage say that freezing water, not melting water, is the first step in the process that causes the global conveyor belt, which is a term in the passage for the ocean currents.

The correct answer here is D, as it is the only one that is supported by the passage. The final sentence says that coastal countries are warmer than landlocked countries, so we also know the opposite is true – landlocked countries are colder than coastal countries. This is tricky because the correct answer flips what the evidence from passage says. On scientific passages, always be aware of evidence like this, as the SAT may ask you to use this type of thinking for advanced questions.

Opposite or Slant of the Passage Practice:

Sabine Tebbich and Irmgard Teschke have found that information about woodpecker finches' social system can shed some light on the reasons for the strong genetic predetermination of tool use in this species. For one thing, in contrast to socially living primates, woodpecker finches are solitary and thus parents are likely to be the only available tool-using models. In such a system, reliance on social transmission from parents to offspring during an association would be a highly risky endeavor. Where the likelihood of encountering important social information is uncertain, selection for a development process based on genetically fixed components could be advantageous.

1. What does the passage most strongly suggest about the social system of primates?
 - A) It allows for young animals to regularly observe other members of their species using tools.
 - B) It does not provide a tool-using model unlike woodpecker finches' social system.
 - C) It restricts the transmission of tool-related knowledge to close relatives only.
 - D) It is not as important as the social system of woodpecker finches as primates have more genetically fixed components.

The following passage is adapted from James Baldwin's 1960 novel "This Morning, This Evening, So soon." The unnamed narrator is an African American musician who married Harriet.

Harriet comes from orderly and progressive Sweden and has reacted against all the advanced doctrines to which she has been exposed by becoming steadily and beautifully old-fashioned. We never fought in front of Paul, not even when he was a baby. Harriet does not so much believe in protecting children as she does in helping them to build a foundation on which they can build and build again, each time life's high-flying steel ball knocks down everything they have built. Whenever I become upset, Harriet becomes very cheerful and composed. I think she began to learn how to do this over eight years ago, when I returned from my only visit to America. Now, perhaps, it has become something she could not control if she wished to.

2. The passage suggests that during the family's life together, Harriet has undergone what fundamental change?
 - A) Her approach to parenting has shifted as she has become more progressive.
 - B) Her identification with the place of her birth has intensified.
 - C) Her efforts to appear calm when the narrator becomes dismayed has become an unconscious habit.
 - D) Her concern for herself has come to exceed her attention to family matters.

5) Could Be True

Many incorrect answer choices feel like they could be true. **The answer choice logically makes sense based on information in the passage or outside knowledge you know about the topic. However, when we examine “could be true” answer choices carefully, we cannot fully support the answer choice based on the information in the text.** “Could be true” answer choices are often tempting to select, especially on completion passages or questions that you find more difficult to understand. When selecting an answer choice, it is not good enough that it could be true. Instead, make sure that you can fully prove that answer choice based on information in the passage.

Let’s see how this works with the following passage about bicycle usage:

In a transportation study by Dr. Stephanie Marek and her team, urban residents in Copenhagen, Denmark, and Portland, Oregon, were surveyed regarding their bicycle usage. Among the 412 Copenhagen respondents, 75% reported regular bicycle commuting, and out of 890 Portland respondents, only 45% reported the same. Given that Portland has more extensive bike-lane infrastructure than Copenhagen, infrastructure alone cannot be responsible for the difference in cycling habits between the cities.

The text makes which point about the proportion of bicycle usage between Copenhagen and Portland residents?

- A) The difference was less than what was initially hypothesized by the study.
- B) The higher bicycle usage in Copenhagen may be influenced by cultural factors rather than just bike-lane infrastructure.
- C) The results may not be accurate due to the subjective nature of surveys.
- D) The discrepancy is caused by something besides the number of bike lanes.

In this example, B is incorrect because it could be true. While the final sentence of the passage says that something other than bike-lane infrastructure is responsible for the difference in cycling between Copenhagen and Portland, the passage never mentioned cultural factors. Culture factors are a good potential explanation, and it might even be true if you know much about Copenhagen and Portland, but we cannot prove this statement is true from the passage, so it is incorrect.

A is incorrect because it is not in the passage. The passage never mentions a hypothesis. C is also not in the passage. At no point does the passage question the accuracy of the results.

D is supported by the final sentence of the passage, which says that something other than bike-lane infrastructure must be responsible for the different in bicycle usage in Copenhagen and Portland. The passage never specifies what is responsible, so **D is correct**.

Could Be True Practice:

Psychologist Carol Dweck is well known for her research on academic success and self-perception. According to Dweck, individuals with a "growth mindset" believe that their abilities can be developed through hard work and dedication, while those with a "fixed mindset" believe that their abilities are innate and cannot be changed no matter how hard they work. Dweck claims that those with a growth mindset react more positively to failure and will put in extra time and effort, leading to higher achievement. To assess this claim, a team of psychologists surveyed a group of 11th grade students about their reactions to failing a surprise test and then recorded the students' eventual final grade in the class at the end of the semester.

1. Which finding, if true, would most strongly support Dweck's claim?
 - A) Students who reacted to failing the surprise test by surveying classmates to see how their classmates scored ended up with higher scores at the end of the semester.
 - B) Students with a "growth mindset" were less likely to have failed the surprise test than students with a "fixed mindset."
 - C) Students who failed the surprise test with a "fixed mindset" had a lower average final grade at the end of the semester when compared to students with a "growth mindset" who failed the surprise test.
 - D) Students who reacted more negatively to failing the test had a higher average final grade at the end of the semester than the students who reacted more positively to failing the test.

Text 1

Many drugs tested as cancer treatments fail not because they are ineffective at killing cancers cell but because they also cause extensive damage to healthy tissues, leading to side effects that outweigh the drug's benefits. Recently, researchers modified the administration protocol of a once-promising chemotherapy DRS-078 that had been abandoned due to damage it causes in epithelial cells in humans. The modification incorporated a novel mRNA treatment that enabled DRS-078 to be triggered by enzymes only found in tumors, eliminating the damage to epithelial cells.

Text 2

Dr. Stephanie Purcell, who led a study on the administration of DRS-078 and the novel mRNA treatment together on mice, said that the drug is as good at eliminating tumors as the treatment of DRS-078 alone. In addition to directly killing tumor cells, the addition of the mRNA treatment had an unexpected benefit in clinical trials: it boosted the ability of a type of immune cell to kill cancer cells, helping to prevent tumors from coming back. "To have a drug that not only kills cancer cells but also activates immune cells is unique," Dr. Purcell commented.

2. Based on the texts, the researchers in Text 1 and Dr. Purcell in Text 2 would most likely agree with which statement?
 - A) The use of DRS-078 with the novel mRNA treatment is ready to be administered to human patients.
 - B) For a cancer treatment to be successful, it must not only kill cancer cells but also not cause significant harm to healthy cells.
 - C) The administration of DRS-078 and the novel mRNA treatment is an incredibly important discovery to improve the treatment of cancer in human patients.
 - D) The combination of DRS-078 and the novel mRNA treatment resulted in a better treatment than just administering DRS-078.

6) In the Passage But Not Answering the Question

This final type of incorrect answer choice is often the most difficult to avoid. These are answer choices that are directly stated in the passage but do not answer the question being asked. You will be able to go to the passage, find the information, and match it with the answer choice. However, it will still be incorrect!

This is a good spot to reiterate two important tips we have learned already:

1. **Do not select an answer choice because it has a word or phrase that matches the passage. Make sure the answer choice is 100% correct.** The SAT can include exact words or phrases from the passage in incorrect answer choices to try to trick you.
2. **Finding evidence for an answer choice in the passage does not mean you found the correct answer. You still need to make sure you are answering the question the SAT is asking.**

We will see some examples of these questions as we work through more practice questions in the rest of this course.

Chapter 6: How To Effectively Approach Each Question

So far, we have focused on learning the core principles for Reading Comprehension and the differences between correct and incorrect answer choices. Before we move onto learning specific strategies for each type of Reading Comprehension question, let's learn how to effectively approach Reading Comprehension questions on test day and share some tips on how to use the answer choices.

How To Approach Reading Comprehension Questions

For each Reading Comprehension question, we recommend using the following approach.

1. **Read the question.** That's right, read the question FIRST! Do not read the passage before reading the question.
2. **Identify the question type.** We will learn how to do this in the rest of this course. The SAT makes it very clear what the question type is, so this step is easy.
3. **Read the entire passage.** As you read the passage, you should have an idea of what you are looking for based on what the question is asking.
4. **Reread the question, if necessary (optional).** If after reading the passage, you are not 100% clear on what the question is asking you to find reread the question.
5. **Read the answer choices.** ALWAYS read all 4 answer choices.
6. **Eliminate incorrect answer choices (if you can).** Only eliminate answer choices that you are sure are incorrect.
7. **Go back to the passage.** For most questions, you will likely not be 100% confident which answer choice is correct after reading all 4 answer choices. Now that you know the answer choices, go back to the passage to find the evidence that supports the correct answer. If you feel 100% confident that you know which answer choice is correct right away, you can skip this step and select that answer choice without going back to the passage.
8. **Select the correct answer.** At this point, you should hopefully be confident in your answer choice. If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

For most Reading Comprehension questions, students prefer to use the order above. However, **you should not follow this order exactly for every single question.** While we have numbered the steps above, you will not always use this exact order. For some question types, we may add steps or adjust the order. We will teach you those adjustments in the rest of this course.

In the rest of this course, we will introduce different approaches for each question type. Remember, **there is no best way to approach Reading Comprehension Questions, but there is a best way for you.** As you complete practice questions, try different approaches and find what works best for you!

Our Recommended Approach – Work Both Forwards and Backwards

Now that we know how to approach each Reading Comprehension question, let's discuss how to best approach the answer choices. We recommend working forwards (look for evidence in the passage) and backwards (eliminate incorrect answer choices) at the same time.

Work Forwards – Look for the Evidence in the Passage

Working forwards is looking for the evidence in the passage that matches the correct answer choice. **When working forwards, find the evidence in the passage and match it to the correct answer choice.** In an ideal world, you could work forwards all the time, but finding the evidence in the passage that supports the correct answer for every single question is difficult. We do not want to only look for the correct answer choice.

Work Backwards – Eliminate Incorrect Answer Choices

Working backwards is eliminating incorrect answer choices. **Anytime you see an answer choice that is incorrect for any reason, mark it as incorrect.** Look for the 6 types of incorrect answer choices that we learned in Chapter 5 as you read each answer choice.

On the Reading Comprehension questions, **it is often easier to eliminate three answer choices as incorrect than it is to find the evidence that supports the correct answer**, especially for the most difficult questions. Even if you cannot find evidence in the passage, if you can eliminate 3 answer choices as incorrect, you have found the correct answer.

How to Work Forwards and Backwards

As you read each answer choice, you should be simultaneously working forward and backwards. Ask yourself the following questions:

- 1) **Is there evidence in the passage that matches what this answer choice says?**
- 2) **Is there any specific detail or strong statement in this answer choice that could make it incorrect?**

The first question is working forwards. You will need to go back to the passage to answer this question properly. If there is no evidence from the passage to support the answer choice, it is incorrect; cross it off.

The second question is working backwards. As you read each answer choice, look for any word(s) that could make the answer choice incorrect. Be cautious about specific details or strong statements in the answer choices. In general, **stronger and more specific answer choices are usually incorrect** because they cannot be supported by the passage. Oppositely, **more boring answer choices are more commonly correct**. The problem is that we like to pick specific answer choices when we are struggling on a question because it is easier to justify why the specific answer choice could be correct. Boring answer choices are, well, just boring. Nobody wants to pick the boring answer choices. The writers of the SAT know this and take advantage of it to make questions more difficult.

***TIP – If you are stuck between two answer choices and cannot find any evidence to support either one, always pick the less detailed answer choice.**

Boring is usually better on the SAT Reading Test!

Chapter 7: Specific Detail

Specific detail questions ask you to locate a specific detail in the passage and identify the answer choice that matches. For specific detail questions, **there is always evidence in the passage that support the correct answer choice**. These questions can range from easy to very difficult depending on how obvious, or not obvious, the evidence is and how challenging the passage is to understand.

There are 2 types of specific detail questions: (1) clear evidence questions and (2) inference questions. Let's start by learning the difference between these 2 types of questions and how to spot them on test day.

Clear Evidence Questions

For clear evidence questions, **the correct answer is almost always a restatement or rephrasing of evidence directly stated in the passage**. In other words, the correct answer is usually clearly in the passage and the evidence from the text should be strong.

Clear evidence questions will almost always have at least one of the following keywords in the question:

- **Indicates**
- **According to the text**
- **Based on the text**
- **As presented in the text**

Clear evidence questions look like this:

1. **According to the text**, what is the best methodology for increasing plant growth?
 - A) increase the availability of nitrogen-based nutrients to the rooms.
 - B) optimize the pH and moisture level of the soil.
 - C) provide artificial light with more UVA rays than UVB rays.
 - D) prevent root entanglement by removing nearby plants.
2. What does the text **indicate** about the Mrs. Olivia?
 - A) She is unable to spend as much time with Dylan as she likes.
 - B) She is not offended by what Mr. Plank wrote about her.
 - C) She avoids sharing her emotions in public.
 - D) She prefers living near the beach to living in the mountains.

Whenever we spot a clear evidence question, we know that we are looking for clear evidence in the passage. **Do not make any inferences when answering the question!** This is one of the most common mistakes that students make.

Clear evidence questions usually are easier because the evidence more directly matches the correct answer. However, clear evidence questions can still be quite challenging when the evidence is well hidden in the passage, so make sure to still guess and move on to the next question if you get stuck and cannot find the evidence.

To see how clear evidence questions work, let's consider the example below:

University of Queensland archeologist Chris Clarkson had long wanted to reexcavate Madjedbebe to resolve the controversy around the peopling of Australia. With Aborigine permission, Clarkson's team reexcavated the site in 2012 and 2015 with painstaking stratigraphic controls. They found hundreds of thousands of new artifacts, including elaborate technologies such as the world's oldest ground-edge stone axes, grindstones for pulverizing seeds, and finely made stone points that may have served as spear tips. The earliest people at the site also used "huge quantities of ochre" and are the first humans shown to have used reflective mica to decorate themselves or rock walls.

1. According to the text, what does the discovery of mica at Madjedbebe indicate about the first people who lived at the site?
 - A) They used tools chiefly to extract this resource.
 - B) They used this material for artistic creations.
 - C) They traded this substance only amongst themselves.
 - D) They used it to make points that may have served as spear tips.

Since this is a clear evidence question, we must find direct evidence in the passage that matches one of the answer choices. The question asks about the discovery of mica, and the only place we see mica in the passage is in the final sentence, where it says "the first humans shown to have used reflective mica to decorate themselves or rock walls." There is no other information in the passage about mica, so the correct answer is B. All other answer choices are not in the passage.

Inference Questions

For inference questions, **the correct answer is most commonly not directly stated in the passage. Instead, the correct answer is demonstrated in the passage. There must still be some evidence from the passage to support the correct answer, but the evidence is not going to directly match the answer choice.**

Inference questions always have at least one of the following keywords in the question:

- **Inferred**
- **Implies**
- **Suggests**
- **Most likely**
- **Most reasonably**
- **Most strongly**
- **Best supports**

As an example, consider the following passage and questions:

His mother, standing across the room, smiled warmly at Elijah. His grandfather, a man known for his short temper and intimidating appearance, knelt and reached out his hand.

1. What does the passage **most strongly suggest** about Elijah's mother?
 - A) She wishes to support Elijah's interaction with his grandfather.

Notice that passage never directly states that Elijah's mother supports the interaction with the grandfather, but the "smiling warmly" at this interaction demonstrates her support. This is the type of evidence we can see for inference questions.

Now, let's look at a second example:

Surprisingly to the researchers, large hawks and eagles were found to be more territorial when the average weekly temperature is above 80 °F.

1. Based on the text, which statement about large hawks and eagles is **most likely** correct?
 - A) They are not as aggressive when the average weekly temperature is 70 °F or less.

The passage never directly states that large hawks and eagles are not as aggressive when the temperature is 70 °F or less, but we can assume that since the passage states that large hawks and eagles are more territorial when the temperature is above 80 °F, the birds will be less territorial (or aggressive) when the temperature is lower. This is an example the type of thinking that we may need to apply on a more challenging inference question.

Inference questions are generally more difficult because you must select an answer choice that is demonstrated but not directly stated in the passage. Remember that **there still needs to be evidence from the passage to support the correct answer.**

To better understand inference questions, let's start with an easier/medium difficulty example:

Carnivorous plants hold a place of special fascination in elementary science classrooms and botany labs alike. Many of these plants have an obviously predatory look about them, such as Venus flytraps. But pitcher plants, as successful as they are at capturing insects for their nutrients, don't make a lot of sense at first glance. A new study aims to make sense of the fact the plants' traps aren't always slippery along the edges, even though a slippery edge would, in theory, catch more insects not sure of their footing.

1. What does the text most strongly suggest about pitcher plants?
 - A) They are unusual in that they lack a trait that would seem to improve their ability to capture insects.
 - B) They prey primarily on crawling insects rather than on flying ones.
 - C) They have no apparent mechanism to prevent insects from escaping their traps.
 - D) They look more predatory than Venus flytraps.

Since this is an inference example, we do not expect to see direct evidence in the passage. Here, the entire passage is about pitcher plants, so we want to assess each answer choice individually. For A, the final sentence of the passage closely matches what A says; the passage says the study aims to make sense of the fact that the plants' traps are not slippery, which would be helpful in capturing insects, and answer choice A says the essentially same thing. Answer choice A also states that the plants are unusual. This is the inference we must make in this question, as the passage does not directly state they are unusual. There is evidence to them being unusual, as the passage earlier says "many of these plants have obviously predatory looks about them" and then contrasts this with the non-predatory pitcher plants, but the fact that pitcher plants are unusual is not directly stated.

Answer choice B is incorrect because the passage never mentions crawling or flying insects. Answer choice C is incorrect because the passage never discussed if pitcher plants have a mechanism to prevent insects from escaping. Answer choice D is the opposite of the passage, as the passage points to Venus flytraps as an example of a plant that has an obviously predatory look and contrasts that with the pitcher plants, meaning the pitcher plants look less predatory than the Venus flytrap.

Inference questions on test day can often be quite difficult. Let's now consider a harder example:

Conventional microfluidics devices employ tiny pumps to control fluid flows on the microscale, for example in microchips designed to carry out sensitive chemical or biological analyses. To reduce energy usage, researchers have been developing new passive pumps that work like a plant sucking water from soil, and now a team has demonstrated a highly efficient version of such a pump that uses a branched structure analogous to the veins of a leaf. The approach may find use in cooling electronic devices or in exerting precise control over the delivery of medical drugs.

2. What does the text most strongly suggest about the pumps used in conventional microfluidics?
- A) Those pumps must be cooled by additional technology.
 - B) Those pumps work best if the fluids distributed are under high pressure.
 - C) Those pumps sometimes distribute fluids unevenly.
 - D) Those pumps draw power from an external source.

The first hard part about this example is that the question asks about conventional microfluidics, which is mentioned in the first sentence, while the majority of the passage focuses on the new passive pumps. We have to recognize that the new passive pumps are not conventional microfluidics. Further, we have to recognize that the passage sets up a contrast between the tiny pumps in conventional microfluidics and new passive pumps, so the characteristics of the new passive pumps are the opposite of the characteristics of the tiny pumps in conventional microfluidics. We call this **inverse evidence**, and it can appear on difficult inference questions.

Once we understand this, we can assess each answer choice. For answer choice A, the passage mentions "cooling electronic devices" as a potential usage for the new passive pumps, but the passage never mentions anything about either the conventional pumps or new passive pumps requiring or not requiring cooling, so A is incorrect. For answer choice B, high pressure is never mentioned in the passage, so B is incorrect. For answer choice C, the passage never discusses fluids being distributed unevenly or evenly, so C is incorrect.

For answer choice D, the passage says that passive pumps reduce energy usage and described the pumps as "passive" and "efficient," all of which point to the fact that passive pumps use less or no energy. Using the inverse evidence, we can conclude that conventional pumps must be using more energy less efficiently, so the pumps in conventional microfluidics must be getting energy from an external source. We must infer that the energy is coming from an external source, but this inference is a pretty easy one to make because the passage never states the pumps provide their own energy, so the energy must be coming from an external source. D is the correct answer.

Breaking Down Specific Detail Questions

A key skill to success on Specific Detail questions is effectively breaking down each question to identify exactly what the SAT is asking you. Many students believe that they are doing are already doing this, but most are not doing it effectively enough, especially for more complex questions.

Let me give you an example to better explain what we mean. Imagine that you are working on a Reading Comprehension question. You read the question, read the passage, and look for the evidence. All of the sudden, I reach across the table, cover the question, and ask you, “what exactly are you looking for?” **If you cannot tell me EXACTLY what you are looking for, you are not doing a good enough job breaking down the question.** And if you are not doing a good enough job breaking down the question, you do not know exactly what the SAT is asking, which of course makes it much more difficult to consistently find the correct answer.

The skills we are about to learn are critical for Specific Detail questions, but they also apply to many other question types. **The better you get at breaking down questions, the easier the Reading Comprehension Questions become.** In addition, **you will improve your time management skills and answer more questions correctly.**

Skill #1 – Identify the Type of Question

When you read a question, you first need to identify the type of question. This step should be easy, as we will teach you how to spot all 8 question types as we complete this course.

You should memorize all the key words and approaches we just learned to make identifying clear evidence and inference question types easy. Knowing what type of question you are looking at is critical to knowing how to approach the question and the type of evidence to look for in the passage.

Practice: For each question below, identify if the question is a clear evidence question or an inference question.

1. What does the text indicate about Austin’s reaction when Mr. Amar rejected his cabinet design?
2. What does the text most strongly support about blues music?
3. According to the text, when did women’s voting rights as we now understand them first gain widespread acceptance?
4. How would the author classify the new reusable bottle design, as presented in the text?

Skill #2 – Identify the Keywords

As you read each specific detail question, identify the important keyword(s) in the question. These are the most important words or phrases that you must find in the passage to answer the question. Identifying the keywords will help you know what specific detail(s) to look for in the passage.

1. Based on the text, what about the state of her garden makes Aubrey feel despair?
2. What does the text most strongly suggest about why Elliot chose to include butterflies instead of moths in his experiment?

In the first example above, we need to find why her garden makes Aubrey feel sad. At times, the SAT includes vocabulary words in the question, as we did in this example. This is another reason why knowing your vocabulary words from part 1 of this course is important! We should also recognize that this is a clear evidence question since the question starts with “based on the text.” If we can find the part of the passage discusses why her garden makes Aubrey feel sad, we should be able to clearly match the evidence to the correct answer.

In the second example, we are looking for why Elliot chose butterflies and not moths for his experiment. We see the question says “most strongly suggest,” so this is an inference question; the answer will not be as clearly stated in the passage. To find the evidence, we need to look for where the passage discusses “butterflies” and “moths” and then find why Elliot chose to include butterflies and not moths.

Skill #3 – Rephrase the Question in Your Own Words (If Necessary)

For most questions on the SAT, the keyword(s) are enough to know exactly what you are looking for. Of course, there is no need to rephrase the question for these questions. For example, let’s say a question asks:

1. According to the text, what is true about Jane?
 - A) Jane is a poor role model for her daughter.
 - B) Jane lets her temper get in the way of her relationship with her daughter.
 - C) Jane often disagrees with her husband about household finances.
 - D) Jane can be indecisive about how to discipline her daughter.

For this question, the question itself makes it very clear what you are looking for in the passage – information about Jane. **For shorter/simpler questions like the example above, there is no need to rephrase the question in your own words.**

When to Rephrase the Question In Your Own Words

For longer and more complicated questions, it can be important to rephrase the questions in your own words. **If you can rephrase the question in your own words, you know exactly what you are looking for when you go back to the passage.** To see how this can be helpful, let’s consider the example below:

1. Based on the text, how do the luciferin molecules involved in Lawson and colleagues’ study cause bioluminescence?
 - A) Luciferin molecules transfer chemical energy into photons.
 - B) Luciferin molecules increase the intensity of a bioluminescent burst.
 - C) Luciferin molecules prevent the completion of a chemical reaction.
 - D) Luciferin molecules react with photoproteins to create light.

Rephrase: How do the luciferin molecules cause bioluminescence?

In a longer question like this, we can break down the question to identify the most important keywords, which are “luciferin” and “bioluminescence.” To find the answer, we should go back to the passage and look for where the passage discusses “luciferin” and “bioluminescence” and particularly look for how the molecules cause bioluminescence. Lawson and colleagues is most likely not a useful keyword, as the entire passage for a question like this is probably about the study.

Now, let’s look at a second example question:

1. Why do Austin’s teammates believe that he could most likely succeed as the team captain for the rest of the abbreviated season?
 - A) He understands each teammates’ individual strengths.
 - B) He allows his teammates to showcase their talents during games.
 - C) He played professionally for five years.
 - D) He is familiar with a variety of strategies and set plays.

Rephrase: Why do Austin’s teammates think he can succeed as team captain?

With a long question like this, rephrasing the question makes it easier to know exactly what you are looking. You need to find why Austin’s teammates think he can succeed as the team captain. Keeping this in the front of your mind as you read the passage makes it much easier to find the evidence and the correct answer.

Tips For When to Rephrase the Question in Your Own Words

1. **If you read a question and are unclear exactly what the question is asking, rephrase the question in your own words before going back to the passage.**
2. **For long questions with many keywords, rephrase the question.** This will help you frame what you are looking for and prioritize what keyword(s) are the most important to find in the passage.
3. **Generally speaking, the longer the questions is, the more likely you should rephrase the question in your own words.**
4. **Find what works for you!** There is no set of rules for when to rephrase the question vs. when to use the keywords. Practice and find what works for you.

Breaking Down Specific Detail Questions Practice: For each question below, (1) identify if the question is a clear evidence question or inference question, (2) identify the most important keywords, and (3) rephrase the question if necessary.

- | | |
|--|---|
| 1. Based on the text, how would the author describe the residents of Orange County in the 1950s? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |
| 2. What does Aliana’s team infer about the walnut oil used in Da Vinci’s paintings? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |
| 3. According to the text, why does Sarah feel slighted during the graduation ceremony? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |
| 4. How does Ahora make a distinction between the Māori and Samoan nations, according to the text? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |
| 5. Based on the text, why did Sarah return to Kansas? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |
| 6. What does the text most strongly suggest about the farmers’ views of the Populist movement of the 1890s? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |
| 7. Based on the text, what is the most likely reason that Rylee has the wrong guitar onstage during her “Summertime Blues” performance? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |
| 8. Based on the text, what does Miller indicate is a consequence of the distortion of images in a lower magnification mirror? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |
| 9. What is the most likely reason that an artic fox can locate lemmings underneath a snowpack during a windstorm? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |
| 10. Which of the following behaviors does the author provide as the most reasonable evidence that a dolphin strategizes with other dolphins while hunting? | <p>Question Type: Clear Evidence / Inference</p> <p>Keyword(s):</p> <p>Rephrase the Question:</p> |

Specific Detail Practice:

1. Oluwaseyi Moejoh cofounded U-recycle Initiative Africa when she was only a teenager. Moejoh and her team founded the organization to teach young people how their actions affect the environment and why recycling is important. For example, the organization put on an exhibit of art made using recycled materials.

According to the text, what is one reason Moejoh and others founded U-recycle Initiative Africa?

- A) To bring attention to overlooked African artists
 - B) To teach young people why recycling is important
 - C) To help adults gain important outdoor skills
 - D) To give teenagers advice about starting businesses
2. To make her art more widely available, graphic artist Elizabeth Catlett turned to linocuts. In linocut printing, an artist carves an image into a sheet of linoleum to create a stamp that is used to mass-produce prints. In the linocut series *The Black Woman* (1946–1947), Catlett depicts the everyday experiences of Black women alongside the achievements of well-known Black women. This pairing invites the viewer to draw connections among the women. The linocut process enabled Catlett’s work to reach a wide audience and supported her aim to unite Black women through her art.

According to the text, what is significant about Catlett’s use of linocut printing?

- A) Linocut printing involved using materials that were readily available to Catlett.
 - B) Linocut printing helped Catlett use art to connect people, especially Black women.
 - C) Catlett became commercially successful once she started using linocut printing.
 - D) Catlett was one of the first Black artists to use linocut printing.
3. The following text is from Shyam Selvadurai’s 1994 novel *Funny Boy*. The seven-year-old narrator lives with his family in Sri Lanka. Radha Aunty is the narrator’s aunt.

Radha Aunty, who was the youngest in my father’s family, had left for America four years ago when I was three, and I could not remember what she looked like. I went into the corridor to look at the family photographs that were hung there. But all the pictures were old ones, taken when Radha Aunty was a baby or young girl. Try as I might, I couldn’t get an idea of what she looked like now. My imagination, however, was quick to fill in this void.

According to the text, why does the narrator consult some family photographs?

- A) He wants to use the photographs as inspiration for a story he is writing.
- B) He is curious about how his father dressed a long time ago.
- C) He hopes the photographs will help him recall what his aunt looked like.
- D) He wants to remind his aunt of an event that is shown in an old photograph

4. The ice melted on a Norwegian mountain during a particularly warm summer in 2019, revealing a 1,700-year-old sandal to a mountaineer looking for artifacts. The sandal would normally have degraded quickly, but it was instead well preserved for centuries by the surrounding ice. According to archaeologist Espen Finstad and his team, the sandal, like those worn by imperial Romans, wouldn't have offered any protection from the cold in the mountains, so some kind of insulation, like fabric or animal skin, would have needed to be worn on the feet with the sandal.

What does the text indicate about the discovery of the sandal?

- A) Temperatures contributed to both protecting and revealing the sandal.
 - B) The discovery revealed that the Roman Empire had more influence on Norway than archaeologists previously assumed.
 - C) Archaeologists would have found the sandal eventually without help from the general public.
 - D) The sandal would have degraded if it hadn't been removed from the ice.
5. The following text is adapted from Robert Louis Stevenson's 1883 novel *Treasure Island*. Bill is a sailor staying at the Admiral Benbow, an inn run by the narrator's parents.

Every day when [Bill] came back from his stroll he would ask if any seafaring men had gone by along the road. At first we thought it was the want of company of his own kind that made him ask this question, but at last we began to see he was desirous to avoid them. When a seaman did [stay] at the Admiral Benbow (as now and then some did) he would look in at him through the curtained door before he entered the parlour; and he was always sure to be as silent as a mouse when any such was present.

According to the text, why does Bill regularly ask about "seafaring men"?

- A) He's hoping to find an old friend and fellow sailor.
 - B) He's trying to secure a job as part of the crew on a new ship.
 - C) He isn't sure that other guests at the inn will be welcoming of sailors.
 - D) He doesn't want to encounter any other sailor unexpectedly.
6. A common assumption among art historians is that the invention of photography in the mid-nineteenth century displaced the painted portrait in the public consciousness. The diminishing popularity of the portrait miniature, which coincided with the rise of photography, seems to support this claim. However, photography's impact on the portrait miniature may be overstated. Although records from art exhibitions in the Netherlands from 1820 to 1892 show a decrease in the number of both full-sized and miniature portraits submitted, this trend was established before the invention of photography.

Based on the text, what can be concluded about the diminishing popularity of the portrait miniature in the nineteenth century?

- A) Factors other than the rise of photography may be more directly responsible for the portrait miniature's decline.
- B) Although portrait miniatures became less common than photographs, they were widely regarded as having more artistic merit.
- C) The popularity of the portrait miniature likely persisted for longer than art historians have assumed.
- D) As demand for portrait miniatures decreased, portrait artists likely shifted their creative focus to photography.

7. Paleontologists searching for signs of ancient life have found many fossilized specimens of prehistoric human ancestors, including several from the Pleistocene era discovered in a geological formation in the Minatogawa quarry in Japan. However, to study the emergence of the earliest multicellular organisms to appear on Earth, researchers must turn elsewhere, such as to the Ediacaran geological formation at Mistaken Point in Canada. A UNESCO World Heritage Site, the 146-hectare reserve contains more than 10,000 fossils that together document a critical moment in evolutionary history.

What does the text indicate about the geological formation at Mistaken Point?

- A) It holds a greater number of fossils but from a smaller variety of species than the formation in the Minatogawa quarry does.
 - B) It has provided evidence that the earliest human species may have emerged before the Pleistocene era.
 - C) It is widely considered by paleontologists to be the most valuable source of information about prehistoric life forms.
 - D) It contains specimens from an older time period than those found in the formation in the Minatogawa quarry.
8. The following text is adapted from Countee Cullen’s 1926 poem “Thoughts in a Zoo.”

They in their cruel traps, and we in ours,
 Survey each other’s rage, and pass the hours
 Commiserating each the other’s woe,
 To mitigate his own pain’s fiery glow.
 Man could but little proffer in exchange
 Save that his cages have a larger range.
 That lion with his lordly, untamed heart
 Has in some man his human counterpart,
 Some lofty soul in dreams and visions wrapped,
 But in the stifling flesh securely trapped.

Based on the text, what challenge do humans sometimes experience?

- A) They cannot effectively tame certain wild animals because of a lack of compassion.
- B) They cannot focus on setting attainable goals because of a lack of motivation.
- C) They quickly become frustrated when faced with difficult tasks because of a lack of self-control.
- D) They have aspirations that cannot be fulfilled because of certain limitations.

9. In superfluorescence, electrical charges known as dipoles emit light in synchronized bursts so intense that they are visible to the eye. Until recently, this phenomenon has only been observed at extremely cold temperatures because dipoles cannot synchronize at higher temperatures. But in a study, Melike Biliroglu and colleagues observed superfluorescence at room temperature in thin films made of perovskite and other similarly crystalline materials; the researchers propose that the formation of shock-absorbing quasiparticles called polarons in the material protects dipoles from thermal interference.

Based on the text, how are polarons believed to be involved in the superfluorescence observed in Biliroglu and colleagues' study?

- A) Polarons enable superfluorescent bursts to cross from one crystalline material to another.
 - B) Polarons allow for the dipoles to synchronize despite higher temperatures.
 - C) Polarons accelerate the dipoles' release of superfluorescent bursts.
 - D) Polarons decrease the intensity of the superfluorescent burst.
10. Paleontologist Lucas E. Fiorelli and colleagues have reported the discovery at a mine in Brazil of several egg clutches, partially preserved single eggs, and egg shells from the Late Cretaceous period. The researchers have concluded that the area was once a nesting and breeding site for titanosaurs, a group of sauropod dinosaurs. The finding is significant given the previous lack of known nesting sites in northern regions of South America, which led many paleontologists to assume that titanosaurs migrated south to lay eggs.

What does the text most strongly suggest about the site discovered by the researchers?

- A) It is the earliest known example of a titanosaur nesting and breeding site.
- B) It was very difficult to excavate given that it was discovered in a mine.
- C) It may have been occupied by other sauropods in addition to titanosaurs.
- D) It is farther north than any other nesting site discovered in South America.

Chapter 8: Main Idea

Main Idea questions ask you to determine the main idea of the passage. As we answer main idea questions, **we need to consider the passage as a whole and not focus on a specific detail in the passage. We can think of the main idea of the passage as the main takeaway.** For these questions, **we will see evidence that supports the main idea in multiple places or throughout the passage.**

Main idea questions are already easy to spot because the question always looks like this:

1. Which choice best states the **main idea** of the text?

In the rest of this chapter, we will learn how to approach Main Idea questions, share a few strategies for success on these questions, and list a few common mistakes to avoid.

How To Approach Main Idea Questions

For Main Idea questions, we recommend making a few adjustments to the approach that we learned in chapter 6. We have outlined our recommended approach below:

1. **Read the question and recognize that it is a Main Idea question.** Since Main Idea questions always includes the words “main idea,” this step is easy.
2. **Read the entire passage.** If the passage includes a description above the passage, make sure to read that as well. As you read the passage, try to identify the main idea.
3. **Come up with your own main idea.** After reading the passage, state the main idea (your main takeaway) in your own words. You can simply write down a few words that summarize the main idea of the passage. You do not need to write a full sentence. If the passage was confusing and you struggle to write your own main idea, proceed to the next step.
4. **Read the answer choices.** ALWAYS read all 4 answer choices.
5. **Eliminate incorrect answer choices.** Only eliminate answer choices that you are sure are incorrect. If you are unsure, leave the answer choice.
6. **If you are confident that you know the answer, select the correct answer and move on.** If one of the answer choices matches your own main idea, you probably have the correct answer.
7. **If you are not sure which answer choice is correct, find the key difference between the remaining answer choices.** Most commonly, students are stuck between 2 answer choices at this point. If you can find the key difference between the answer choices, it will be easier to determine which one is correct.
8. **Reread the passage.** Now that you know the answer choices, it can be easier to recognize which answer choices do or do not match the main idea of the passage.
9. **Select the correct answer.** At this point, you should hopefully be confident in your answer choice. If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

This method is designed to put you in control. Coming up with your own main idea for the passage ensures that you are using your reading comprehension skills. If you skip this step and go straight to the answer choices, you can easily get lost in the answer choices and select an answer choice that may seem correct in the moment but does not actually reflect the main idea of the passage.

Let's try this modified approach with the following passage:

Bats, known for their echolocation abilities, navigate and hunt in the dark in part by emitting ultrasonic sounds. Bats are thought by many to rely solely on echolocation for spatial awareness. Many scientists once held the same beliefs. However, a study by Dr. Emma Teeling and her team explored the possibility that bats use visual cues in conjunction with echolocation. They observed bats' reactions to various illuminated sensors that were recessed into the walls of the enclosed room the bats were placed into. The bats demonstrated the ability to distinguish and react to these visual stimuli, indicating that their spatial navigation also incorporates visual elements, not just echolocation.

Write your main idea: _____

1. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Scientists have long known that bats can use echolocation for navigation and hunting.
- B) Bats have been shown to be able to hunt only by using visual elements.
- C) Contrary to what many believe, bats do not solely rely upon echolocation for navigation.
- D) Bats use of echolocation when hunting is their most important ability for a successful hunt.

The main takeaway from this passage is that bats do not only use echolocation for spatial awareness. This idea is introduced in the fourth sentence and is expanded on in the rest of the passage. The experiment supported this idea by showing that bats responded to the illuminated sensors in the walls. And the final sentence summarizes the main takeaway that bats rely on more than echolocation for spatial navigation. The correct answer is C.

Answer choice A is too narrow. The first sentence support this, but the passage as a whole is not about how scientists have long known bats using echolocation for navigation and hunting. Answer choice B is opposite/slant of the passage. The passage says that bats can use visual stimuli, but it never says bats hunt only using visual stimuli. Answer choice D is incorrect because it is too specific. At no point does the passage say that echolocation is the most important part of a successful hunt. Additionally, D does not reflect the main idea of the passage, as the passage is not about what ability is most important for bats when hunting.

4 Keys For Success on Main Idea Questions

Now, let's break down 4 keys to success on Main Idea questions. As you answer any Main Idea question, you will complete all of the following steps:

1. **Identifying The Topic.** What is the passage about? The topic is most commonly introduced in the first 1-2 sentences and is discussed throughout the rest of the passage.
2. **Identify The Relationship.** The first 1-2 sentences set the stage for the passage, often introducing the topics and providing background information for context. As the passage continues, you need to identify the relationship. The common relationships are listed below:
 - **Continuation** – the passage continues the discussion of the topic introduced in the first 1-2 sentences.
 - **Further Support** – the passage supports a position, fact, or argument introduced in the first 1-2 sentences. This is common for science and history passages.
 - **Contrast** – the passage provides information that contrasts the position, fact, or argument introduced in the first 1-2 sentences. This is a common relationship for science passages.

3. Recognize The Structure. As you read the passage, you should recognize the structure of the passage. Knowing the 3 most common structures below will help you better identify the main idea. With practice, you will build this skill.

- **Introduction, Then Key Takeaway.** This is the most common structure for main idea questions. The first 1-2 sentences introduce the topic and provide information for context. In the rest of the passage, the author shares new information about the topic. For questions with this structure, **the main idea is usually in the final 1-2 sentences.**
- **Continuous Narrative.** Some passages on SAT are a continuous discussion of one topic. For continuous narrative passages, **the main idea is a summary of the main takeaway from the passage.** The main idea is the argument/point that is built throughout the passage.
 - For fiction and poetry passages with a continuous narrative, ask yourself, **“What happened?”**
 - For all other types of passages with a continuous narrative, ask yourself, **“What is the main point the author is making?”**
- **Out With the Old, In With the New (Science Passages, History Passages).** Many science and history passages begin with a description of how something used to be. Scientists formerly believed ____ or historians initially believe that _____. The passage then introduce something new (a new study, a new discovery, etc.) and shares how this new information has changed the understanding.

For passages with this structure, ask yourself, **“What changed?” The main idea is the answer choice that describes what changed based on the new information.**

While these 3 structures are the most common, **not all Main Idea question follow one of these 3 structures.** If you see a different structure on test day, use the skills we have learned to work through the question and find the correct answer.

4. Find The Main Takeaway. What is the most important thing in the passage? After you identify the topic, identify the relationship, and recognize the structure, you are ready to find the main takeaway. **The main takeaway can be a position, an argument, or a topic discussed through the passage.** No matter what, the main takeaway always communicates something about the topic.

With practice, these steps will start to become automatic. Let’s apply these steps with 2 more practice questions.

Originally worn only by Asante royalty, tunics made from Kente cloth, recognizable for its bright colors and bold patterns, originated in the 17th century in Ghana. Each Kente cloth, woven by hand, has a meaning, which is conveyed through its colors, patterns, and symbols. Over time, it became acceptable for more and more people to wear Kente cloth. Now, it is worn by almost everyone in Ghana but only for special occasions and celebrations.

1. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?
 - A) Kente cloth is now more commonly worn in Ghana than it was in the past.
 - B) Certain Kente cloths are worn for celebrations while others are worn for mourning.
 - C) Kente cloth has remained a popular part of Ghanaian culture because it was worn by the Asante.
 - D) The Asante royalty are the first people recorded to wear Kente cloth.

NASA's Cassini spacecraft's observations have revealed a region of higher temperature near the south pole of Enceladus, Saturn's ice-covered moon. NASA scientists suggest that this heat anomaly could be caused by hydrothermal activity on the ocean floor beneath the ice. The complex chemistry required for hydrothermal activity makes Enceladus a key target for NASA in the search for extraterrestrial life. The team recommends closer examination of these warm regions to understand the moon's potential habitability of extraterrestrial life.

2. Which choice best states the main idea of the text?
- A) The NASA team has definitively found life on Enceladus due to the detected heat anomaly.
 - B) The spacecraft's data indicating a possibility of hydrothermal activity on Enceladus merits future research about the habitability of life there.
 - C) Enceladus's south pole is universally known to be the warmest part of the moon.
 - D) Heat anomalies have been used in the past to correctly identify planets that hold extraterrestrial life.

How To Use The Answer Choices

So far, we have focused on how to identify the main takeaway as you read the passage. While it is important to be able to identify the main takeaway of the passage, it is equally important to know how to use the answer choices on Main Idea questions.

1. **Work Backwards First.** As you read each answer choice, eliminate any answer choices that you know are incorrect. Incorrect answer choices for Main Idea questions often include details that are not in the passage, are too specific, or are too narrow. If you can eliminate 2 or 3 answer choices right away, finding the correct answer choice becomes much easier.
2. **Let The Answer Choices Help.** If you are reading a passage that you find difficult to understand or are having trouble coming up with your own main idea, let the answer choices help! As you read the answer choices, you will see 4 options for what the main idea of the passage could be. After reading the answer choices, reread the passage. Once you know that the main idea could be, it will likely be easier for you to understand the passage.
3. **Identify the Key Difference When Stuck Between 2 Answer Choices.** Students commonly are stuck between 2 answer choices, especially on hard questions. When you are stuck between 2 answer choices, read both answer choices carefully and identify the key difference. Once you know the key difference, it will be easier to reread the passage and identify which answer choice is correct and why the incorrect answer choice is wrong.

As you work through the rest of this chapter and course, always look to use the answer choices to your advantage.

3 Common Mistakes To Avoid on Main Idea Questions

To finish up this chapter, let's go over 3 common mistakes that we see students make on Main Idea questions. Knowing these common mistakes can help you avoid them on test day.

1. **Rereading The Passage Over and Over.** You should NOT keep reading the passage over and over again if you cannot identify the main idea. On your first read of the passage, you are reading to get the basics. Find out what the passage is about. On your second read, you are reading for understanding.

After 2 reads of the passage, if you still do not understand the passage or cannot identify the main idea, read the answer choices. Do not keep rereading the passage. Let the answer choices help you out. After you have read the answer choices, you can reread the passage again.

2. **Selecting Too Narrow Answer Choices.** Main idea questions often include 1 too narrow answer choice. This answer choice is tempting because it includes information that is directly stated in the passage. However, the too narrow answer choice is incorrect because it does not express the main idea of the passage.

Always be on the lookout for too narrow answer choices on Main Idea questions. Make sure the answer choice you select reflects the main takeaway from the passage and is not just a detail from a small part of the passage.

3. **Word Matching.** Incorrect answer choices on Main Idea questions often include words or phrases directly from the passage. For harder questions, students often fall for answer choices that have exact words and phrases from the passage. As always, make sure that the entire answer choice is correct! **If you are struggling on a question, do your best to assess the entire answer choice and do NOT just pick an answer choice because it has words that match the words in the passage.**

Main Idea Practice:

1. The following text is from Edith Nesbit's 1902 novel *Five Children and It*.

Five young siblings have just moved with their parents from London to a house in the countryside that they call the White House. It was not really a pretty house at all; it was quite ordinary, and mother thought it was rather inconvenient, and was quite annoyed at there being no shelves, to speak of, and hardly a cupboard in the place. Father used to say that the ironwork on the roof and coping was like an architect's nightmare. But the house was deep in the country, with no other house in sight, and the children had been in London for two years, without so much as once going to the seaside even for a day by an excursion train, and so the White House seemed to them a sort of Fairy Palace set down in an Earthly Paradise.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Although their parents believe the house has several drawbacks, the children are enchanted by it.
 - B) The children don't like the house nearly as much as their parents do.
 - C) Each member of the family admires a different characteristic of the house.
 - D) The house is beautiful and well built, but the children miss their old home in London.
2. Psychologists wanted to test how young children think about rewards and fairness. In an experiment, two teachers handed out rewards while children (ages four to six) watched. The teachers gave out the same number of rewards, but one of them counted the rewards out loud. The children were then asked who was fairer. 73% chose the teacher who counted. The psychologists think that counting showed the children that the teacher wanted to be fair. The children may have believed that the teacher who did not count did not care about fairness.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Psychologists think children cannot understand the concept of fairness until they are six years old.
 - B) An experiment found that counting out loud is the best way to teach mathematical concepts to children.
 - C) Psychologists think young children expect to be rewarded when the children show that they care about fairness.
 - D) An experiment showed that the way rewards are given out may affect whether young children think the situation is fair.
3. Microplastics are pieces of plastic that are smaller than a grain of rice. These small plastics can be found in large quantities in ocean waters. Ecologist Jessica Reichert and her team are studying the role reef-building corals have in capturing microplastics from ocean waters. Through research, her team has found that these corals may be storing up to 20 million kilograms of microplastics each year in their skeletons and tissues.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Ecologists are interested in learning more about how certain corals build large reefs.
- B) Questions remain around the impact certain corals have on ocean ecosystems.
- C) Microplastics are small pieces of plastic that can be found in ocean waters.
- D) Ecologists predict that corals store large amounts of microplastics from ocean waters.

4. The recovery of a 1,000-year-old Chinese shipwreck in the Java Sea near present-day Indonesia has yielded a treasure trove of artifacts, including thousands of small ceramic bowls. Using a portable X-ray fluorescence analyzer tool, Lisa Niziolek and her team were able to detect the chemical composition of these bowls without damaging them. By comparing the chemical signatures of the bowls with those of the materials still at old Chinese kiln sites, Niziolek and her team can pinpoint which Chinese kilns likely produced the ceramic bowls.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Because of a new technology, researchers can locate and recover more shipwrecks than they could in the past.
 - B) Researchers have been able to identify the location of a number of Chinese kilns in operation 1,000 years ago.
 - C) With the help of a special tool, researchers have determined the likely origin of bowls recovered from a shipwreck.
 - D) Before the invention of portable X-ray fluorescence, researchers needed to take a small piece out of an artifact to analyze its components.
5. The following text is adapted from Christina Rossetti's 1881 poem "Monna Innominata 2."

I wish I could remember that first day,
 First hour, first moment of your meeting me,
 If bright or dim the season, it might be
 Summer or Winter for [all] I can say;
 So unrecorded did it slip away,
 So blind was I to see and to foresee,
 So dull to mark the budding of my tree
 That would not blossom yet for many a May.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) The speaker celebrates how the passage of time has strengthened a relationship that once seemed unimportant.
- B) Because the speaker did not anticipate how important a relationship would become, she cannot recall how the relationship began, which she regrets.
- C) As the anniversary of the beginning of an important relationship approaches, the speaker feels conflicted about how best to commemorate it.
- D) After years of neglecting a once valuable relationship, the speaker worries it may be too late for her to salvage the relationship.

6. The following text is adapted from Guy de Maupassant's nineteenth-century short story "The Trip of Le Horla" (translated by Albert M. C. McMaster, A. E. Henderson, Mme. Quesada, et al.). The narrator is part of a group traveling in a hot-air balloon at night.

The earth no longer seems to exist, it is buried in milky vapors that resemble a sea. We are now alone in space with the moon, which looks like another balloon travelling opposite us; and our balloon, which shines in the air, appears like another, larger moon, a world wandering in the sky amid the stars, through infinity. We no longer speak, think nor live; we float along through space in delicious inertia. The air which is bearing us up has made of us all beings which resemble itself, silent, joyous, irresponsible beings, peculiarly alert, although motionless.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) The narrator feels a growing sense of isolation even though his companions are nearby during the balloon ride.
 - B) The narrator and his companions are completely absorbed in the change in perspective they gain while riding in the balloon.
 - C) The narrator and his companions are troubled by the disorienting effects of the altitude while riding in the balloon.
 - D) The narrator is pleasantly surprised by his companions' unrestrained enthusiasm about the sensation of riding in the balloon.
7. Several scholars have argued that conditions in England in the late ninth through early eleventh centuries—namely, burgeoning literacy amid running conflicts between England's Anglo-Saxon kingdoms and Danish invaders—were especially conducive to the production of the Old English epic poem Beowulf, and they have dated the poem's composition accordingly. It is not inconceivable that Beowulf emerged from such a context, but privileging contextual fit over the linguistic evidence of an eighth- or even seventh-century composition requires a level of justification that thus far has not been presented.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Although there are some grounds for believing that Beowulf was composed between the late ninth and early eleventh centuries, advocates for that view tend to rely on evidence that has been called into question by advocates for an earlier date.
- B) Although several scholars have dated Beowulf to the late ninth through early eleventh centuries, others have argued that doing so privileges a controversial interpretation of the social conditions of the period.
- C) Although Beowulf fits well with the historical context of England in the late ninth through early eleventh centuries, it fits equally well with the historical context of England in the seventh and eighth centuries.
- D) Although the claim of a late ninth- through early eleventh-century composition date for Beowulf has some plausibility, advocates for the claim have not compellingly addressed evidence suggesting an earlier date.

8. For centuries, the widespread acknowledgment of the involvement of the cerebellum—a dense brain structure in vertebrates—in coordinating motor control in humans has hindered recognition of other possible functions of the structure. Neuroscience research from the last two decades now suggests that the cerebellum regulates emotion and social behavior, and recent research by Ilaria Carta and colleagues has identified a pathway connecting the cerebellum to a center for motivation and reward processing known as the ventral tegmental area (VTA).

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) The recent verification of a pathway between the VTA and the cerebellum confirms the cerebellum's long-suspected role in motor coordination.
 - B) Recent advances in the field of neuroscience have challenged widely accepted claims about the function of a pathway connecting the VTA and the cerebellum.
 - C) The cerebellum has primarily been thought to regulate motor functioning, but in recent years neuroscience researchers have been uncovering additional functions.
 - D) Technological limitations have historically hindered the study of the cerebellum, but the recent development of new technologies has led to greater insights into its functions.
9. Modern dog breeds are largely the result of 160 years of owners crossbreeding certain dogs in order to select for particular physical appearances. Owners often say that some breeds are also more likely than others to have particular personality traits—basset hounds are affectionate; boxers are easy to train—but Kathleen Morrill and colleagues found through a combination of owner surveys and DNA sequencing of 2,000 dogs that while physical traits are predictably heritable among purebred dogs, behavior varies widely among dogs of the same breed.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Dog breeds would not exist without many years of human intervention in dogs' reproduction.
 - B) Research fails to confirm a commonly held belief about dog breeds and behavior.
 - C) The dog breeds most popular among owners have often changed over the past 160 years.
 - D) A study of dog breeds is notable for its usage of both opinion surveys and DNA sequencing.
10. Having written the impassioned call to arms "Letter to the Spanish Americans" in 1791, Peruvian intellectual Juan Pablo Viscardo y Guzmán is often considered a forerunner for the independence movements in Latin America. But Viscardo's role in history would have remained insignificant were it not for Venezuelan revolutionary Francisco de Miranda, who was handed the unpublished letter after Viscardo's death. Miranda not only helped circulate the letter, but his edits and footnotes to the text position Miranda as a central figure in the text's creation.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) The original authorship of "Letter to the Spanish Americans" is disputed by contemporary historians.
- B) The majority of the most eloquently stated arguments in "Letter to the Spanish Americans" were written by Miranda.
- C) Miranda played a crucial role in influencing the content and distribution of "Letter to the Spanish Americans."
- D) "Letter to the Spanish Americans" persuaded many people in Latin America to pursue national independence.

Chapter 9: Purpose

Purpose questions ask you to determine the main purpose of the passage. As we answer Purpose questions, **we need to consider the passage as a whole and not focus on a specific detail in the passage. The purpose of the passage is the main goal the author is achieving in the passage.**

Purpose questions are already easy to spot because the question always looks like this:

1. Which choice best states the **main purpose** of the text?

As you consider the purpose of a passage, ask yourself the following questions:

- **Why did the author write this passage?**
- **What goal is the author trying to achieve in this passage?**

The answer to these questions is the purpose of the passage! In the rest of this chapter, we will learn how to approach Purpose questions, share a few key principles and tips for success on these questions, and list a few common mistakes to avoid.

Main Purpose vs. Main Idea

Many students think that Purpose questions and Main Idea questions are essentially the same – they are not!

Main Purpose ≠ Main Idea

Main idea questions ask you to identify the main takeaway of the passage. So, **Main Idea questions are “What” questions** that ask you what happened in the passage. On the other hand, Main Purpose questions ask you to identify the main goal the author is achieving in the passage. **Main Purpose questions are “Why” questions** that ask you why the author wrote the passage.

To learn the difference, let’s revisit a passage that we saw in chapter 8.

Bats, known for their echolocation abilities, navigate and hunt in the dark in part by emitting ultrasonic sounds. Bats are thought by many to rely solely on echolocation for spatial awareness. Many scientists once held the same beliefs. However, a study by Dr. Emma Teeling and her team explored the possibility that bats use visual cues in conjunction with echolocation. They observed bats' reactions to various illuminated sensors that were recessed into the walls of the enclosed room the bats were placed into. The bats demonstrated the ability to distinguish and react to these visual stimuli, indicating that their spatial navigation also incorporates visual elements, not just echolocation.

Main Idea: Bats do not only use echolocation for spatial awareness.

Main Purpose: To summarize a study that disproves a previous assumption about how bats navigate.

Notice the difference between the main idea and main purpose. This difference is why we need to approach main idea and main purpose questions differently.

Now that you understand the basics, let's revisit another passage to try to find the difference between the main idea and the purpose.

NASA's Cassini spacecraft's observations have revealed a region of higher temperature near the south pole of Enceladus, Saturn's ice-covered moon. NASA scientists suggest that this heat anomaly could be caused by hydrothermal activity on the ocean floor beneath the ice. The complex chemistry required for hydrothermal activity makes Enceladus a key target for NASA in the search for extraterrestrial life. The team recommends closer examination of these warm regions to understand the moon's potential habitability of extraterrestrial life.

Main Idea: _____

Main Purpose: _____

How To Approach Purpose Questions

For Purpose questions, we recommend making a few adjustments to the approach that we learned in chapter 6. We have outlined our recommended approach below:

1. **Read the question and recognize that it is a Main Purpose question.** Since main idea questions always includes the words "main purpose," this step is easy.
2. **Read the entire passage.** If the passage includes a description above the passage, make sure to read that as well. As you read the passage, **you do NOT need to come up with your own purpose.** If you have a purpose in mind after reading the passage, that is great, but it is not necessary before moving onto step 3.
3. **Read the answer choices.** ALWAYS read all 4 answer choices.
4. **Eliminate incorrect answer choices.** Answer choices on purpose questions are often clearly wrong. Look for details in answer choices that are not in the passage and eliminate any answer choices that include these details. Only eliminate answer choices that you are 100% sure are incorrect.
5. **If you are confident that you know the answer, go back to the passage to verify your answer choice is correct.** Do not select your final answer without going back to the passage.
6. **If you are unsure which answer choice is correct, reread the passage and assess the remaining answer choices 1 at a time.** As you reread the passage, it will be easier to verify if an answer choice is correct or identify why it is incorrect. If an answer choice is incorrect for any reason, eliminate it.
7. **If you are stuck between 2 answer choices, find the key difference.** On harder purpose questions, two answer choices can seem very similar. If you can find the key difference between the answer choices, it will be easier to determine which one is correct.
8. **Select the correct answer.** At this point, you should hopefully be confident in your answer choice. If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

For purpose questions, you should use the answer choices more actively, as working backwards and eliminating incorrect answer choices is a very effective technique on purpose questions.

3 Key Principles for Purpose Questions

For success on Purpose questions, it is important to understand the following 3 key principles:

1. **The main purpose is a twist on the main idea.** To answer Purpose questions correctly, you need to understand the main idea, but the correct answer will not match the main idea. Remember, the purpose explains WHY the author wrote the passage not WHAT the passage is about.
2. **The correct answer is often not explicitly supported in the text.** There still must be evidence in the text to support the correct answer, but it will not be directly matching information in the passage. Correct answer choices are commonly more general or abstract than the passage.
3. **Incorrect answer choices are often clearly incorrect.** Since purpose questions are more abstract, the SAT must make incorrect answer choices clearly wrong. Be picky and look for anything wrong with answer choices to eliminate. Also, look for too narrow answer choices that only match a portion of the passage.

Let's apply this approach and the 3 principles we just learned on the following question:

Contemporary artist Adrian Hall was always interested in interactive art. Initially, Hall's works were constructed with mirrors and lights to let the viewer become the central focus of the installation. However, his fascination with viewer engagement and technology led him to explore generative light floors and walls. Hall's installations involve motion sensors and digital screens that react to the presence and movement of viewers, creating an ever-changing visual experience. This innovative approach bridges art and technology, offering a multisensory, dynamic experience for the viewer. Although Hall has also worked with canvas, mobiles, and metal, his interactive pieces remain his most popular works.

1. Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?
 - A) To explain why Adrian Hall is best known for his interactive art installations.
 - B) To describe the progression of Adrian Hall's interactive art installations.
 - C) To explain why the use of generative light floors made Adrian Hall's interactive art more popular.
 - D) To discuss why canvas, mobiles, and metal artworks were less popular than Adrian Hall's interactive pieces.

This passage shares the progression of Adrian Hall's interactive artwork exhibits, starting with his interest, then sharing his start with mirrors and lights, and finally discussing his integration of motion sensors and digital screens into his exhibit. The purpose of the passage is to describe Hall's development of his interactive art exhibits, so the answer is B. Notice how there is no direct evidence in the passage that says this, but we can recognize this is correct based on the passage as a whole.

Answer choice A is incorrect because even though it is in the passage, the passage as a whole does not focus on Hall being best known for interactive art. Answer choice C is incorrect because the passage's focus is not entirely on generative light floors – and the passage never says the floors made his art popular. Answer choice D is incorrect because the passage never discusses why his other artworks were less popular.

4 Tips for Success on Purpose Questions

Now, let's break down 4 tips for success on Purpose questions. These tips will help you consistently answer Purpose questions correctly on test day.

1. **Identify the Main Takeaway.** As you read the passage, identify the main takeaway (the main idea). If you know the main takeaway of the passage, assess the answer choices and identifying the purpose becomes much easier.

2. **Support Your Answer Choice.** Even though the correct answer for purpose questions is most commonly not directly stated in the passage, there still must be evidence from the passage that supports the correct answer choice. **ALWAYS go back to the passage to make sure the passage supports your answer choice.**
3. **Work Backwards and Be Picky!** For most students, working backwards and eliminating answer choices is the best way to find the correct answer. As you read each answer choice, look for details in each answer choice that are incorrect and eliminate answer choices.
4. **Consider the Passage as a Whole.** For most questions (and especially harder questions), the purpose is not summarized in one sentence. Instead, the purpose comes from understanding the progression of the passage as a whole. Therefore, you cannot put your finger on the evidence and point to one place in the passage for the purpose.

Let's practice applying these tips on 2 more practice questions:

In the early 1960s, computer scientist Paul Baran developed a novel telecommunication system that he called 'distributed packet switching' that could maintain communication after a nuclear attack. His telecommunication system, which used inexpensive, unreliable nodes at the center of the network and expensive, reliable nodes at the endpoints, was the opposite of the established systems. Baran's distributed packet switching found little support from telecommunication companies until the work of British computer scientist Donald Davies was published in 1965. Once Davies and Baran's ideas were combined, they created ARPANET, a system for computers to be shared remotely. ARPANET quickly turned into something unforeseen: a high speed, electronic post office for exchanging technical and personal information. The moniker ARPANET was later changed to the Internet, which forever changed how people communicate and business is done across the world.

1. Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?
 - A) To highlight the impact of the inventions of Paul Baran.
 - B) To contrast the works of two computer scientists.
 - C) To describe how the work of two scientists led to a technological innovation.
 - D) To attribute the origin of internet to telecommunications companies' inventions.

The following text is from Paul Laurence Dunbar's 1893 poem "Retort."

"Thou art a fool," said my head to my heart,
 "Indeed, the greatest of fools thou art,
 To be led astray by the trick of a tress,
 By a smiling face or a ribbon smart;"
 And my heart was in sore distress.

Then Phyllis came by, and her face was fair,
 The light gleamed soft on her raven hair;
 And her lips were blooming a rosy red.
 Then my heart spoke out with a right bold air:
 "Thou art worse than a fool, O head!"

2. Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?
 - A) To describe the effects of Phyllis's beauty.
 - B) To underline the fallibility of human emotions.
 - C) To convey the narrator's ambivalence.
 - D) To praise the head for its rational approach.

How To Use The Answer Choices on Purpose Questions

For purpose question, you should use the answer choices A LOT! For many students, describing the purpose on their own can be a challenge, so it is critical to know how to use the answer choices.

1. **Work Backwards As Much As Possible!** This is the most important tip for purpose questions. As you read each answer choice, eliminate any answer choices that you know are incorrect. Incorrect answer choices for Purpose questions are often clearly incorrect. Common types of incorrect answer choices are not in the passage, too specific, too narrow, and in the passage but not answering the question.
2. **Let The Answer Choices Help.** If you are reading a passage that you find difficult to understand, let the answer choices help! The answer choices will give you 4 options for what the purpose of the passage could be. After reading the answer choices, reread the passage. Once you know what the purpose could be, it will likely be easier for you to understand the passage and eliminate incorrect answer choices.
3. **Identify the Key Difference When Stuck Between 2 Answer Choices.** Students commonly are stuck between 2 answer choices, especially on hard questions. When you are stuck between 2 answer choices, read both answer choices carefully and identify the key difference. Once you know the key difference, it will be easier to reread the passage and identify which answer choice is correct and why the incorrect answer choice is wrong.

3 Common Mistakes To Avoid on Purpose Questions

To finish up this chapter, let's go over 3 common mistakes that we see students make on Purpose questions. Knowing these common mistakes can help you avoid them on test day.

1. **Rereading The Passage Over and Over.** Do NOT keep reading the passage over and over again to try and come up with your own purpose. Let the answer choices help you out. After you have read the answer choices, you can reread the passage again.
2. **Selecting Too Narrow Answer Choices.** Many incorrect answer choices on Purpose questions are too narrow. Too narrow answer choices are tempting because they do match evidence in part of the passage. However, too narrow are incorrect because they match a small portion of the passage and do not summarize the purpose of the passage.

Remember, **finding evidence in the passage to support an answer choice is not enough on purpose questions. The correct answer must summarize the purpose of the passage as a whole.**

3. **Word Matching.** Incorrect answer choices on Purpose questions often include words or phrases directly from the passage. For harder questions, students often fall for answer choices that have exact words and phrases from the passage. **If you are struggling on a question, do your best to assess the entire answer choice and do NOT just pick an answer choice because it has words that match the words in the passage.**

Purpose Practice:

1. In many agricultural environments, the banks of streams are kept forested to protect water quality, but it's been unclear what effects these forests may have on stream biodiversity. To investigate the issue, biologist Xingli Giam and colleagues studied an Indonesian oil palm plantation, comparing the species richness of forested streams with that of nonforested streams. Giam and colleagues found that species richness was significantly higher in forested streams, a finding the researchers attribute to the role leaf litter plays in sheltering fish from predators and providing food resources.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A) It discusses research intended to settle a debate about how agricultural yields can be increased without negative effects on water quality.
 - B) It explains the differences between stream-protection strategies used in oil palm plantations and stream-protection strategies used in other kinds of agricultural environments.
 - C) It describes findings that challenge a previously held view about how fish that inhabit streams in agricultural environments attempt to avoid predators.
 - D) It presents a study that addresses an unresolved question about the presence of forests along streams in agricultural environments.
2. Composer Florence Price won first place for her score *Symphony in E Minor* at the 1932 Wanamaker Foundation Awards. The piece was performed the following year by the Chicago Symphony Orchestra, a significant recognition of its quality. Price continued to compose many musical pieces throughout her career, blending traditional Black spirituals with classical European Romantic musical traditions. In recent years, Price's concertos and symphonies have been performed and recorded by several major orchestras, further preserving her work for others to enjoy.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A) To provide examples of Price's importance as a composer
 - B) To argue that more major orchestras should perform Price's compositions
 - C) To describe the musical styles that inspired many of Price's symphonies
 - D) To compare Price's scores with those of classical European composers
3. Early in the Great Migration of 1910–1970, which involved the mass migration of Black people from the southern to the northern United States, political activist and Chicago *Defender* writer Fannie Barrier Williams was instrumental in helping other Black women establish themselves in the North. Many women hoped for better employment opportunities in the North because, in the South, they faced much competition for domestic employment and men tended to get agricultural work. To aid with this transition, Barrier Williams helped secure job placement in the North for many women before they even began their journey.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A) To introduce and illustrate Barrier Williams's integral role in supporting other Black women as their circumstances changed during part of the Great Migration
- B) To establish that Barrier Williams used her professional connections to arrange employment for other Black women, including jobs with the *Chicago Defender*
- C) To demonstrate that the factors that motivated the start of the Great Migration were different for Black women than they were for Black men
- D) To provide an overview of the employment challenges faced by Black women in the agricultural and domestic spheres in the southern United States

4. By combining Indigenous and classical music, Cree composer and cellist Cris Derksen creates works that reflect the diverse cultural landscape of Canada. For her album *Orchestral Powwow*, Derksen composed new songs in the style of traditional powwow music that were accompanied by classical arrangements played by an orchestra. But where an orchestra would normally follow the directions of a conductor, the musicians on *Orchestral Powwow* are led by the beat of a powwow drum.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that Derksen should be recognized for creating a new style of music
 - B) To describe the difficulties Derksen encountered when producing her album
 - C) To establish a contrast between Derksen’s classical training and her Cree heritage
 - D) To examine how Derksen’s musical compositions blend cultures
5. In 1973, poet Miguel Algarín started inviting other writers who, like him, were Nuyorican—a term for New Yorkers of Puerto Rican heritage—to gather in his apartment to present their work. The gatherings were so well attended that Algarín soon had to rent space in a cafe to accommodate them. Thus, the Nuyorican Poets Cafe was born. Moving to a permanent location in 1981, the Nuyorican Poets Cafe expanded its original scope beyond the written word, hosting art exhibitions and musical performances as well. Half a century since its inception, it continues to foster emerging Nuyorican talent.

Which choice best describes the overall purpose of the text?

- A) To explain what motivated Algarín to found the Nuyorican Poets Cafe
 - B) To situate the Nuyorican Poets Cafe within the cultural life of New York as a whole
 - C) To discuss why the Nuyorican Poets Cafe expanded its scope to include art and music
 - D) To provide an overview of the founding and mission of the Nuyorican Poets Café
6. The following text is from Lucy Maud Montgomery’s 1908 novel *Anne of Green Gables*. Anne, an eleven-year-old girl, has come to live on a farm with a woman named Marilla in Nova Scotia, Canada.

Anne reveled in the world of color about her.

“Oh, Marilla,” she exclaimed one Saturday morning, coming dancing in with her arms full of gorgeous boughs, “I’m so glad I live in a world where there are Octobers. It would be terrible if we just skipped from September to November, wouldn’t it? Look at these maple branches. Don’t they give you a thrill—several thrills? I’m going to decorate my room with them.”

“Messy things,” said Marilla, whose aesthetic sense was not noticeably developed. “You clutter up your room entirely too much with out-of-doors stuff, Anne. Bedrooms were made to sleep in.”

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A) To demonstrate that Anne has a newly developed appreciation of nature
- B) To describe an argument that Anne and Marilla often have
- C) To emphasize Marilla’s disapproval of how Anne has decorated her room
- D) To show that Anne and Marilla have very different personalities

7. The field of study called affective neuroscience seeks instinctive, physiological causes for feelings such as pleasure or displeasure. Because these sensations are linked to a chemical component (for example, the release of the neurotransmitter dopamine in the brain when one receives or expects a reward), they can be said to have a partly physiological basis. These processes have been described in mammals, but Jingnan Huang and his colleagues have recently observed that some behaviors of honeybees (such as foraging) are also motivated by a dopamine-based signaling process.

What choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) It describes an experimental method of measuring the strength of physiological responses in humans.
 - B) It illustrates processes by which certain insects can express how they are feeling.
 - C) It summarizes a finding suggesting that some mechanisms in the brains of certain insects resemble mechanisms in mammalian brains.
 - D) It presents research showing that certain insects and mammals behave similarly when there is a possibility of a reward for their actions.
8. Studying late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century artifacts from an agricultural and domestic site in Texas, archaeologist Ayana O. Flewellen found that Black women employed as farm workers utilized hook-and-eye closures to fasten their clothes at the waist, giving themselves a silhouette similar to the one that was popular in contemporary fashion and typically achieved through more restrictive garments such as corsets. Flewellen argues that this sartorial practice shows that these women balanced hegemonic ideals of femininity with the requirements of their physically demanding occupation.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A) To describe an unexpected discovery that altered a researcher's view of how rapidly fashions among Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas changed during the period
- B) To discuss research that investigated the ways in which Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas used fashion practices to resist traditional gender ideals
- C) To evaluate a scholarly work that offers explanations for the impact of urban fashion ideals on Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas
- D) To summarize the findings of a study that explored factors influencing a fashion practice among Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas

9. The following text is adapted from Herman Melville's 1857 novel *The Confidence-Man*. Humphry Davy was a prominent British chemist and inventor.

Years ago, a grave American savant, being in London, observed at an evening party there, a certain coxcombical fellow, as he thought, an absurd ribbon in his lapel, and full of smart [banter], whisking about to the admiration of as many as were disposed to admire. Great was the savant's disdain; but, chancing ere long to find himself in a corner with the jackanapes, got into conversation with him, when he was somewhat ill-prepared for the good sense of the jackanapes, but was altogether thrown aback, upon subsequently being [informed that he was] no less a personage than Sir Humphry Davy.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A) It portrays the thoughts of a character who is embarrassed about his own behavior.
 - B) It presents an account of a misunderstanding.
 - C) It offers a short history of how a person came to be famous.
 - D) It explains why one character dislikes another.
10. Some studies have suggested that posture can influence cognition, but we should not overstate this phenomenon. A case in point: In a 2014 study, Megan O'Brien and Alaa Ahmed had subjects stand or sit while making risky simulated economic decisions. Standing is more physically unstable and cognitively demanding than sitting; accordingly, O'Brien and Ahmed hypothesized that standing subjects would display more risk aversion during the decision-making tasks than sitting subjects did, since they would want to avoid further feelings of discomfort and complicated risk evaluations. But O'Brien and Ahmed actually found no difference in the groups' performance.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A) It argues that research findings about the effects of posture on cognition are often misunderstood, as in the case of O'Brien and Ahmed's study.
- B) It presents the study by O'Brien and Ahmed to critique the methods and results reported in previous studies of the effects of posture on cognition.
- C) It explains a significant problem in the emerging understanding of posture's effects on cognition and how O'Brien and Ahmed tried to solve that problem.
- D) It discusses the study by O'Brien and Ahmed to illustrate why caution is needed when making claims about the effects of posture on cognition.

Chapter 10: Function

Function questions ask you to find the function of an underlined portion of the passage. As we answer Function questions, we need to consider the role of the underlined sentence within the passage.

Function questions are already easy to spot because the question always looks like this:

1. Which choice best describes the **function** of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

As you consider the function of the underlined sentence, ask yourself the following questions:

- **What is the purpose of the sentence in the passage?**
- **Why did the author need to include this sentence?**

Function questions are somewhat similar to purpose questions. The main difference is that now we are asked to identify the function of a single sentence instead of the purpose of the entire passage. Compared to purpose question, function questions are generally easier for most students.

In the rest of this chapter, we will learn how to approach Function questions, the 9 common types of functions, and 2 tips for success on these questions.

How To Approach Function Questions

For Function questions, we have outlined our recommended approach below:

1. **Read the question and recognize that it is a Function question.** Since Function questions always include the words “function,” this step is easy.
2. **Read the entire passage.** On your first read, focus on understanding the passage.
3. **Identify what the underlined sentence is connected to.** The function of the underlined sentence has to do with what other idea in the passage the underlined sentence is connected to.

The underlined sentence must be connected to the idea before, after, or both. For example, if the underlined sentence defines a term introduced in the previous sentence, it is connected to an idea before. Oppositely, if the underlined sentence introduces a study whose results are summarized in the rest of the passage, it is connected to an idea after.

4. **Try to identify the type of function.** We have listed the common types of functions below and will discuss these in more detail later in this chapter.

• Introduction	• Explaining a previous idea	• Example
• Definition	• Connection between ideas	• Summary
• Design of a study	• Findings/results	

If you can identify the type of function before reading the answer choices, it will be much easier to find the correct answer choice.

5. **If you cannot identify the type of function, reread the passage.** If you still cannot identify the type of function, read the answer choices. Do not keep reading the passage over and over again.
6. **Assess the accuracy of each answer choice and eliminate incorrect answer choices.** Incorrect answer choices for Function questions often include details that make them clearly incorrect. Only eliminate answer choices that you are 100% sure are incorrect.

7. **If you are confident, select your answer and move on.** If you are not 100% confident, you can reread the passage to verify your answer choice, but this step is not always necessary.
8. **If you are unsure which answer choice is correct, reread the passage and assess the remaining answer choices 1 at a time.** As you reread the passage, it will be easier to verify if an answer choice is correct or identify why it is incorrect. If an answer choice is incorrect for any reason, eliminate it.
9. **If you are stuck between 2 answer choices, find the key difference.** On harder function questions, two answer choices can seem very similar. If you can find the key difference between the answer choices, it will be easier to determine which one is correct.
10. **Select the correct answer.** At this point, you should hopefully be confident in your answer choice. If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

For functions question, step 4 is the most important. If you can identify the type of function, finding the correct answer becomes much easier.

9 Common Types of Functions

The function of a sentence in a paragraph most commonly falls into 1 of the 9 categories below. While these 9 categories do not include all possible functions of a sentence in a text, they cover the majority of functions that you will see on the SAT.

1. **Introduction.** A sentence, especially the first sentence of the passage, often introduce the topic that will be discussed in the passage.

Location in the text: First sentence of the passage (most commonly) or second sentence (less commonly).

2. **Definition.** A sentence can provide a definition of a term, phrase, or something else discussed in the passage. The definition helps readers understand a concept that would otherwise be unfamiliar to them.

Location in the text: Anywhere in the passage.

3. **Explaining a Previous Idea.** A sentence can provide a further explanation of a previous idea introduced earlier in the passage. These sentences often give more information to help explain a claim made earlier in the passage.

Location in the text: Middle or end of the passage.

4. **Design of a Study:** In passages with a study, a sentence can describe the design of a study. These sentences will outline the setup of the study and will not include any findings.

Location in the text: Middle or end of the passage.

5. **Connection Between Ideas:** A sentence in the middle of the passage can connect the ideas in the previous sentence(s) to the sentence(s) that follow. These sentences help continue the discussion of the passage.

Location in the text: Middle of the passage.

6. **Findings/Results:** In passages with a study, a sentence can share the findings or results of the study. These sentences can share specific findings or outline a broader conclusion found based on the data.

Location in the text: Middle or end of the passage.

7. **Example:** A sentence can provide an example of an idea described in the previous sentence. The previous sentence will state a broader claim, and the example will be more specific and will support the claim.

Location in the text: Middle or end of the passage.

8. **Context.** A sentence can provide information that is necessary to understand other parts of the passage. The information in a context sentence is critical for the reader to comprehend some aspect of the rest of the text.

Location in the text: Anywhere in the passage.

9. **Summary:** A sentence, most commonly the final sentence of a passage, can summarize the main takeaway from the passage.

Location in the text: End of the passage.

Anytime you see a function question, try to determine the general function of the sentence. If you can do that, you will be in a great position to answer functions questions correctly.

Now, let's try to apply the approach that we have learned on 2 practice questions:

A longitudinal study led by psychologist Dr. Jonas Salk investigated the impact of urban green spaces on mental health. From 2014 to 2019, Salk and his team monitored 300 residents living in densely populated urban areas with varying levels of access to parks. Participants, whose neighborhoods were graded based on the proximity and number of parks, were asked to complete quarterly surveys that assessed their mental health status, including levels of anxiety and depression. The study concluded that individuals with greater access to green spaces exhibited lower levels of anxiety and depression.

1. Which choice best states the function of the underlined sentence in the overall structure of the text?
 - A) To present the results of Dr. Salk's study.
 - B) To support the conclusion in the final sentence.
 - C) To describe the methodology used to gather the study's data.
 - D) To dispute a possible criticism of the study.

Bioluminescence, a type of chemiluminescence, is the production and emission of light by a living organism, a phenomenon primarily observed in marine species such as jellyfish, some fish, and plankton. Interestingly, in marine species bioluminescence is used for both defensive and offensive adaptations. Terrestrial species with bioluminescence, however, almost never share similar adaptations. Fireflies, also called lighting bugs, use their bioluminescence to attract mates.

2. What is the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?
 - A) It explains why terrestrial species do not use bioluminescence for the same reasons as marine species.
 - B) It contrasts the mechanisms of bioluminescence between marine and terrestrial organisms.
 - C) It outlines a hypothesis that additional evidence in the following sentence casts doubt on.
 - D) It makes a distinction about the purpose of bioluminescence in marine and terrestrial species.

2 Tips For Success on Function Questions

Finally, let's highlight 2 tips for success on Function questions. If you can apply both of these tips, it will greatly improve your ability to answer Function questions correctly on the SAT.

1. **Find the Connection.** To identify the function of the underlined sentence, we must find what other portion(s) in the passage the underlined sentence is connected to. Understanding this is critical to correctly identifying the function.

The underlined sentence must be connected to the rest of the passage in 1 of the following 3 ways:

- **Connected Before:** A sentence that is supporting, proving, or expanding on information introduced in the previous sentence(s) of the passage is connected before. Common functions for a sentence connected before are a definition, an explanation of a previous idea, a finding/result, an example, and a summary.
- **Connected After:** A sentence that introduces a concept, definition, or other information that is important to understanding the following sentence(s) connects to the ideas after. Common functions for a sentence connected after are an introduction, a definition, and context.
- **Connected Before and After:** A sentence that provides information that continues an ongoing discussion in the passage is connected before and after. Common functions for a sentence connected before and after are design of a study, connection between ideas, and context.

While we outlined the common function for each type of connections, **these are guidelines and NOT strict rules to memorize.** Many of our 9 types of function can be connected before, after, or both, so **you must always use your reading comprehension skills to determine the connection.**

2. **Be REALLY Picky and Work Backwards (as much as possible)!** Incorrect answer choices for Function questions commonly have at least 1 thing in each answer choice that make the answer clearly incorrect. As you read each answer choice look, ask yourself the following questions:

- **Are there any details in this answer choice that do not match the underlined sentence?** If there are details that do not match the underlined sentence, eliminate that answer choice! Incorrect answer choices commonly include details that go beyond what is included in the underlined sentence. For example, if an answer choice says, "it emphasizes the surprising nature of the team's findings," but there is nothing in the underlined sentence that indicates a surprise, that answer choice is incorrect.
- **Does the function in the answer choice match the function you identified?** Sometimes, the function in the answer choice will be clearly wrong. For example, if thought that the sentence provided an explanation of a previous idea, but the answer starts with, "to question..." that answer choice is incorrect.

As you read each answer choice, consider each word carefully and look for what could be wrong first. If you can get really good at identifying why answer choices are incorrect, finding the correct answer become much easier!

Function Practice:

1. In 1801, a Blackfoot chief named Ac Ko Mok Ki drew a finely detailed map of the Upper Missouri region. This work demonstrates a vast amount of topographic knowledge, as the map features specific names of mountains and rivers, as well as the first-known sketch of the drainage network of the Missouri River. The map is especially notable because Ac Ko Mok Ki also included details about the numerous tribes that lived in the area.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- A) It emphasizes Ac Ko Mok Ki's desire to represent other tribes on the map.
 - B) It explains how Ac Ko Mok Ki developed an interest in mapmaking.
 - C) It identifies some reasons why the map is impressive.
 - D) It details how the map was used for hunting and trading purposes.
2. The following text is from Srimati Svarna Kumari Devi's 1894 novel *The Fatal Garland* (translated by A. Christina Albers in 1910). Shakti is walking near a riverbank that she visited frequently during her childhood.

She crossed the woods she knew so well. The trees seemed to extend their branches like welcoming arms. They greeted her as an old friend. Soon she reached the river-side.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It suggests that Shakti feels uncomfortable near the river.
 - B) It indicates that Shakti has lost her sense of direction in the woods.
 - C) It emphasizes Shakti's sense of belonging in the landscape.
 - D) It conveys Shakti's appreciation for her long-term friendships.
3. Researchers have found a nearly 164,000-year-old molar from a member of the archaic human species known as Denisovans in a cave in Laos, suggesting that Denisovans lived in a wider range of environments than indicated by earlier evidence. Before the discovery, Denisovans were thought to have lived only at high altitudes in relatively cold climates in what are now Russia and China, but the discovery of the tooth in Laos suggests that they may have lived at low altitudes in relatively warm climates in Southeast Asia as well.

Which choice best states the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It dismisses as untrue the research presented in the previous sentence.
- B) It defines a term used in the description that follows in the rest of the sentence.
- C) It emphasizes the main goal of the research introduced in the previous sentence.
- D) It provides context that clarifies the significance of the information that follows in the rest of the sentence.

4. The following text is from Herman Melville's 1854 novel *The Lightning-rod Man*.

The stranger still stood in the exact middle of the cottage, where he had first planted himself. His singularity impelled a closer scrutiny. A lean, gloomy figure. Hair dark and lank, mattedly streaked over his brow. His sunken pitfalls of eyes were ringed by indigo halos, and played with an innocuous sort of lightning: the gleam without the bolt. The whole man was dripping. He stood in a puddle on the bare oak floor: his strange walking-stick vertically resting at his side.

Which choice best states the function of the underlined sentence in the overall structure of the text?

- A) It elaborates on the previous sentence's description of the character.
 - B) It introduces the setting that is described in the sentences that follow.
 - C) It establishes a contrast with the description in the previous sentence.
 - D) It sets up the character description presented in the sentences that follow.
5. Part of the Atacama Desert in Peru has surprisingly rich plant life despite receiving almost no rainfall. Moisture from winter fog sustains plants once they're growing, but the soil's tough crust makes it hard for seeds to germinate in the first place. Local birds that dig nests in the ground seem to be of help: they churn the soil, exposing buried seeds to moisture and nutrients. Indeed, in 2016 Cristina Rengifo Faijfer found that mounds of soil dug up by birds were far more fertile and supported more seedlings than soil in undisturbed areas.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It elaborates on the idea that the top layer of Atacama Desert soil forms a tough crust.
 - B) It describes the process by which seeds are deposited into Atacama Desert soil.
 - C) It identifies the reason particular bird species dig nests in Atacama Desert soil.
 - D) It explains how certain birds promote seed germination in Atacama Desert soil.
6. Horizontal gene transfer occurs when an organism of one species acquires genetic material from an organism of another species through nonreproductive means. The genetic material can then be transferred "vertically" in the second species—that is, through reproductive inheritance. Scientist Atma Ivancevic and her team have hypothesized infection by invertebrate parasites as a mechanism of horizontal gene transfer between vertebrate species: while feeding, a parasite could acquire a gene from one host, then relocate to a host from a different vertebrate species and transfer the gene to it in turn.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It explains why parasites are less susceptible to horizontal gene transfer than their hosts are.
- B) It describes a means by which horizontal gene transfer might occur among vertebrates.
- C) It clarifies why some genes are more likely to be transferred horizontally than others are.
- D) It contrasts how horizontal gene transfer occurs among vertebrates with how it occurs among invertebrates.

7. Yawn contagion occurs when one individual yawns in response to another's yawn. Studies of this behavior in primates have focused on populations in captivity, but biologist Elisabetta Palagi and her colleagues have shown that it can occur in wild primate populations as well. In their study, which focused on a wild population of gelada monkeys (*Theropithecus gelada*) in Ethiopia, the researchers further reported that yawn contagion most commonly occurred in males and across different social groups instead of within a single social group.

Which choice best describes the function of the first sentence in the text as a whole?

- A) It defines a phenomenon that is discussed in the text.
 - B) It introduces a problem that is examined in the text.
 - C) It makes a claim that is challenged in the text.
 - D) It presents a hypothesis that is evaluated in the text.
8. The following text is from Joseph Conrad's 1907 novel *The Secret Agent: A Simple Tale*. Mr. Verloc is navigating the London streets on his way to a meeting.

Before reaching Knightsbridge, Mr. Verloc took a turn to the left out of the busy main thoroughfare, uproarious with the traffic of swaying omnibuses and trotting vans, in the almost silent, swift flow of hansoms [horse-drawn carriages]. Under his hat, worn with a slight backward tilt, his hair had been carefully brushed into respectful sleekness; for his business was with an Embassy. And Mr. Verloc, steady like a rock—a soft kind of rock—marched now along a street which could with every propriety be described as private.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined phrase in the text as a whole?

- A) It qualifies an earlier description of Mr. Verloc.
 - B) It emphasizes an internal struggle Mr. Verloc experiences.
 - C) It contrasts Mr. Verloc with his surroundings.
 - D) It reveals a private opinion Mr. Verloc holds.
9. "How lifelike are they?" Many computer animators prioritize this question as they strive to create ever more realistic environments and lighting. Generally, while characters in computer-animated films appear highly exaggerated, environments and lighting are carefully engineered to mimic reality. But some animators, such as Pixar's Sanjay Patel, are focused on a different question. Rather than asking first whether the environments and lighting they're creating are convincingly lifelike, Patel and others are asking whether these elements reflect their films' unique stories.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined question in the text as a whole?

- A) It reflects a primary goal that many computer animators have for certain components of the animations they produce.
- B) It represents a concern of computer animators who are more interested in creating unique backgrounds and lighting effects than realistic ones.
- C) It conveys the uncertainty among many computer animators about how to create realistic animations using current technology.
- D) It illustrates a reaction that audiences typically have to the appearance of characters created by computer animators.

10. According to historian Vicki L. Ruiz, Mexican American women made crucial contributions to the labor movement during World War II. At the time, food processing companies entered into contracts to supply United States armed forces with canned goods. Increased production quotas conferred greater bargaining power on the companies' employees, many of whom were Mexican American women: employees insisted on more favorable benefits, and employers, who were anxious to fulfill the contracts, complied. Thus, labor activism became a platform for Mexican American women to assert their agency.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It offers an example of a trend in the World War II–era economy discussed earlier in the text.
- B) It notes a possible exception to the historical narrative of labor activism sketched earlier in the text.
- C) It elaborates on a claim about labor relations in a particular industry made earlier in the text.
- D) It provides further details about the identities of the workers discussed earlier in the text.

Chapter 11: Claims

Claims questions ask you to select the answer choice that illustrates, supports, or weakens a claim. As we answer Claims questions, we need to identify the claim in the passage and understand how it relates to other portions of the passage.

3 Types of Claims Questions

There are 3 types of Claims questions you will see on the SAT:

1. **Illustrates The Claim:** Illustrates The Claim questions ask you to select the answer choice that most effectively illustrates the claim and are the easiest type of claims question. Illustrates The Claim questions look like this:

“The Gift Outright ” is a poem by Robert Frost. In the poem, Frost tells a story of Europeans exploring a land that they do not fully understand, writing _____

Which quotation from “The Gift Outright” most effectively **illustrates the claim**?

Illustrates The Claim questions always have a blank at the end of the passage and ask you to complete the last sentence.

2. **Support The Claim:** Support The Claim questions ask you to read the passage, identify the claim, and select the answer choice that supports the claim. These questions require more reading comprehension and can be easy, medium, or hard. Support The Claim questions always include the word “support” and look like this:

Which statement, if true, would most directly **support** the researchers’ claim?

Which finding, if true, would most directly **support** Olivia’s hypothesis?

Support The Claim questions do not have a blank at the end of the passage.

3. **Weaken The Claim:** Weaken The Claim questions ask you to read the passage, identify the claim, and select the answer choice that weakens the claim. These questions are generally more advanced, as you must understand the claim presented in the passage and then select an answer choice that in some way contradicts that claim. Weaken The Claim questions always include the word “weaken” or “undermine” and look like this:

Which statement, if true, would most directly **weaken** the student’s assertion?

Which finding from the study, if true, would most directly **undermine** the team’s conclusion?

Weaken The Claim questions do not have a blank at the end of the passage.

1 Principle To Know

For Claims questions, **the correct answer is NOT in the text directly**. Instead the answer choices provide 4 pieces of outside information that relate to the claim in the passage, so **the correct answer can be entirely outside of the information provided in the passage**.

As always, there must be evidence in the text to support the correct answer. For Claims questions, this evidence is the claim in the passage and other relevant information in the rest of the passage that relates to the claim. The correct answer choice is the answer choice that matches the claim in the text by illustrating, supporting, or weakening that claim.

Illustrates The Claim

Illustrates The Claim questions are one of the easiest types of Reading Comprehension questions on the SAT. The key to Illustrate The claims Questions is to keep them simple and follow these steps.

1. **Identify the claim.** The claim is almost always clearly stated directly before the blank, so it should be easy to identify.
2. **Select the answer choice that illustrates the claim.** As you assess each answer choice, ONLY look for the claim. If the claim in the passage is that a character is scared of his own abilities, select the answer choice that shows him being scared of his abilities. It's that simple!

And that's it! Illustrates The Claim questions are very straightforward. Now, let's give it a try:

The *Underdogs* is a 1915 novel by Mariano Azuela. In the novel, Anastasio gets dragged into the Mexican Revolution. Azuela portrays Anastasio as surprising, writing _____

1. Which quotation from "The *Underdogs*" most effectively illustrates the claim?
 - A) "If you want my opinion, I'm not much on gambling. Do you want to bet? Well, come on then, I'm game. How do you like the sound of this leather snake jingling, eh?"
 - B) "I don't like to fight with my tongue either, it's not decent. I'm right, too, eh? I tell you no man living has ever breathed a word to me against my mother. I want to be respected, see?"
 - C) "Now, I may look dirty and my clothes may be torn to shreds, but I'm not really what I seem to be. I'm not here because I've got to be and don't you think so. Why, I own twenty oxen."
 - D) "What you need is the excitement of the city. I wager you shine your shoes every day and wear a necktie."

Notice how the claim is very clearly stated directly before the underline portion: we must select the answer choice that portrays Anastasio as surprising. As we read the answer choice, C is the only answer choice that shows Anastasio as surprising, as C says that while he may look dirty, he is not really what he seems to be. So, he is surprising. No other answer choice shows Anastasio as being surprising in any way, so C is correct.

Let's practice Illustrates The Claim questions with 2 more examples:

2. "The Fall of the House of Usher" is an 1839 short story by Edgar Allan Poe. In the short story, Roderick Usher is portrayed as a man with swiftly changing moods: _____

Which quotation from "The Fall of the House of Usher" most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A) "To an anomalous species of terror I found him a bounden slave. 'I shall perish,' said Roderick, 'I must perish in this deplorable folly. Thus, thus, and not otherwise, shall I be lost.'"
- B) "Roderick admitted, however, although with hesitation, that much of the peculiar gloom which thus afflicted him could be traced to a more natural and far more palpable origin—to the severe and long-continued illness of a tenderly beloved sister."
- C) "Yet the character of Roderick's face had been at all times remarkable. A cadaverousness of complexion; an eye large, liquid, and luminous beyond comparison; lips somewhat thin and very pallid, but of a surpassingly beautiful curve."
- D) "His voice varied rapidly from a tremulous indecision to that species of energetic concision. That leaden, self-balanced and perfectly modulated guttural utterance, which may be observed in the lost drunkard, or the irreclaimable eater of opium, during the periods of his most intense excitement."

3. “Pride and Prejudice” is an 1813 novel by Jane Austen. In the novel, Mr. Darcy is noted as lacking social graces: _____

Which quotation from “Pride and Prejudice” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A) “Mr. Bingley had soon made himself acquainted with all the principal people in the room: he was lively and unreserved. Such amiable qualities must speak for themselves. What a contrast between him and his friend, Mr. Darcy!”
- B) “Bingley was endeared to Darcy by the easiness, openness, and ductility of his temper, though no disposition could offer a greater contrast to his own, and though with his own he never appeared dissatisfied.”
- C) “Darcy had seen a collection of people in whom there was little beauty and no fashion, for none of whom he had felt the smallest interest, and from none received either attention or pleasure.”
- D) “‘If I were as rich as Mr. Darcy,’ cried a young Lucas, who came with his sisters, ‘I should not care how proud I was. I would keep a pack of foxhounds and drink a bottle of wine every day.’”

Support/Weaken The Claim

Support and Weaken The Claim questions require more reading comprehension, as you are asked (1) to identify the claim within a longer passage and (2) assess the answer choices to find an answer choice that supports or weakens the claim.

To start, let’s clarify what you are looking for in the correct answer for each type of question:

- **Support The Claim:** The correct answer is evidence supporting the claim or a portion of the claim.
- **Weaken The Claim:** The correct answer is evidence disproving the claim or a portion of the claim.

How to Approach Support/Weaken The Claim Questions

For Support/Weaken The Claim questions, we have outlined our recommended approach below:

1. **Read the question and recognize that it is a Support/Weaken The Claim question.** Look for the word “support” or “weaken” in the question.
2. **Read the entire passage.** On your first read, focus on understanding the passage.
3. **Find the claim in the passage.** The passage always makes it clear where the claim is by including a sentence like this:

“One team of scientists **claimed** that this phenomenon is the result of phosphate molecules in the topsoil attaching to the roots of tall fescue grass.

The claim in the passage is easy to find because it always has one of the following words:

Main Word	Alternate Versions			
claim	claims	claimed	claiming	
assert	asserts	asserted	asserting	assertion
conclude	concludes	concluded	concluding	conclusion
explain	explains	explained	explaining	explanation
predict	predicts	predicted	predicting	prediction
argue	argues	argued	arguing	argument
hypothesis	hypothesizes	hypothesized	hypothesize	
idea				

4. **Identify the keywords from the claim.** This step is critical. You need to know EXACTLY what you are looking for before you go to the answer choices. For example, let's say the passage has the following claim and asks you to select the answer choice that supports the claim:

"Wang and Young claim that female macaws may even provide food for other birds' chicks within their flock."

You need to look for an answer choice that provides evidence that show female macaws helping to feed other birds' chicks within their flock. Any answer choice that does not do this is incorrect.

5. **Relate the claim back to other portions of the passage (if necessary).** For some claims, you need to reread the passage and related the information in the claim back to other portions of the passage. For example, let's say a passage includes the following claim:

"The student asserts that beyond these factors there must be additional ones that affect the average income of a teacher."

Here, the claim references other factors. To understand the claim, we need to find the other factors in the passage and identify how these factors relate to the claim.

6. **Anticipate the evidence.** At this point, you should have a clear idea of what type(s) of evidence can support or weaken the claim. If you can anticipate the type(s) of evidence BEFORE reading the answer choices, identify the correct answer is much easier.
7. **Read the answer choices.** Read and assess each answer choice 1 at a time, going back to the passage as necessary.
8. **Return to the passage and reread as necessary.** For easier questions, the correct answer may immediately be clear on your first read of the answer choices. For harder questions, you should go back to the passage, as the information that you need to fully understand the claim is commonly related to other portions of the passage beyond the claim itself.
9. **Select the correct answer.** At this point, you should hopefully be confident in your answer choice. If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

Let's try this approach on 3 practice questions:

1. Nigerian author Chinua Achebe was a Nigerian novelist, poet, and critic who is most famous for his novel *Things Fall Apart*. Born to Nigerian parents in an area that would undergo profound changes due to European colonial rule, Achebe's works often reflect the complex interplay of traditional Nigerian culture and Western influences. In a literary analysis, a scholar argues that experiencing the effects of colonialism allowed Achebe to draw from the clash of African and European values to create a lasting impact on African literature.

Which of the following quotations from a scholarly review of Achebe's work best supports the scholar's claim?

- A) "Achebe is like many other African writers who experienced colonialism and chose to write both in their native language and English to reach a broad audience."
- B) "Achebe sought to escape the colonial perspective that framed African literature at the time and drew from the traditions of his Igbo people to create a unique voice."
- C) "*Things Fall Apart* depicts Achebe's experiences of living through the tumultuous changes of colonialism and is seen as the model for modern African novels."
- D) "The protagonist of *Things Fall Apart* Okonkwo is forced to respond with either appeasement or resistance to the imposition of Christianity on his culture much like Achebe was in real life."

2. Sepsis is a life-threatening condition caused by the body's immune system's overactive response to an infection. These infections are typically bacterial but may be fungal, parasitic, or viral. Doctors use the elevation of biomarkers for inflammation, such as lactate, C-reactive protein and procalcitonin to identify the presence of sepsis in the human body. The body's response to these infections leads to increased inflammation and organ damage, which can further place the immune system in overdrive. In a recent study, a team of doctors led by Dr. Patrick Burr claims that administering intravenous vitamin B1 can reduce the inflammation and further damage caused by sepsis.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Dr Burr's claim?

- A) Another study noted that after administering intravenous vitamin B1 on top of the standard antibiotic treatment, patients' immune systems had a more elevated response to their infections.
 - B) When intravenous vitamin B1 is administered, it is shown to not only increase the presence of vitamin B1 in blood samples but also increase patients' overall energy.
 - C) A controlled study found that patients administered vitamin B1 and standard antibiotics intravenously had elevated levels of procalcitonin compared to those who were only administered standard antibiotics.
 - D) Another study found that the administration of standard antibiotics and vitamin B1 showed a 70% greater reduction in the levels of C-reactive protein in patient's than the administration of standard antibiotics alone.
3. 2.6 million years ago, the Earth experienced the Quaternary extinction event, which resulted in the extinction of many large mammals, including mammoths and saber-toothed cats. Some zoologists hypothesize that mammals with smaller body sizes were more likely to survive this period of significant climatic changes since smaller mammals require fewer resources and can adapt more quickly to changes in their environment.

Which finding, if true, would weaken the zoologists' hypothesis?

- A) The dating of fossils of many species of smaller mammals showed they existed both before and after the Quaternary extinction event.
- B) A study by zoologists found that smaller mammals may require fewer resources, but a nearly identical percentage of smaller mammals and larger mammals went extinct 2.6 million years ago.
- C) A study by zoologists found that smaller mammals are one of the most adaptable species of animals on the planet.
- D) The adaptability of smaller animals has been shown to have decreased over the millennia since the Quaternary extinction event.

3 Tips For Success on Claims Questions

To finish up this chapter, let's highlight 3 tips for success on Claims questions.

1. **Anticipate the evidence.** After assessing the claim and other evidence in the passage, **you should have an idea of what you are looking for BEFORE you go back to the answer choices.**

If you do this effectively, it will be clear which answer choice is correct and which ones are wrong. If you do not do this effectively, you will get lost in the answer choices and will find it extremely difficult to tell which answer choice is correct.

2. **Find the connection across the passage (for harder questions).** For harder Support The Claim and Weaken The Claim questions, the evidence in the passage that you will need to fully understand the claim will go beyond the claim itself. You will need to find how the claim in the passage connects with other relevant information in the rest of the passage.

3. **If you get stuck, reread the claim.** If you get stuck at any point when answering a Claims question, your first move should be to go back and reread the claim. Think of the claim as our homebase. If we get lost, we should always return there to find out way.

For harder questions, **you should read the claim at least twice.** Rereading the claim can be an effective method to make sure that you are 100% clear on exactly what you are looking for. Additionally, if you are stuck between 2 answer choices and cannot tell which one is correct after rereading the claim (and more of the passage if necessary), it may become clear which answer choice is correct and which one is incorrect.

Claims Practice:

1. The Milky Way galaxy is composed of millions of stars in a relatively flat structure containing a thin disk and a thick disk. Based on computer simulations and analysis of data on the brightness, position, and chemical composition of about 250,000 stars in the thick disk (collected from two telescopes, one in China and one orbiting in space), astrophysicists Maosheng Xiang and Hans-Walter Rix claim that the thick disk of the Milky Way formed in two distinct phases rather than a single one.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers' claim?

- A) The telescopes used by the researchers have detected stars of similar ages in galaxies other than the Milky Way.
- B) There's an age difference of about 2 billion years between certain stars in the thick disk.
- C) The thin disk contains about twice as many stars that can be seen from Earth as the thick disk does.
- D) The stars in the Milky Way tend to have very similar chemical compositions.

2. Some residents in a neighborhood in Atlanta recently founded a community garden inside a local park. The residents agreed to volunteer to take care of the garden together. Students at a local high school surveyed some of the volunteers as part of a project to understand the impact of the new garden. The students concluded that the new garden benefited the community overall by fostering connections and relationships between the volunteers and other residents of the neighborhood who weren't volunteering at the garden.

Which quotation from a survey respondent would best illustrate the students' conclusion?

- A) "Our first challenge was deciding what plants would be most suitable to the climate and soil here in Atlanta. We needed plants that could survive the hot and humid summers."
 - B) "We're lucky to have a few expert gardeners living in the neighborhood. Some volunteers and I have gone to them a few times with questions, and they've been eager to help us and to learn more about the project."
 - C) "I love getting the opportunity to be outside and around nature, especially on days when the weather is nice."
 - D) "My favorite thing about the garden is the feeling of pride I get when I walk by each day. As I see the plants growing, I feel good knowing I had a small part in creating this beautiful space in the neighborhood."
3. In addition to her technical skill and daring feats, American stunt pilot Bessie Coleman was also known for dazzling the crowds that came to watch her air shows in the 1920s with her exuberant personality. During her career, she was careful and purposeful about how she crafted her public persona. An aviation researcher has claimed that Coleman intentionally defied social norms of the time by how she chose to present herself to the public.

Which quotation from an article about Coleman would most directly support the aviation researcher's claim?

- A) "For her air shows, Coleman frequently used the Curtiss JN-4, or 'Jenny,' which at that time was one of the most well-known types of planes."
 - B) "While Coleman was beloved by spectators for her charisma, she had a more complicated relationship with her managers and staff, who at times found her behavior too impulsive and demanding."
 - C) "Coleman once considered leaving her career as a stunt pilot to focus her efforts on giving speeches, which she felt would better support her public image."
 - D) "Although female pilots were typically expected to wear traditional but impractical attire that included dresses or skirts, photographs of Coleman show her wearing pants and leather jackets."
4. "The Rock and the Sea" is an 1893 poem by Charlotte Perkins Gilman. In the poem, a rock is portrayed as intending to confront and restrain the sea: _____

Which quotation from "The Rock and the Sea" most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A) "I am the Rock. Black midnight falls; / The terrible breakers rise like walls; / With curling lips and gleaming teeth / They plunge and tear at my bones beneath."
- B) "I am the Sea. I hold the land / As one holds an apple in his hand, / Hold it fast with sleepless eyes, / Watching the continents sink and rise."
- C) "I am the Rock, presumptuous Sea! / I am set to encounter thee. / Angry and loud or gentle and still, / I am set here to limit thy power, and I will!"
- D) "I am the Sea. The earth I sway; / Granite to me is potter's clay; / Under the touch of my careless waves / It rises in turrets and sinks in caves."

5. “Valia” is a 1907 short story by Leonid Andreyev. In the story, the author emphasizes that the setting where the character Valia is reading is nearly silent: _____

Which quotation from “Valia” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A) “The hand in which he carried his book was getting stiff with cold, but he would not ask his mother to take the book from him.”
- B) “Valia was reading a huge, very huge book, almost half as large as himself.”
- C) “Valia approached the window and examined the toys.”
- D) “Everything in the room was quiet, so quiet that the only thing to be heard was the rustling of the pages he turned.”

6. Although many transposons, DNA sequences that move within an organism’s genome through shuffling or duplication, have become corrupted and inactive over time, those from the long interspersed nuclear elements (LINE) family appear to remain active in the genomes of some species. In humans, they are functionally important within the hippocampus, a brain structure that supports complex cognitive processes. When the results of molecular analysis of two species of octopus—an animal known for its intelligence—were announced in 2022, the confirmation of a LINE transposon in *Octopus vulgaris* and *Octopus bimaculoides* genomes prompted researchers to hypothesize that that transposon family is tied to a species’ capacity for advanced cognition.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ hypothesis?

- A) The LINE transposon in *O. vulgaris* and *O. bimaculoides* genomes is active in an octopus brain structure that functions similarly to the human hippocampus.
- B) The human genome contains multiple transposons from the LINE family that are all primarily active in the hippocampus.
- C) A consistent number of copies of LINE transposons is present across the genomes of most octopus species, with few known corruptions.
- D) *O. vulgaris* and *O. bimaculoides* have smaller brains than humans do relative to body size, but their genomes contain sequences from a wider variety of transposon families.

7. Sandra Cisneros’s 1984 novella *The House on Mango Street* made a lasting impact on US literature. Its depiction of Mexican American culture inspired later authors to examine their own heritage within their fictional works. Also influential was the book’s portrayal of the main character, Esperanza, during a pivotal year of her youth. This insightful depiction of a preteen girl encouraged authors who, like Cisneros herself, are Latina to use fictional works to examine experiences from their own youth.

Which statement, if true, would most strongly support the claim in the underlined sentence?

- A) In interviews, a number of Latina authors say that *The House on Mango Street* inspired them to write about their own adolescence in their novels.
- B) In published writings, several prominent authors who are not Latina say that reading *The House on Mango Street* influenced their approach to writing fiction.
- C) *The House on Mango Street* has sold over six million copies and is one of the most commonly read books among high school and university students in the US.
- D) Since 1984, new novels about young Latina characters by Latina authors have often been compared to *The House on Mango Street*.

8. Rivers rich in sediment appear yellow, while increases in red algae make rivers appear red. To track things like the sediment or algae content of large US rivers, John R. Gardner and colleagues used satellite data to determine the dominant visible wavelengths of light measured for various segments of these rivers. The researchers classified wavelengths of 495 nanometers (nm) and below as red, wavelengths between 495 and 560 nm as blue, and wavelengths of 560 nm and above as yellow. The researchers concluded that for the Missouri River, segments flowing into lakes tend to carry more sediment than those flowing out of lakes.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers' conclusion?

- A) The segments of the Missouri River that had higher levels of chlorophyll-a, which contributes to the green color of photosynthetic organisms, have dominant wavelengths of light between 490 and 560 nm.
 - B) In lakes through which segments of the Missouri River pass, the dominant wavelength of light tended to be above 560 nm near the lakes' shores and below 560 nm in the lakes' centers.
 - C) The majority of the segments of the Missouri River were found to have dominant wavelengths of light significantly higher than 560 nm.
 - D) Segments of the Missouri River flowing into lakes typically had dominant wavelengths of light above 560 nm, while segments flowing out of lakes typically had dominant wavelengths below 560 nm.
9. Although it's clear that Mars once had liquid water on its surface, astronomers have debated whether the evidence of ancient water reflects a prolonged phase of warm, wet conditions—the so-called wet and warm scenario—or a brief period of melting in an otherwise consistently frozen environment. Researchers Benjamin T. Cardenas and Michael P. Lamb recently added to this debate by using data from NASA and the Mars Orbiter Laser Altimeter to map the topography of what is now a large basin in Mars's northern hemisphere. Cardenas and Lamb concluded that the wet and warm scenario is likely correct.

Which finding about the basin, if true, would most directly support Cardenas and Lamb's conclusion?

- A) Its dimensions and shape indicate that it is unlikely to have formed as the result of an asteroid or comet impact.
- B) It has features suggesting that it once held an ocean that underwent gradual sea-level changes over an extended time.
- C) Its physical characteristics are most consistent with it having formed as a result of a massive but short-lived influx of liquid water.
- D) It is surrounded by channels that could have been formed either by running water or by flowing lava.

10. *Sense and Sensibility* is an 1811 novel by Jane Austen. In the novel, Austen describes Marianne Dashwood's ability to persuade others of the rightness of her artistic judgments, as is evident when Marianne visits with John Willoughby, a potential suitor: _____

Which quotation from *Sense and Sensibility* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A) "Above all, when she heard him declare, that of music and dancing he was passionately fond, she gave him such a look of approbation as secured the largest share of his discourse to herself for the rest of his stay."
 - B) "Their taste was strikingly alike. The same books, the same passages were idolized by each—or if any difference appeared, any objection arose, it lasted no longer than till the force of her arguments and the brightness of her eyes could be displayed."
 - C) "It was only necessary to mention any favourite amusement to engage her to talk. She could not be silent when such points were introduced, and she had neither shyness nor reserve in their discussion."
 - D) "They speedily discovered that their enjoyment of dancing and music was mutual, and that it arose from a general conformity of judgment in all that related to either. Encouraged by this to a further examination of his opinions, she proceeded to question him on the subject of books."
11. Matthew D. Rocklage and team examined whether consumer ratings of movies can predict box office success. The team considered both numeric star ratings and written reviews in their research. To analyze the written reviews, the team measured the emotionality—the degree to which a written review expresses an emotional reaction—of user reviews on a movie rating website, assigning each review an emotionality score. After reviewing this research, a student argues that the emotionality of movie reviews is unrelated to a movie's success at the box office.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the student's conclusion?

- A) Movies that had the highest average emotionality scores received the lowest average star ratings on the movie rating website.
 - B) The average emotionality score of a movie's reviews was a positive predictor of that movie's box office earnings.
 - C) More than half of the movies that the team examined received an average star rating of 3 out of 5 stars.
 - D) The movies that were most successful at the box office tended to have high average star ratings.
12. Although most songbirds build open, cupped nests, some species build domed nests with roofs that provide much more protection. Many ecologists have assumed that domed nests would provide protection from weather conditions and thus would allow species that build them to have larger geographic ranges than species that build open nests do. To evaluate this assumption, a research team led by evolutionary biologist Iliana Medina analyzed data for over 3,000 species of songbirds.

Which finding from Medina and her colleagues' study, if true, would most directly challenge the assumption in the underlined sentence?

- A) Species that build open nests tend to have higher extinction rates than species that build domed nests.
- B) Species that build open nests tend to be smaller in size than species that build domed nests.
- C) Species that build open nests tend to use fewer materials to build their nests than species that build domed nests do.
- D) Species that build open nests tend to have larger ranges than species that build domed nests.

13. In 1534 CE, King Henry VIII of England split with the Catholic Church and declared himself head of the Church of England, in part because Pope Clement VII refused to annul his marriage to Catherine of Aragon. Two years later, Henry VIII introduced a policy titled the Dissolution of the Monasteries that by 1540 had resulted in the closure of all Catholic monasteries in England and the confiscation of their estates. Some historians assert that the enactment of the policy was primarily motivated by perceived financial opportunities.

Which quotation from a scholarly article best supports the assertion of the historians mentioned in the text?

- A) "At the time of the Dissolution of the Monasteries, about 2 percent of the adult male population of England were monks; by 1690, the proportion of the adult male population who were monks was less than 1 percent."
 - B) "A contemporary description of the Dissolution of the Monasteries, Michael Sherbrook's *Falle of the Religious Howses*, recounts witness testimony that monks were allowed to keep the contents of their cells and that the monastery timber was purchased by local yeomen."
 - C) "In 1535, the year before enacting the Dissolution of the Monasteries, Henry commissioned a survey of the value of church holdings in England—the work, performed by sheriffs, bishops, and magistrates, began that January and was swiftly completed by the summer."
 - D) "The October 1536 revolt known as the Pilgrimage of Grace had several economic motives: high food prices due to a poor harvest the prior year; the Dissolution of the Monasteries, which closed reliable sources of food and shelter for many; and rents and taxes throughout Northern England that were not merely high but predatory."
14. Neural networks are computer models intended to reflect the organization of human brains and are often used in studies of brain function. According to an analysis of 11,000 such networks, Rylan Schaeffer and colleagues advise caution when drawing conclusions about brains from observations of neural networks. They found that when attempting to mimic grid cells (brain cells used in navigation), while 90% of the networks could accomplish navigation related tasks, only about 10% of those exhibited any behaviors similar to those of grid cells. But even this approximation of grid-cell activity has less to do with similarity between the neural networks and biological brains than it does with the rules programmed into the networks.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the claim in the underlined sentence?

- A) The rules that allow for networks to exhibit behaviors like those of grid cells have no equivalent in the function of biological brains.
- B) The networks that do not exhibit behaviors like those of grid cells were nonetheless programmed with rules that had proven useful in earlier neural-network studies.
- C) Neural networks can often accomplish tasks that biological brains do, but they are typically programmed with rules to model multiple types of brain cells simultaneously.
- D) Once a neural network is programmed, it is trained on certain tasks to see if it can independently arrive at processes that are similar to those performed by biological brains.

15. In a research paper, a student criticizes some historians of modern African politics, claiming that they have evaluated Patrice Lumumba, the first prime minister of what is now the Democratic Republic of the Congo, primarily as a symbol rather than in terms of his actions.

Which quotation from a work by a historian would best illustrate the student's claim?

- A) "Lumumba is a difficult figure to evaluate due to the starkly conflicting opinions he inspired during his life and continues to inspire today."
- B) "The available information makes it clear that Lumumba's political beliefs and values were largely consistent throughout his career."
- C) "Lumumba's practical accomplishments can be passed over quickly; it is mainly as the personification of Congolese independence that he warrants scholarly attention."
- D) "Many questions remain about Lumumba's ultimate vision for an independent Congo; without new evidence coming to light, these questions are likely to remain unanswered."

16. Many governments that regularly transfer money to individuals—to provide supplemental incomes for senior citizens, for example—have long done so electronically, but other countries typically have distributed physical money and have only recently developed electronic transfer infrastructure. Researchers studied the introduction of an electronic transfer system in one such location and found that recipients of electronic transfers consumed a different array of foods than recipients of physical transfers of the same amount did. One potential explanation for this result is that individuals conceive of and allocate funds in physical money differently than they conceive of and allocate funds in electronic form.

Which finding from the study, if true, would most directly weaken the potential explanation?

- A) Recipients of electronic transfers typically spent their funds at a slower rate than recipients of physical transfers did.
- B) Nearly every recipient of an electronic transfer withdrew the entire amount in physical money shortly after receiving the transfer.
- C) Recipients of physical transfers tended to purchase food about as frequently as recipients of electronic transfers did.
- D) Some recipients of physical transfers received small amounts of money relatively frequently, while others received large amounts relatively infrequently.

17. Icebergs generally appear to be mostly white or blue, depending on how the ice reflects sunlight. Ice with air bubbles trapped in it looks white because much of the light reflects off the bubbles. Ice without air bubbles usually looks blue because the light travels deep into the ice and only a little of it is reflected. However, some icebergs in the sea around Antarctica appear to be green. One team of scientists hypothesized that this phenomenon is the result of yellow-tinted dissolved organic carbon in Antarctic waters mixing with blue ice to produce the color green.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the team's hypothesis?

- A) White ice doesn't change color when mixed with dissolved organic carbon due to the air bubbles in the ice.
- B) Dissolved organic carbon has a stronger yellow color in Antarctic waters than it does in other places.
- C) Blue icebergs and green icebergs are rarely found near each other.
- D) Blue icebergs and green icebergs contain similarly small traces of dissolved organic carbon.

18. Barchester Towers is an 1857 novel by Anthony Trollope. In the novel, Trollope's portrayal of Dr. Proudie underscores the character's exaggerated sense of his own abilities: _____

Which quotation from Barchester Towers most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A) "It must not...be taken as proved that Dr. Proudie was a man of great mental powers, or even of much capacity for business, for such qualities had not been required in him."
 - B) "[Dr. Proudie] was comparatively young, and had, as he fondly flattered himself, been selected as possessing such gifts, natural and acquired, as must be sure to recommend him to a yet higher notice."
 - C) "[Dr. Proudie's] residence in the metropolis, rendered necessary by duties thus entrusted to him, his high connexions, and the peculiar talents and nature of the man, recommended him to persons in power."
 - D) "[Dr. Proudie] was certainly possessed of sufficient tact to answer the purpose for which he was required without making himself troublesome."
19. A student performs an experiment testing her hypothesis that a slightly acidic soil environment is more beneficial for the growth of the plant *Brassica rapa parachinensis* (a vegetable commonly known as choy sum) than a neutral soil environment. She plants sixteen seeds of choy sum in a mixture of equal amounts of coffee grounds (which are highly acidic) and potting soil and another sixteen seeds in potting soil without coffee grounds as the control for the experiment. The two groups of seeds were exposed to the same growing conditions and monitored for three weeks.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the student's hypothesis?

- A) The choy sum planted in the soil without coffee grounds were significantly taller at the end of the experiment than the choy sum planted in the mixture of soil and coffee grounds.
 - B) The choy sum grown in the soil without coffee grounds weighed significantly less at the end of the experiment than the choy sum grown in the mixture of soil and coffee grounds.
 - C) The choy sum seeds planted in the soil without coffee grounds sprouted significantly later in the experiment than did the seeds planted in the mixture of soil and coffee grounds.
 - D) Significantly fewer of the choy sum seeds planted in the soil without coffee grounds sprouted plants than did the seeds planted in the mixture of soil and coffee grounds.
20. Many archaeologists will tell you that categorizing excavated fragments of pottery by style, period, and what objects they belong to relies not only on standard criteria, but also on instinct developed over years of practice. In a recent study, however, researchers trained a deep-learning computer model on thousands of images of pottery fragments and found that it could categorize them as accurately as a team of expert archaeologists. Some archaeologists have expressed concern that they might be replaced by such computer models, but the researchers claim that outcome is highly unlikely.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers' claim?

- A) In the researchers' study, the model was able to categorize the pottery fragments much more quickly than the archaeologists could.
- B) In the researchers' study, neither the model nor the archeologists were able to accurately categorize all the pottery fragments that were presented.
- C) A survey of archaeologists showed that categorizing pottery fragments limits the amount of time they can dedicate to other important tasks that only human experts can do.
- D) A survey of archaeologists showed that few of them received dedicated training in how to properly categorize pottery fragments.

Chapter 12: Data

Data questions include a passage and a graph or table and ask you to identify information in the graph to complete, support, or weaken a claim made in the passage. **Data questions are essentially the same as Claims questions** (except that we add in a graph or table), **so we will use the same principles that we learned in chapter 11.**

3 Types of Data Questions

There are 3 types of Data questions you will see on the SAT:

1. **Complete The Example:** Complete The Example questions ask you to select the answer choice that includes data from the table or graph that completes the example. Complete The Example questions look like this:

The team found that the least amount of groundwater occurred in _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to **complete the example**?

Complete The Example questions always have a blank at the end of the passage.

While the example above says, “complete the example,” complete the example question on test day can include any of the following phrases:

- complete the **example**
- complete the **claim**
- complete the **statement**
- complete the **text**
- complete the **assertion**
- complete the **hypothesis**

All of these phrasings are essentially the same and do not change how to approach these questions.

2. **Support The Claim:** Data questions often ask you to identify data from the table or graph that supports the claim in the passage. These questions are just like the Support The Claim questions we just covered in chapter 11 and look like this:

Which choice best describes data from the graph that **support** Connell’s claim?

Support The Claim questions do not have a blank at the end of the passage.

3. **Weaken The Claim:** Weaken The Claim questions ask you to identify data from the table or graph that weakens the claim in the passage. These questions are just like the Weaken The Claim questions from chapter 11 and look like this:

Which choice best describes data from the table that **weaken** the student’s findings?

Weaken The Claim questions do not have a blank at the end of the passage.

As you can see, data questions are very similar to claims questions, so we will use many of the same principles and approaches that we covered in chapter 11. **Do not complete this chapter before you have completed chapter 11.**

Complete The Example

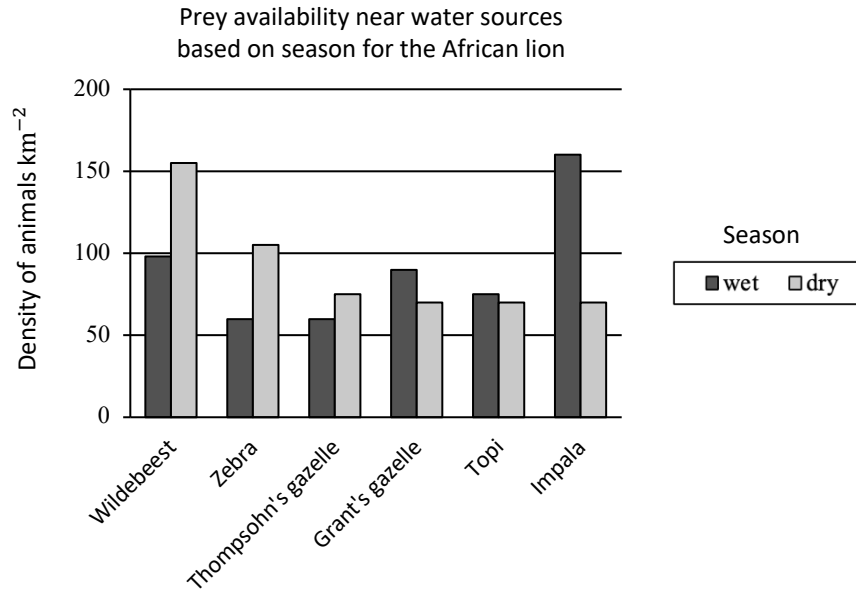
Complete The Example questions are the easier type of data questions. For Complete The Example questions, **the correct answer must (1) correctly interpret the data in the table or graph and (2) complete the example/statement/claim in the passage.**

How To Approach Complete The Example Questions

For Complete The Example questions, you should follow these steps.

1. **Read the passage.**
2. **Identify the example/statement/claim you are completing.** This should be easy to find, as the example/statement/claim is almost always clearly stated directly before the blank.
3. **Understand the graph or table.** Read the title, axes, and other labels to understand what the graph is showing and how it is related to the passage.
4. **Find the relevant part of the table or graph.** For easier questions, the last sentence of the passage often directs you to a specific portion of the graph or table. For harder questions, you may have to consider the table or graph as a whole.
5. **Assess each answer choice 1 by 1.** As you assess each answer choices, take the following steps:
 - **First, check if the answer choice matches the data.** Many incorrect answer choices include statements that do not match the data in the graph or table. Eliminate any answer choices that do not match the data.
 - **Next, check if the answer choice completes the example/statement/claim.** Correct answer choices must both match the data correctly AND complete the example/statement/claim. Incorrect answer choices commonly correctly match the data but are incorrect because they are not relevant to the example/statement/claim in the passage.
6. **Reread the example/statement/claim as necessary.** As you assess each answer choice, it can be easy to forget exactly what the example/statement/claim is that you are completing. If you forget or are stuck between 2 answer choices, it is best to reread the example/statement/claim you are completing to make sure you know exactly what you are looking for.
7. **Select the correct answer choice that completes the example.** Make sure the answer choice you select (1) is an accurate representation of the data and (2) completes the example/statement/claim.

Complete The Example questions are pretty straightforward. Now, let's give one a try:



Biologists Andrew M. Kittle and his colleagues studied the relationship between prey selection and weather patterns for the African lion (*Panthera leo*) in Tanzania's Serengeti National Park. The Serengeti has both a wet season, when available prey are scarce, and a dry season, when available prey are abundant, near remaining water sources where prey occurrence is predictable. For some species of prey, however, the lions had a greater availability during the wet season than the dry season; for instance, _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the example?

- A) the wildebeest, zebra, and Thompson's gazelle all had a higher level of availability as a source of prey during the dry season than the wet season.
- B) the Impala were twice as densely populated during the dry season than the wet season.
- C) Grante's gazelle had a higher level of density during the wet season than the dry season.
- D) during the wet season the Topi had a higher level of availability than the Thompsohn's gazelle.

Support/Weaken The Claim

Support and Weaken The Claim Data questions are the more difficult data questions, as **you are asked (1) to identify the claim within a longer passage and (2) find the answer choice that correctly includes data from the table or graph that support or weaken the claim.**

As a reminder, let's clarify what you are looking for in the correct answer for each type of question:

- **Support The Claim:** The correct answer includes data from the table or graph that support the claim or a portion of the claim.
- **Weaken The Claim:** The correct answer includes data from the table or graph that weaken the claim or a portion of the claim.

How to Approach Support/Weaken The Claim Data Questions

For Support/Weaken The Claim Data questions, we have outlined our recommended approach below:

1. **Read the entire passage.** On your first read, focus on understanding the passage.
2. **Find the claim in the passage.** To review how to find the claim in the passage, go to step 3 on p. 91.
3. **Identify the keywords from the claim.** Make sure you are clear on EXACTLY what the claim is.
4. **Understand the graph or table.** Read the title, axes, and other labels to understand what the graph is showing.
5. **Find how the graph is connected to the passage.** This usually involves rereading the passage to find the connection.
6. **Read the answer choices.** Read and assess each answer choice 1 at a time, going back to the passage as necessary. Note that for Support/Weaken The Claim Data questions, **we do NOT recommend that you try to identify exactly what you are looking for before reading the answer choices.** For Support/Weaken The Claim Data questions, using the answer choices and working backwards is much easier, as there can often be multiple pieces of data that could potentially support or weaken the argument.

As you assess each answer choice, take the following steps:

- **First, check if the answer choice matches the data.** Incorrect answer choices may include statements that do not match the data in the graph or table. Eliminate any answer choices that do not match the data.
- **Next, check if the answer choice supports or weakens the claim.** The correct answer must both match the data correctly AND support or weaken the claim. Incorrect answer choices commonly correctly match the data but are incorrect because they are not relevant to the claim.

Always read all 4 answer choices. Even if you think you have found the correct answer, it is best to always consider all 4 answer choices to make sure you are answering the question correctly.

7. **Return to the passage and reread as necessary.** For easier questions, the correct answer may immediately be clear on your first read of the answer choices. For harder questions, you should go back to the passage and data, as the information that you need to fully understand the claim and table or graph is commonly related to other portions of the passage beyond the claim itself.
8. **Select the correct answer.** At this point, you should hopefully be confident in your answer choice. If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

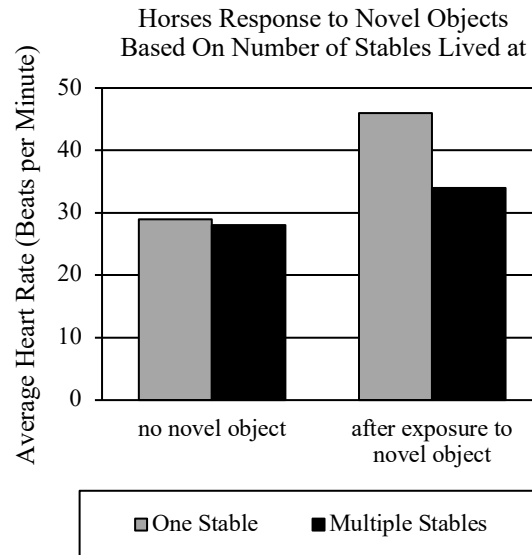
2 Common Incorrect Answers To Avoid

For all types of data questions, you should be on the lookout for the following 2 common incorrect answer choices.

1. **Incorrect Data Interpretation:** Incorrect answer choices commonly include statements about the data in the table or graph that are incorrect. If the information in the answer choice does not match the data, it is always wrong! For each answer choice, **you should first verify if the statement in the answer correctly matches the data in the graph or table.**

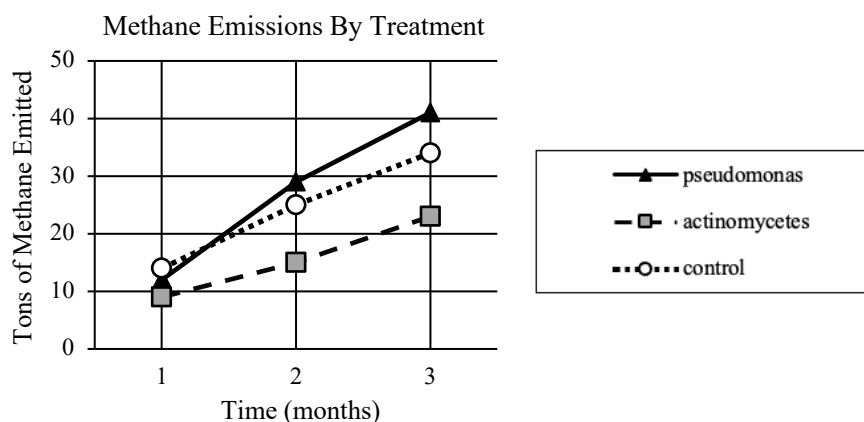
- 2. Unrelated To The Claim:** If an answer choice does not complete the example or support or weaken the claim, it is always incorrect, even if the answer choice correctly represents data from the data. Always make sure the answer you select actually complete the example/statement/claim (for Complete The Example questions) and supports/weakens the claim in the passage (for Support/Weakens The Claim questions).

Now, let's try to apply the approach that we have learned on 2 practice questions:



As prey animals, horses innately have a fear of new situations and objects. Horse fearfulness is measured by latency to resume feeding and elevated heart rate after being exposed to a novel object. Biologists Janne Winther Christensen, Line Peerstrup Ahrendt, and Christine Nicol led a team of researchers to determine the effect of the number of stables horses had lived at (either one stable or more than one stable) on the horses' response to a novel object. The researchers concluded that horses that had only lived at one stable were more reluctant to interact with a novel object than were horses that had lived at more than one stable.

1. Which choice best describes data from the table that support the researchers' conclusion?
 - A) After exposure to a novel object, the horses that had lived at multiple stables had a greater average increase in average heart rate than the horses that had lived at one stable.
 - B) After exposure to a novel object, the horses that had lived at one stable had a greater average increase in average heart rate than the horses that had lived at multiple stables.
 - C) The horses that had lived at one stable had a higher average heart rate without exposure to a novel object than horses that had lived at multiple stables.
 - D) The horses that had lived at multiple stables had their average heart rate increase by less than 10 beats per minute after exposure to a novel object.



Methane (CH_4), a powerful greenhouse gas, is emitted from landfills, resulting from the decaying of organic waste over time under anaerobic conditions. Mechanical Biological Pre-Recovery and Treatment (MBPT) uses anaerobic microorganisms, such as actinomycetes and pseudomonas, to break down the biodegradable component of the waste before it is placed in the landfill to reduce methane emissions. In a 2021 study, researchers hypothesized that the rate of methane emission in landfills could be lessened by utilizing anaerobic microorganisms that reduce the amount of biodegradable content entering the landfill. To test this hypothesis, researchers used three landfills of nearly identical size with one control landfill without MBPT, one that used actinomycetes in MBPT, and one that used pseudomonas in MBPT, and, for three months, the researchers measured the tons of methane produced at each.

2. Which choice best describes data from the table that weaken the researchers' hypothesis?
- A) For all 3 months measured, the landfill using actinomycetes in MBPT emitted fewer tons of methane than did the control landfill.
 - B) For all 3 months measured, the landfill that was not using pseudomonas or actinomycetes had the lowest level of emission of methane.
 - C) At the end of the three months, the difference in methane emissions between the control landfill and the actinomycetes landfill was greater than the difference between the pseudomonas landfill and the control landfill.
 - D) For 2 of the 3 months, the pseudomonas site had higher methane emissions than the control site.

3 Tips For Success on Data Questions

These 3 tips will help you succeed on Data questions on test day.

1. **Always Read the Title, Labels for the Axes, and Key.** Anytime you see a graph or table on the SAT, read the title, labels for the axes, and key carefully. **Make sure you clearly understand exactly what each table or graph is showing.** Sometimes, Data questions are some of the easiest questions on the entire SAT Reading & Writing Test. Many other times, however, the SAT includes graphs and tables that are more difficult to interpret properly to make Data questions more challenging.
2. **Watch Out for Answer Choices Written to Trick You.** Data questions are a classic place the SAT includes incorrect answer choices that seem correct if you are not reading the data carefully. **Read the answer choices to any data question extra carefully.** To be correct, the answer choice you pick must match exactly what the graph or table is showing!
3. **Work Backwards Using the Answer Choices.** On data questions, use the answer choices to your advantage. **Always assess the answer choices 1 at a time and work backwards.** There are many possible conclusions that can be drawn from the information in a graph or table, so it is easier and faster to assess the answer choices than try to come up with your own conclusion from the data.

Data Practice:

1.

Sample of Food Items from Gemini Mission Menus

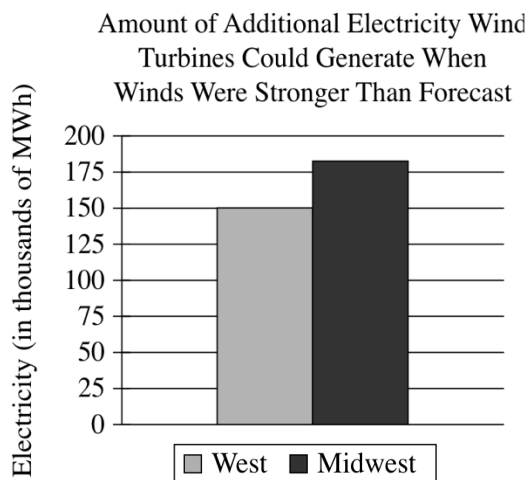
Food Item	Day	Meal
Sugar cookie cubes	1	B
Chicken and vegetables	2	B
Shrimp cocktail	3	C
Hot cocoa	4	A

To make sure they got nutrition they needed while in space, astronauts of NASA's Gemini missions were given menus for three meals a day (meals A, B, and C) on a four-day rotating schedule. Looking at the sample of food items from these menus, a student notes that on day 1, the menu included _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A) shrimp cocktail for meal B.
- B) hot cocoa for meal C.
- C) sugar cube cookies for meal B.
- D) chicken and vegetables for meal A.

2.



Electric companies that use wind turbines rely on weather forecasts to predict the maximum amount of power, in megawatt-hours (MWh), they can generate using wind so that they can determine how much they'll need to generate from other sources. When winds are stronger than they were forecasted to be, however, the predicted maximum amount of electricity wind turbines could generate will be too low. For example, the graph shows that for the West region, the winds were _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the example?

- A) strong enough to generate about 150 thousand more MWh of electricity from wind turbines.
- B) so weak that the electricity from wind turbines was about 175 thousand MWh less than predicted.
- C) so weak that the electricity from wind turbines was about 150 thousand MWh less than predicted.
- D) strong enough to generate about 175 thousand more MWh of electricity from wind turbines.

3. Results of Footprint Analysis for Two Sets of Theropod Tracks

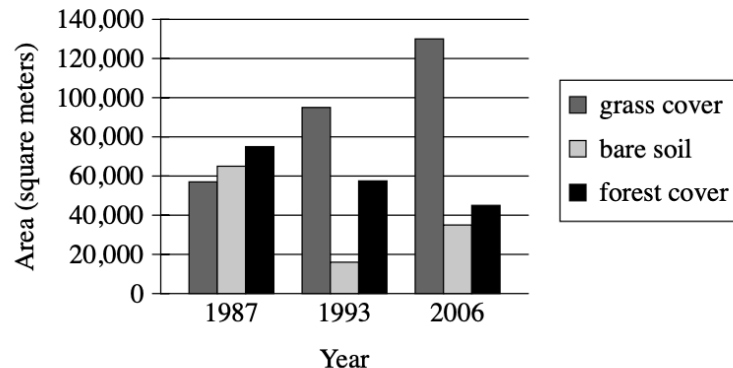
Tracks	Estimated footprint length (centimeters)	Average stride length (meters)	Estimated mean speed (meters per second)
La Torre 6A	32.8	5.23	6.5-10.3
La Torre 6B	28.9	5.57	8.8-12.4

The table shows data from paleontologist Angélica Torices and colleagues' 2021 study of two sets of dinosaur tracks preserved in a fossilized lake bed in Spain. The tracks, referred to as La Torre 6A and La Torre 6B, were left by two individual theropods (dinosaurs that walked on two legs). The team's findings suggest that of the two theropods, the one that left the La Torre 6B tracks had a higher maximum mean speed, _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the claim?

- A) a longer footprint, and a longer average stride.
- B) a longer footprint, and a shorter average stride.
- C) a shorter footprint, and a longer average stride.
- D) a shorter footprint, and a shorter average stride.

4. Characteristics of the Banks of the Provo River Downstream of the Jordanelle Dam

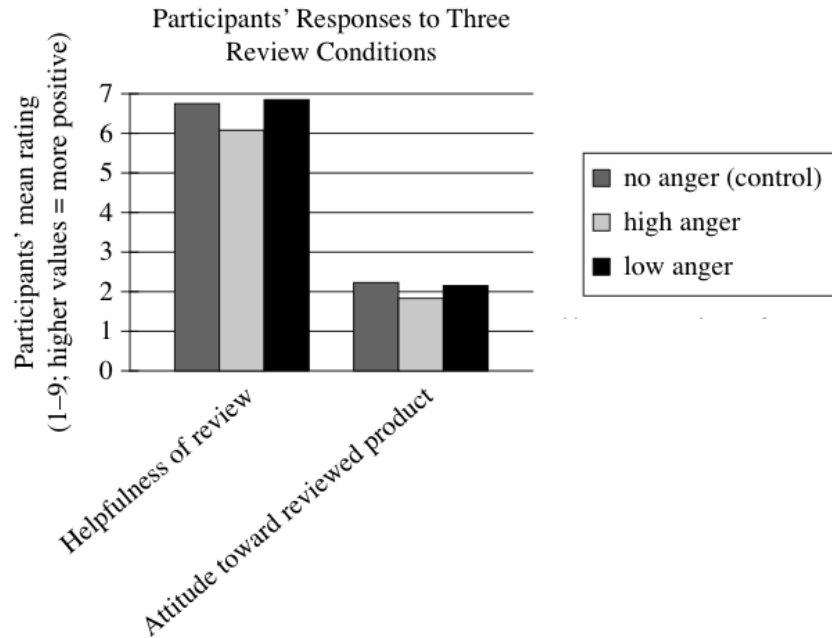


The Jordanelle Dam was built on the Provo River in Utah in 1992. Earth scientist Adriana E. Martinez and colleagues tracked the changes to the environment on the banks of the river downstream of the dam, including how much grass and forest cover were present. They concluded that the dam changed the flow of the river in ways that benefited grass plants but didn't benefit trees.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support Martinez and colleagues' conclusion?

- A) The lowest amount of grass cover was approximately 58,000 square meters, and the highest amount of forest cover was approximately 75,000 square meters.
- B) There was more grass cover than forest cover in 1987, and this difference increased dramatically in 1993 and again in 2006.
- C) There was less grass cover than bare soil in 1987 but more grass cover than bare soil in 1993 and 2006, whereas there was more forest cover than bare soil in all three years.
- D) Grass cover increased from 1987 to 1993 and from 1993 to 2006, whereas forest cover decreased in those periods.

5.

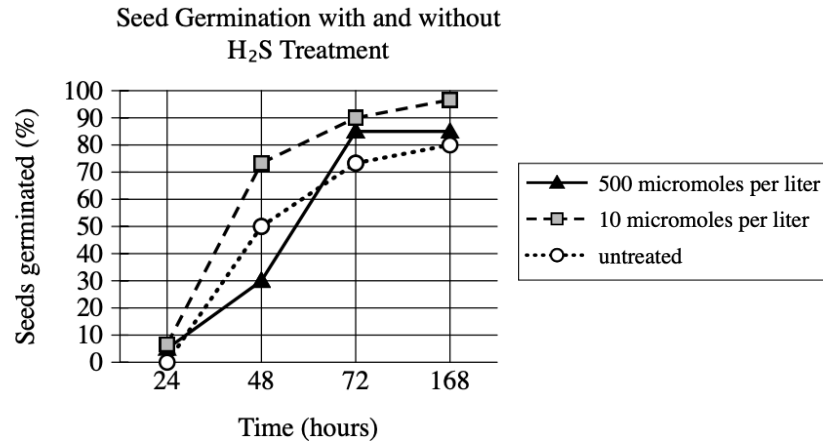


To understand how expressions of anger in reviews of products affect readers of those reviews, business scholar Dezhi Yin and colleagues measured study participants' responses to three versions of the same negative review—a control review expressing no anger, a review expressing a high degree of anger, and a review expressing a low degree of anger. Reviewing the data, a student concludes that the mere presence of anger in a review may not negatively affect readers' perceptions of the review, but a high degree of anger in a review does worsen readers' perceptions of the review.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support the student's conclusion?

- A) On average, participants' ratings of the helpfulness of the review were substantially higher than were participants' ratings of the reviewed product regardless of which type of review participants had seen.
- B) Compared with participants who saw the control review, participants who saw the low-anger review rated the review as slightly more helpful, whereas participants who saw the high-anger review rated the review as less helpful.
- C) Participants who saw the low-anger review rated the review as slightly more helpful than participants who saw the control review did, but participants' attitude toward the reviewed product was slightly worse when participants saw the low-anger review than when they saw the no-anger review.
- D) Compared with participants who saw the low-anger review, participants who saw the high-anger review rated the review as less helpful and had a less positive attitude toward the reviewed product.

6.

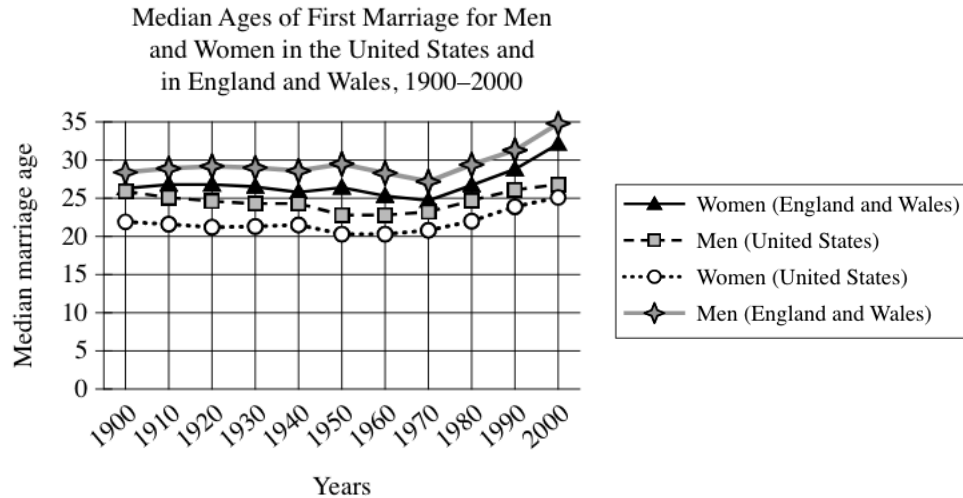


In high concentrations, hydrogen sulfide (H₂S) is typically toxic to many plants. Frederick D. Dooley and colleagues wanted to understand what effects low doses of H₂S might have on plant growth. They treated bean, corn, wheat, and pea seeds with various concentrations (measured in micromoles per liter) of H₂S and tracked the germination of those seeds along with the germination of untreated seeds. Treatment with particular concentrations of H₂S was associated with accelerated germination: for example, _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the statement?

- A) at 24 hours, less than 10% of seeds treated with H₂S at a concentration of 10 micromoles per liter had germinated, whereas more than 90% of those seeds had germinated at 168 hours.
- B) at 48 hours, more than 70% of the seeds treated with H₂S at a concentration of 10 micromoles per liter had germinated, whereas only 50% of untreated seeds had germinated.
- C) at 168 hours, more than 90% of seeds treated with H₂S at concentrations of 10 or 500 micromoles per liter had germinated, whereas less than 70% of untreated seeds had germinated.
- D) at 48 hours, approximately 50% of seeds treated with H₂S at a concentration of 10 micromoles per liter had germinated, whereas only approximately 30% of untreated seeds had germinated.

7.



A sociology student is reading an essay on the median age of first marriage in Western countries throughout the twentieth century. The author of the essay cites factors common to these countries that the author believes caused an increase in the median age of first marriage, such as new technologies that shortened the time needed for domestic chores, making two-person households less necessary and living alone more viable. The student asserts that beyond these factors there must be additional ones specific to particular Western countries that influenced the increase of age at first marriage.

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph that support the student's assertion?

- A) Between 1970 and 2000, the median age of first marriage rose more sharply for men in England and Wales than it did for men in the United States.
- B) In England and Wales, the median age of first marriage was consistently higher for men than for women between 1900 and 2000, but this was not always the case in the United States.
- C) The median age of first marriage for men in England and Wales was lower in 1970 than in 1950 or 1990
- D) Between 1900 and 2000, the median age of first marriage for women in England and Wales was consistently higher than for women in the United States, as was the case for men.

8.

Percentage of Available Eggs Eaten by Cane Toad Tadpoles

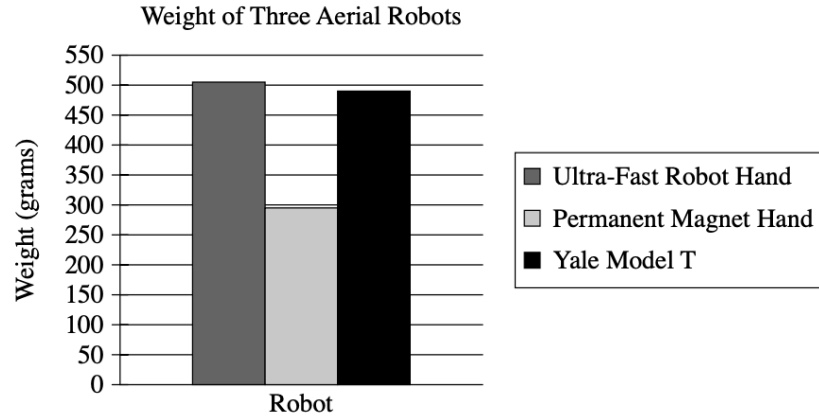
Amphibian species (common name)	Percentage of eggs eaten	Native to Australia	Produces bufadienolide
Little red tree frog	1%	yes	no
Cane toad	90%	no	yes
Short-footed frog	7%	yes	no
Striped burrowing frog	10%	yes	no
Dainty green tree frog	1%	yes	no

Native to Latin America, the cane toad was introduced to Australia in the 1930s. In recent decades, tadpoles in the Australian population have been shown to consume eggs of their own species. A 2022 study showed that when presented with cane toad eggs as well as eggs of native Australian amphibians, cane toad tadpoles disproportionately consumed eggs of their own species. This behavior results from their attraction to bufadienolide, a chemical produced by the eggs of cane toads but not by the eggs of native amphibians. However, using data from this study, a student wishes to argue that the presence of bufadienolide doesn't entirely explain the cane toad tadpoles' preference for certain eggs over others.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the student's argument?

- A) The tadpoles consumed a higher percentage of the striped burrowing frog eggs than they did of the eggs of the dainty green tree frog.
- B) The tadpoles left a certain percentage of eggs of each of the five species unharmed, thus ultimately allowing them to hatch.
- C) The tadpoles consumed a lower percentage of the short-footed frog eggs than they did of the eggs of their own species.
- D) The tadpoles consumed the same percentage of the dainty green tree frog eggs as they did of the little red tree frog eggs.

9.



Aerial robots vary considerably in their holding force; the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand, for example, has a holding force of 56 newtons, more than twice that of the Permanent Magnet Hand and more than four times that of the Yale Model T. Since an aerial robot must lift its own weight along with its cargo, engineer Jiawei Meng and colleagues used a ratio of each robot's holding force to the robot's weight to calculate payload capacity, with higher ratios corresponding to greater capacity, concluding that the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand has a higher payload capacity than the Yale Model T.

Which choice best describes data in the graph that support Meng and colleagues' conclusion?

- A) The Ultra-Fast Robot Hand and the Yale Model T each weigh more than 450 grams.
- B) The Ultra-Fast Robot Hand and the Yale Model T each weigh more than the Permanent Magnet Hand does.
- C) The Yale Model T has a lower holding force than the Permanent Magnet Hand despite weighing more.
- D) The Ultra-Fast Robot Hand weighs only slightly more than the Yale Model T does.

10. Tadpole Body Mass and Toxins Production after Three Weeks in Ponds

Population Density	Average tadpole body mass (milligrams)	Average number of distinct bufadienolide toxins per tadpole	Average amount of bufadienolide per tadpole (nanograms)	Average bufadienolide concentration (nanograms per milligram of tadpole body mass)
High	193.87	22.69	5,815.51	374.22
Medium	254.56	21.65	5,525.72	230.10
Low	258.97	22.08	4,664.99	171.43

Ecologist Veronika Bókony and colleagues investigated within-species competition among common toads (*Bufo bufo*), a species that secretes various unpleasant-tasting toxins called bufadienolides in response to threats. The researchers tested *B. bufo* tadpoles' responses to different levels of competition by creating ponds with different tadpole population densities but a fixed amount of food. Based on analysis of the tadpoles after three weeks, the researchers concluded that increased competition drove bufadienolide production at the expense of growth.

Which choice uses data from the table to most effectively support the researchers' conclusion?

- A) The difference in average tadpole body mass was small between the low and medium population density conditions and substantially larger between the low and high population density conditions.
- B) Tadpoles in the low and medium population density conditions had substantially lower average bufadienolide concentrations but had greater average body masses than those in the high population density condition.
- C) Tadpoles in the high population density condition displayed a relatively modest increase in the average amount of bufadienolide but roughly double the average bufadienolide concentration compared to those in the low population density condition.
- D) Tadpoles produced approximately the same number of different bufadienolide toxins per individual across the population density conditions, but average tadpole body mass decreased as population density increased.

Chapter 13: Completes The Text

Completes The Text questions ask you to read and understand the passage and select the answer choice that most logically completes the text. These questions really test your reading comprehension skills, as you must not only understand the passage as a whole but must also identify how various ideas are connected across the passage.

Completes The Text questions are already easy to spot because the question always look like this:

Many doctors of Sport Physiology have weighed in on the debate over whether cardiovascular exercise or weight training is the better form of physical exercise. Some doctors like Peter Attia often promote cardiovascular exercises for overall health and weight loss, highlighting benefits like improved heart health and blood pressure. However, other doctors like Mike Israetel emphasize the advantages of weight training, including increased muscle mass and bone density. Dr. Israetel argues that a focus on lifting weights can lead to more effective long-term health outcomes, especially in older populations. The presence of substantial scientific evidence supporting both viewpoints suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) there is a lack of scientific evidence for the benefits of weight training in younger populations.
- B) the debate over the ideal form of physical exercise is not yet settled.
- C) cardiovascular exercises do not effectively increase bone density.
- D) there is a lack of consensus amongst personal trainers regarding the best form of physical exercise.

Completes The Text questions always have a passage with a blank at the end and ask, “which choice most logically completes the text.”

In order to complete the text, the correct answer choice must:

1. **Complete the idea presented in final sentence(s).** The final sentence or last two sentences will often in some way direct you to what idea you are completing.
2. **Make a claim based on the information presented in the passage.** The final sentence that most logically completes the text in some way reflects the information portrayed in the passage.
3. **Connect the information presented in the passage.** There is ALWAYS evidence in the passage to support the correct answer choice. The correct answer in some way connects to the ideas presented in the rest of the passage.

Generally speaking, identifying the correct answer is not easy. For Completes The Text questions, **you NEED to understand the passage as a whole.** To do this, you will most likely need to read the passage multiple times, so these questions generally take longer to complete. Additionally, **you need to understand how different ideas across the passage connect.** All of this requires strong reading comprehension and discipline.

Completes The Text questions can be some of the most difficult on test day, so it is important to learn how to master these questions to achieve top Reading & Writing scores.

How To Approach Completes The Text Questions

For Completes The Text questions, you should use the following approach:

1. **Read the question and recognize that it is a Completes The Text question.** This should be easy since these questions always ask, “Which choice most logically completes the text?”
2. **Read the entire passage.** On the first read, try to get a general understanding of the passage.
3. **Reread the final sentence(s).**
4. **Identify the idea that needs to be completed.** Since we are completing the final sentence, you need to be clear on EXACTLY what idea you are being asked to complete. This is a critical step and helps you identify what information in the rest of the passage is important.
5. **Reread the passage. Find the information in the passage that connects to the idea that needs to be completed.** To do this, you may need to reread the passage 2-3 times. Take your time to do this correctly, as it will really help you answer the question correctly.
6. **Come up with your own completion(s).** At this point, you should have an idea of some potential completions to the sentence. **You do NOT need to write your own sentence.** Instead, we want you to use the clues in the passage to **come up with a rough idea of what could be a good answer that completes the text.**

To help clarify steps 3-6, let’s consider the passage below:

It is widely agreed that the ancient Inca learned how to “train” crops to be able to survive at lower and higher altitudes, but many botanists think there are limits to how much a crop’s native altitude can be altered, with the consensus being that anything beyond 1,000 meters is likely impossible. Johan Reinard’s team recently discovered Leona potatoes at an Incan ecological site at an elevation of 1,235 meters. While finding potatoes at sites where the Inca lived is not surprising, the fact that the Leona potato was at this particular site was, as the Leona potato is normally found between 2,500 and 4,000 meters above sea level. The discovery of the Leona potato at the lower elevation level helps support the idea that _____

The final sentence focuses on the discovery of the Leona potato at lower elevation and what that finding supports. To complete the text, we need to connect this information back to the rest of the passage to find out what the discovery of the potato at a lower elevation could support. Earlier in the passage, we see that botanists think that there is a limit to how much a crop’s native altitude can be altered. The Leona potato being found at 1,235 meters when it normally exists at 2,500-4,000 meters contradicts this, so **we are looking for an answer choice that in some way references that the botanists could be (or are) incorrect or one that says that the Inca’s techniques were more effective than previously thought.** So, some potential correct answer choice be:

- Potential Answer #1:** the botanists’ assumption about the degree to which a crop’s native altitude can be altered is incorrect.
- Potential Answer #2:** the Inca were able to modify the altitude at which a crop is able to grow more than previously believed to be possible.
- Potential Answer #3:** the altitude at which a crop can be grown can be modified by more than 1,000 meters under the right conditions.

Of course, there are more possible potential answer choices. The point here is that no matter the exact answer, we need to see information about the botanists being wrong or the Incas being better at training crops than previously believed in the correct answer choice.

7. **Read the answer choices.** At this point, you are looking for an answer choice that matches your completion(s) you came up with in step 6. Always read all 4 answer choices.
8. **Eliminate incorrect answer choices.** Incorrect answer choices often include details that are not in the passage at all or are not related to the idea you are completing.
9. **Reread the passage if necessary.** If you are unsure which answer choice is correct, reread the passage. After reading the answer choices, it may be easier to understand the passage and find how it all connects together.
10. **Select the correct answer.** At this point, you should hopefully be confident in your answer choice. If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

The most important skill to learn to master Completes The Text question is step 6 – if you can anticipate the type(s) of completions that you are looking for in the answer choices BEFORE reading the answer choices, the correct answer choice will be much easier to identify.

To practice this skill, let's look at the passages below and try to come up with your own potential answers.

Insect-based or supplemented diets are popular in many cultures across the world, especially in regions where raising traditional livestock like chickens, pigs, or cows is too expensive or unsustainable. In Mexico, chapulines, or grasshoppers, are commonly eaten as a snack or used to enhance dishes with their crunchy texture and protein content. According to the Biology Institute of the National Autonomous University of Mexico (UNAM), these insects are more nutritious than beef, chicken, or pork and have medicinal properties that help protect against E. coli infections and H1N1 virus. Considering that insects like chapulines require less land and water to produce and emit lower greenhouse gases compared to traditional livestock, researchers suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Potential Answer #1: _____

Potential Answer #2: _____

Potential Answer #3: _____

Now that you have come up with some potential answers, let's now consider the actual answer choices to this question below.

- A) regions outside of Mexico lack the proper conditions to farm chapulines.
- B) although many cultures consume insects in their diets, convincing other cultures to adopt the practice will likely be difficult even though it has clear benefits.
- C) raising traditional livestock that has damaging environmental effects should be outlawed.
- D) consumption of insects like chapulines provides an excellent alternative or supplementary food source that should be explored more widely.

By the end of the 1990s, many biologists believed that all the large aquatic species had been discovered. The giant squid, an invertebrate that for centuries was dismissed as a maritime myth, was long considered by marine biologists to be a species that probably did not exist, given the absence of any confirmed specimens and the creature's seemingly fantastical size and characteristics. The planet's oceans were thought to be incapable of supporting such a large predator without some form of evidence being discovered. However, in 2004, Japanese researchers captured the first images of a live giant squid, reaching a length of over 10 meters, in its natural habitat, proving its existence beyond doubt. This event may suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Potential Answer #1: _____

Potential Answer #2: _____

Potential Answer #3: _____

Now that you have come up with some potential answers, let's now consider the actual answer choices to this question below.

- A) it is possible that there are still other undiscovered large aquatic species.
- B) the biologists who doubted the existence of the giant squid did not believe that the oceans could support an invertebrate of such great size.
- C) rising ocean temperatures could eventually no longer support large aquatic species to live in secret.
- D) the biologists who did not believe in the existence of the giant squid were mistaken to dismiss sailors' stories due to their lack of scientific training.

3 Tips For Success on Completes The Text Questions

For Completes The Text questions, these 3 tips will help you consistently find the correct answer.

1. **Understanding the passage is key!** To answer Completes The Text properly, you need to understand the passage as a whole. To do this, it is important to **take time to read and reread the passage!** Your first time reading the passage is for general understanding – do not expect to understand the passage after your first read! Your second read is where you can really understand the passage and connect all the ideas together.
2. **Anticipate the potential answer choices.** After you read and reread the passage for understanding, try to come up with your own potential answer(s) for how the passage can be completed. Coming up with your own answers BEFORE you read the answer choices forces you to use the evidence from the passage. While this will take a bit more time at first, if you can do a good job anticipating potential answer choices, you will save time overall because you will be able to be much more decisive as you read each answer choice and can find the correct answer choice more quickly.
3. **Do not read the answer choices too soon.** Going to the answer choices too soon is the biggest mistake you can make on Complete The Text questions. If you go to the answer choices before you take time to understand the passage and come up with your own potential answer(s), you will get lost in the answer choices (and will be far more likely to select an incorrect answer choice).

Let's practice applying all of the skills we have learned in this chapter together on 2 more practice questions:

1. Many doctors of Sport Physiology have weighed in on the debate over whether cardiovascular exercise or weight training is the better form of physical exercise. Some doctors like Peter Attia often promote cardiovascular exercises for overall health and weight loss, highlighting benefits like improved heart health and blood pressure. However, other doctors like Mike Israetel emphasize the advantages of weight training, including increased muscle mass and bone density. Dr. Israetel argues that a focus on lifting weights can lead to more effective long-term health outcomes, especially in older populations. The presence of substantial scientific evidence supporting both viewpoints suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) there is a lack of scientific evidence for the benefits of weight training in younger populations.
 - B) the debate over the ideal form of physical exercise is not yet settled.
 - C) cardiovascular exercises do not effectively increase bone density.
 - D) there is a lack of consensus amongst personal trainers regarding the best form of physical exercise.
2. The Chukchi people of the Chukotka Peninsula in Asia practice a traditional nomadic lifestyle as reindeer herders, with little contact from the outside world. In the early nineteenth century, anthropologists observed certain physical traits in the Chukchi—such as the shape of the eyes and the structure of the face—that resembled those of indigenous populations in North America. Furthermore, the indigenous populations also lived a nomadic lifestyle like the Chukchi. This led to theories of a historical connection between the Chukchi and North America's indigenous populations or a migration of the Chukchi's ancestors long ago. However, genealogists' recent studies have revealed that the Chukchi's are not close genetic relatives of indigenous populations in North America. These findings suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) the indigenous populations in North America directly descended from the Chukchi population.
- B) the genealogists' studies must be flawed as the physical similarities indicate a genetic similarity between the two populations.
- C) the two unrelated populations evolved similar physical traits independently.
- D) migrations of populations from Asia to North America must have occurred before the Chukchi people became genetically distinct.

Completes The Text Practice:

1. Microbes that live in shallow lakes and ponds produce methane, a harmful greenhouse gas. Ecologist Ralf Aben and his team wanted to see how different types of shallow-water plants might affect the amount of methane that escapes into the atmosphere. Aben's team set up some water tanks with soil and microbes from local ponds. Some tanks had a type of underwater plant that grows in the soil called watermilfoil. Other tanks had either duckweed, a type of plant that floats on the water's surface, or algae. Aben and his team found that tanks with duckweed and algae released higher levels of methane than tanks with watermilfoil did. This finding suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) the presence of some kinds of underwater plants like watermilfoil helps prevent methane from escaping shallow lakes and ponds.
 - B) shallow lakes and ponds release more methane than deeper bodies of water because shallow bodies of water usually have more plants than deep bodies of water do.
 - C) shallow lakes and ponds are more likely to contain algae than to contain either watermilfoil or duckweed.
 - D) having a mix of algae, underwater plants, and floating plants is the best way to reduce the amount of methane in shallow lakes and ponds.
2. In their book *Smart Pricing*, Jagmohan Raju and Z. John Zhang consider musicians' use of the nontraditional "pay as you wish" pricing model. This model generally offers listeners the choice to pay more or less than a suggested price for a song or album—or even to pay nothing at all. As the authors note, that's the option most listeners chose for an album by the band Harvey Danger. Only about 1% opted to pay for the album, resulting in earnings below the band's expectations. But the authors also discuss musician Jane Siberry, who saw significant earnings from her "pay as you wish" online music store as a result of many listeners choosing to pay more than the store's suggested prices. Hence, the "pay as you wish" model may _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) prove financially successful for some musicians but disappointing for others.
 - B) hold greater financial appeal for bands than for individual musicians.
 - C) cause most musicians who use the model to lower the suggested prices of their songs and albums over time.
 - D) more strongly reflect differences in certain musicians' popularity than traditional pricing models do.
3. Arthur Conan Doyle's stories about detective Sherlock Holmes were published between 1887 and 1927. They have inspired countless successful adaptations, including comic strips, movies, and a television series *Sherlock Hound*, directed by Hayao Miyazaki, who is celebrated for his animated movies. Until 2014, these stories were copyrighted. The right to adapt was only available to those who could afford the copyright fee and gain approval from the strict copyright holders of Doyle's estate. Some journalists predict that the number of Sherlock Holmes adaptations is likely to increase since the end of copyright means that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) Doyle's original stories will become hard to find.
- B) people will become more interested in detective stories than they were in the 1800s.
- C) producing adaptations will become easier and less expensive.
- D) the former copyright holders of Doyle's estate will return fees they collected.

4. Astronomers investigated the Arabia Terra region of Mars because it appears to contain irregularly shaped craters that may have been caused by massive volcanic explosions. In their investigations of Arabia Terra, the researchers found remnants of ash deposits in an amount and thickness that would result from a massive volcanic eruption. However, erosion and past resurfacing events could have modified the surface of the planet. Therefore, _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) the current makeup of the Arabia Terra region might not accurately reflect the volcanic activity of Mars's past.
 - B) eruptions from Mars's volcanoes were likely not as massive as astronomers previously believed.
 - C) ash was most likely expelled from multiple different volcanoes on Mars's surface.
 - D) the craters found in the Arabia Terra region were necessarily created by events other than volcanic eruptions.
5. In her 2021 article "Throwaway History: Towards a Historiography of Ephemera," scholar Anne Garner discusses John Johnson (1882–1956), a devoted collector of items intended to be discarded, including bus tickets and campaign pamphlets. Johnson recognized that scholarly institutions considered his expansive collection of ephemera to be worthless—indeed, it wasn't until 1968, after Johnson's death, that Oxford University's Bodleian Library acquired the collection, having grasped the items' potential value to historians and other researchers. Hence, the example of Johnson serves to _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) demonstrate the difficulties faced by contemporary historians in conducting research at the Bodleian Library without access to ephemera.
 - B) represent the challenge of incorporating examples of ephemera into the collections of libraries and other scholarly institutions.
 - C) lend support to arguments by historians and other researchers who continue to assert that ephemera holds no value for scholars.
 - D) illustrate both the relatively low scholarly regard in which ephemera was once held and the later recognition of ephemera's possible utility.
6. By running computer simulations of the development of our solar system, André Izidoro, Rajdeep Dasgupta, and colleagues concluded that the Sun may have been surrounded by three giant dust rings before the planets started to form. The researchers suggest that the materials in the innermost ring became the four planets closest to the Sun, the materials in the middle ring produced the rest of the planets, and the materials in the outermost ring created the asteroids and other small bodies in the region beyond Neptune. In one simulation, the researchers delayed the initial formation of the middle ring, causing oversized super-Earths to begin developing from the innermost ring. The researchers therefore hypothesize that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) the middle ring formed earlier in the solar system's development than the initial simulations suggested.
- B) the timing of the initial formation of the middle ring played an important role in determining the eventual size of Earth.
- C) if the formation of the outermost ring had occurred earlier in a simulation, all the planets would have become super-Earths.
- D) the innermost ring actually formed into all the planets in our solar system, not just the four closest to the Sun.

7. Some businesses believe that when employees are interrupted while doing their work, they experience a decrease in energy and productivity. However, a team led by Harshad Puranik, who studies management, has found that interruptions by colleagues can have a social component that increases employees' sense of belonging, resulting in greater job satisfaction that benefits employees and employers. Therefore, businesses should recognize that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) the interpersonal benefits of some interruptions in the workplace may offset the perceived negative effects.
 - B) in order to maximize productivity, employers should be willing to interrupt employees frequently throughout the day.
 - C) most employees avoid interrupting colleagues because they don't appreciate being interrupted themselves.
 - D) in order to cultivate an ideal workplace environment, interruptions of work should be discouraged.
8. Marta Coll and colleagues' 2010 Mediterranean Sea biodiversity census reported approximately 17,000 species, nearly double the number reported in Carlo Bianchi and Carla Morri's 2000 census—a difference only partly attributable to the description of new invertebrate species in the interim. Another factor is that the morphological variability of microorganisms is poorly understood compared to that of vertebrates, invertebrates, plants, and algae, creating uncertainty about how to evaluate microorganisms as species. Researchers' decisions on such matters therefore can be highly consequential. Indeed, the two censuses reported similar counts of vertebrate, plant, and algal species, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) Coll and colleagues reported a much higher number of species than Bianchi and Morri did largely due to the inclusion of invertebrate species that had not been described at the time of Bianchi and Morri's census.
 - B) some differences observed in microorganisms may have been treated as variations within species by Bianchi and Morri but treated as indicative of distinct species by Coll and colleagues.
 - C) Bianchi and Morri may have been less sensitive to the degree of morphological variation displayed within a typical species of microorganism than Coll and colleagues were.
 - D) the absence of clarity regarding how to differentiate among species of microorganisms may have resulted in Coll and colleagues underestimating the number of microorganism species.
9. Researchers recently found that disruptions to an enjoyable experience, like a short series of advertisements during a television show, often increase viewers' reported enjoyment. Suspecting that disruptions to an unpleasant experience would have the opposite effect, the researchers had participants listen to construction noise for 30 minutes and anticipated that those whose listening experience was frequently interrupted with short breaks of silence would thus _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) find the disruptions more irritating as time went on.
- B) rate the listening experience as more negative than those whose listening experience was uninterrupted.
- C) rate the experience of listening to construction noise as lasting for less time than it actually lasted.
- D) perceive the volume of the construction noise as growing softer over time.

10. In the early nineteenth century, some Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States used agricultural techniques developed by the Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) people centuries earlier, but it seems that few of those farmers had actually seen Haudenosaunee farms firsthand. Barring the possibility of several farmers of the same era independently developing techniques that the Haudenosaunee people had already invented, these facts most strongly suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A) those farmers learned the techniques from other people who were more directly influenced by Haudenosaunee practices.
- B) the crops typically cultivated by Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States were not well suited to Haudenosaunee farming techniques.
- C) Haudenosaunee farming techniques were widely used in regions outside the northeastern United States.
- D) Euro-American farmers only began to recognize the benefits of Haudenosaunee farming techniques late in the nineteenth century.

Chapter 14: Cross Text Connections

Cross Text Connections questions give you two short texts and ask you a question that involves both texts.

Cross Text Connections questions always have 2 short texts labeled “Text 1” and Text 2.”

There are three common types of Cross Text Connections questions that appear on the SAT: (1) Both Texts Agree, (2) Most Likely Respond, and (3) Describes A Difference. In this chapter, we will cover how to spot and approach both types of questions.

Both Texts Agree Questions

Both Texts Agree questions ask you to select the answer choice that both texts would most likely agree on. These questions are easy to spot and will look something like this:

1. Based on the texts, **both authors would most likely** agree with which statement?

Of course, there will also be 2 texts (Text 1 and Text 2) as part of the question.

How To Approach Both Texts Agree Questions

Our biggest tip on these questions is **do NOT read both texts at once!** You should read text 1, go to the answer choices and eliminate incorrect answer choices, then read text 2, and finally go back to the answer choices to find the correct answer. This approach makes Both Texts Agree questions much easier to handle.

1. **Read the question and recognize that it is a Both Texts Agree question.** This should be easy since these questions always say something like “both authors would most likely agree.”
2. **Read Text 1.** If Text 1 is confusing, you can reread the passage to make sure you understand it.
3. **Read the answer choices and eliminate incorrect answer choices.** After reading Text 1, you will be able to identify answer choices that Text 1 would not agree with. Eliminate those answer choices. Leave any answer choices Text 1 supports (or could support if you are unsure).
4. **Read Text 2.** If Text 2 is confusing, you can reread the passage to make sure you understand it.
5. **Read the remaining answer choices.** Do NOT reread the answer choices that you already eliminated in step 3. Eliminate any answer choices that Text 2 would not agree with. At this point, it should be clear which answer choice is correct. If it is not, go back and reread Text 1 and Text 2 as necessary.
6. **Select the correct answer.** If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

Many incorrect answer choices agree with only 1 passage. **By reading 1 text at a time and assessing the answer choices after each read, it is much easier to avoid answer choices that only agree with 1 text.**

What if I think I know the answer after just reading Text 1?

After reading Text 1 and assessing the answer choices, you may find only 1 answer choice that Text 1 agrees with. If this happens, you likely already think you know which answer choice is correct. So, what should you do?

- **If you have plenty of time, read passage 2 to confirm your answer choice is correct.**
- **If you are tight on time, select the answer you think is correct and move on.** Mark the question for review, so you can come back to it if you have time left over.

Let's apply this approach on the following practice question:

1. Text 1:

In 2014, Astronomer John Murray and colleagues believed they finally found a conclusive answer to the contested debate over what caused Phobos's numerous parallel, channel-like grooves. After examining, fracture fields throughout the solar system, Murray noticed that the grooves across Phobos have a near-perfect alignment to those he studied. However, Murray still is not certain whether the tidal forces that produced the grooves are from the impact that created Phobos's Stickney Crater or another source.

Text 2:

Past studies have concluded many different theories on the formation of Phobos's grooves. In 2019, scientist Terry Hurford and colleagues believe that the grooves are more like "stretch marks" that occur when Phobos was deformed by tidal forces. The gravitational pull between Mars and Phobos produces these tidal forces. Recent studies have shown that the interior of Phobos is quite supple, which would allow for tidal forces acting on Phobos to create more than enough stress to fracture the surface.

Based on the texts, Murray (Text 1) and Hurford (Text 2) would most likely agree with which statement?

- A) Many of the previous theories on the causation of Phobos's grooves lacked empirical evidence.
- B) The grooves on Phobos match those of other fracture fields.
- C) Tidal forces are responsible for the grooves on Phobos.
- D) Past studies have failed to correctly discover what caused the fractures on Phobos since they did not consider the nature of the interior of Phobos.

Most Likely Respond Questions

Most Likely Respond questions ask you how someone in one text will likely respond to a position in the other text. These questions require a higher level of reading comprehension and critical thinking and generally are more difficult than Both Authors Agree questions.

Most Likely Respond are easy to spot and will look something like this:

1. Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 **most likely respond** to the hypothesis presented in Text 1?

While the exact questions on the SAT vary, they always follow the general structure of the question above.

How To Approach Most Likely Respond Questions

For Most Likely Respond Questions, **you should read both texts before going to the answer choices.** Additionally, **you should try to come up with your own answer** before reading the answer choices. This approach ensures that you are using evidence from the passage to support the correct answer.

1. **Read the question and recognize that it is a Most Likely Respond question.** This should be easy since these questions always say, "most likely respond."
2. **Read Text 1.** Your first read is for general understanding of the text.
3. **Reread Text 1 to understand the main takeaway (if necessary).** This is a very important step. Most commonly, you should reread Text 1 to fully understand the Text 1. **Your goal is the understand the position in Text 1 before moving onto Text 2.**
4. **Read Text 2.** Again, you will likely need to reread Text 2 to fully understand the text.

5. **Come up with your own answer.** After reading both texts, try to identify how someone in Text 2 would respond to the position in Text 1 (more common) or how someone in Text 1 would respond to the position in Text 2 (less common).

As you come up with your own answer, ask yourself the following questions:

- **Do they agree or disagree?**
- **Why would they agree or disagree?**

Your answer does not need to be exact, but even a simple, “they would disagree because _____” will really help you effectively identify the correct answer.

6. **Read the answer choices.** Look for an answer choice that matches your answer. Eliminate any answer choices that are clearly incorrect.
7. **If you are unsure which answer choice is correct, reread the Texts as necessary.** Once you know the remaining answer choices, it can be easier to assess if they are correct or incorrect.
8. **Select the correct answer.** If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

This approach puts you in control. Yes, it is a bit more work to come up with your own answer, but doing so helps make sure that you are using evidence in the passage to explain how they would most likely respond.

Let’s apply this approach on the following practice questions:

1. Text 1

Identifying the factors that affect students’ academic success can allow educators to develop more effective programs. Educational psychologists Lisa Blackwell and Carol S. Dweck investigated the influence of students’ beliefs about intelligence on their academic performance. In a series of studies, they explored the concept of “mindset,” categorizing students’ beliefs into two types: fixed mindset (intelligence is static) and growth mindset (intelligence can be developed). Their research concluded that students with a growth mindset achieved higher grades due to their belief that they could overcome academic challenges through hard work.

Text 2

In another study on academic success, cognitive psychologists Angela L. Duckworth and Martin E.P. Seligman studied the role of self-discipline in students’ academic achievement. They measured students’ self-discipline through self-reported questionnaires and performance on cognitive tasks that required delayed gratification. Their findings suggested that self-discipline was a better predictor of academic success than intelligence quotient (IQ). Students with higher self-discipline scores consistently outperformed their peers on the tasks measured, even those with higher IQ scores, across various academic indicators.

How would Duckworth and Seligman (Text 2) most likely respond to Blackwell and Dweck’s findings, as described in Text 1?

- A) By acknowledging that a “growth mindset” could be an important factor in academic success as it can be a prerequisite for self-discipline.
- B) By disputing that a “fixed mindset” is not as valid of a predictor of academic success as self-discipline.
- C) By concurring that a student’s positive belief in themselves is a necessary component to academic success.
- D) By agreeing that intelligence is not fixed and can be improved by consistent hard work.

2. Text 1

Genetically modified organisms (GMOs) are dangerous and their use in agriculture should be banned. Altering the genetic makeup of crops can have unknown and potentially harmful consequences to both humans and the environment that may not become obvious for decades. Traditional farming methods are safer and more sustainable.

Text 2

While there are certainly risks associated with genetically modifying crops, the technology itself is not unsafe. In fact, GMOs can speed up the natural selection that occurs over decades with traditional farming methods. GMOs have the potential to improve crop yields and make agriculture more sustainable in a much shorter time than traditional methods. To safely incorporate GMOs into agriculture, it is important to conduct thorough research and testing in laboratories to understand any potential risks GMOs may pose to the environment or human health.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the claims of the author of Text 1?

- A) By claiming that GMOs have a benefit that traditional farming methods cannot provide.
- B) By asserting that GMOs have no harmful effects to humans or the environment.
- C) By arguing that GMOs are necessary to meet growing demands for crops.
- D) By acknowledging that the potential risks associated with GMOs are not yet fully understood.

3 Tips For Success on Most Likely Respond Questions

For Most Likely Respond questions, these 3 tips will help you consistently find the correct answer.

1. **Take time to understand both texts AND to determine the relationship!** To determine the most likely response, it is critical to understand both texts, so **you should expect to read each passage twice**. Your first time reading each text is for general understanding – do not expect to understand everything after your first read! Your second read is where you can really understand the text and connect all the ideas together. Understand this takes time, so do not make the mistake of rushing this process and going to the answer choices too soon!
2. **Come up with your own answer (if you can).** If you can understand the passage, recognize how they are related, and come up with your own answer BEFORE reading the answer choices, you are far more likely to find the correct answer. Remember, your answer does not need to be exact. A general “they would agree because _____” or “they would disagree because _____” is perfect. Even if you cannot fill in the blank, knowing if they would agree or disagree is still a great start.

Coming up with your own answers BEFORE you read the answer choices forces you to use the evidence from the passage. While this will take a bit more time at first, you will save time overall because you will be able to be much more decisive as you read each answer choice and can find the correct answer choice more quickly.

3. **Look for details in the answer choices that are not in either text.** Incorrect answer choices on Most Likely Respond questions often include details that are not in either text. **If an answer choice includes details that are not supported by either text, it is always incorrect!** Use this tip as you read the answer choices and if you are ever stuck between 2 answer choices.

Describes A Difference Questions

Describes A Difference questions ask you to select the answer choice that describes a difference in how the authors of Text 1 and Text 2 view something in the texts. Describes a Difference questions look something like this:

1. Which choice best **describes a difference** in how the author of Text 1 and the author of text 2 view the evidence on the formation of the pink sand beach?

While the exact questions on the SAT vary, they always follow the general structure of the question above.

How To Approach Describes A Difference Questions

For Describes A Difference questions, **you should read both passages before going to the answer choices**. For these questions, **you do NOT need to come up with your own answer** before reading the answer choices. Instead, **we recommend using the answer choices and working backwards on these questions**. There are many possible differences in the authors' views, so anticipating the difference is difficult and unnecessary. It is easier to read the answer choices and look for details that make each answer choice incorrect.

1. **Read the question and recognize that it is a Describes A Difference question.** This should be easy since these questions always say, "describes a difference."
2. **Read Text 1.** If Text 1 is confusing, you can reread the passage to make sure you understand it.
3. **Read Text 2.** If Text 2 is confusing, you can reread the passage to make sure you understand it.
4. **Read the answer choices.** As you read each answer choice, look for details that make the answer incorrect. Answer choices for these questions most commonly include statements about both Text 1 and Text 2 and look like this:
 - A) The author of Text 1 argues that the elements in the meteorite sample support the crater moon theory, while the author of Text 2 dismisses the meteorite sample as irrelevant to the crater moon theory.
 - B) The author of Text 1 believes that the crater pattern on the moon is similar to one found on Mars, whereas the author of Text 2 implies that there is not enough information to make that conclusion.

As you can see, we can assess each half of the answer choice independently. **If either half of the answer choice is incorrect, eliminate that entire answer choice!**

5. **Reread the Texts as necessary.** You will almost always have to go back and reread parts of or the full texts. Once you know the answer choices, you can go back to the passage to see if the statements in the answer choices match the texts.
6. **Select the correct answer.** At this point, you should hopefully be confident in your answer. If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

Using this method and working backwards with the answer choices makes Describes A Difference questions much easier to answer correctly.

3 Key Tip For Success on Describes A Difference Questions

1. **Work Backwards More Actively with the Answer Choices.** Describes A Difference passages questions generally have answer choices that include statements about both texts. For answer choices like this, **work backwards more actively and look for any specific detail that does not match the texts.** Often, multiple answer choices are partly correct, so it is easier to look for what is incorrect about each answer choice rather than focus on which answer choice seems to be the most correct.
2. **Beware of Half-Right Answer Choices.** On Describes A Difference questions, the SAT loves writing answer choices that are halfway correct. **Part of the answer choice will perfectly match a text; however, there is something wrong with the remaining portion of the answer choice.** Students often pick these incorrect answer choices because they get excited over the portion that is correct and do not read the rest of the answer choice carefully enough. As always, we need to be very picky when assessing each answer choice.

For example, consider the following answer choices:

Which choice best describes a difference in how the authors of Text 1 and Text 2 view Level's study?

- A) The author of Text 1 questions the methods used to obtain the findings, while the author of Text 2 is optimistic about the impacts of the findings.
- B) The author of Text 1 asserts that the design of the study is flawed, while the author of Text 2 believes the results described by Level are achievable in the near future.

Notice how the first half of answer choices A and B are both very similar. These could both accurately describe passage 1, but only one can be correct – meaning that one of these answer choices must be half-right. In this situation, it is important to focus on the second half of the answer choices to determine which one is correct. As always, the correct answer must be 100% correct!

3. **Do Not Focus on the Identical Parts of the Answer Choices.** As we just saw, answer choices for Describes A Difference questions can have portions of multiple answer choices that are identical, as we just saw in the example on the previous page. **When you see identical parts in the answer choices, do not focus on the similarities; instead, focus on the differences.** Students make the mistake of trying to figure out which identical part is more correct, which is often impossible. Instead, you should focus on the differences in the rest of the answer choice, as this is what actually determines which answer choice is the correct one.

To better illustrate how this can occur, let's look at the example question below:

Which choice best describes a difference in how Smith (Text 1) and Jones (Text 2) view women serving in the army?

- A) Smith implies that women should be prevented from serving in the army, whereas Jones supports women serving in the army in non-combat roles.
- B) Smith believes that women with certain physical abilities can be considered for service in the army, whereas Jones assumes that physical ability is unrelated to any person's ability to serve.
- C) Smith argues that service should be a personal choice regardless of gender, whereas Jones contends that women are unsuitable to serve due to emotional instability.
- D) Smith asserts that anyone who can serve in the army should be able to do so, whereas Jones argues that men and women should serve in gender-specific roles.

Here, the first half of answer choices C and D are both saying the same thing: anyone should be able to serve in the army. Let's assume Smith argues that in Text 1. If that is the case, there is no way to tell if C or D is correct by focusing on the first half alone. Instead, we need to look at the rest of the answer choices and focus on the differences.

Similarly, the second half of answer choices A and D are also making almost identical statements: men and women should have separate roles in the army. These statements are not quite as identical as our first example, but they are still very similar and could both be supported by Jones in Text 2. Again, if Jones did argue that in Text 2, we should not focus on trying to determine which of those answer choices is more correct. Instead, we should look at the first half of those answer choices and focus on the differences to find which one is correct.

Let's apply this approach on the following practice question:

1. Text 1:

Most scientists agree that the greatest challenge of working with ancient DNA (aDNA) is contamination with contemporary DNA. The presence of contemporary DNA can easily "swamp" the small amount of authentic DNA in an ancient sample. To alleviate this problem, scientists have established a set of procedures to minimize the risk of contamination. However, if a sample is contaminated before it arrives at a laboratory, such as during excavation, it can be impossible to distinguish between authentic aDNA and contaminants.

Text 2:

Contamination, corruption, and chromosomal shedding make it nearly impossible for scientists to glean helpful information from aDNA. In most ancient tissues, 99% of the DNA present comes from the contamination by invading fungi and bacteria. A new technique involving chemical snares, like "RNA bait," has been created to address contamination. The bait is prepared with chemical Velcro that gloms onto the human DNA. Scientists then wash away the un-Velcroed microbial and fungal DNA, leaving behind pristine samples.

Which choice best describes a difference in how the author of Text 1 and the author of Text 2 view contamination in aDNA?

- A) The author of Text 1 believes that the most common form of contamination is contemporary DNA, while the author of Text 2 believes that contamination of contemporary DNA can be easily fixed.
- B) The author of Text 1 believes that if proper procedures are followed the risk of contamination can be minimized, while the author of Text 2 believes that such procedures are outdated.
- C) The author of Text 1 claims that contamination of aDNA poses the most significant challenge to working with aDNA, while the author of Text 2 focuses on a novel method that can alleviate the majority of contamination of aDNA.
- D) The author of Text 1 asserts fungal and bacterial contamination are not a risk to aDNA as long as proper procedures are followed, while the author of Text 2 claims that fungal and bacterial contamination are responsible for 99% of the contamination of aDNA samples.

Cross Text Connections Practice:**1. Text 1**

Some animal species, like the leopard, can be found in many kinds of areas. On the other hand, tropical mountain bird species tend to be limited in the types of spaces they can call home. This is because many mountain bird species are only able to survive at very specific elevations. Over time, these species have likely become used to living at a specific temperature. Therefore, these species struggle to survive at elevations that are warmer or colder than they are used to.

Text 2

A new study reviewed observations of nearly 3,000 bird species to understand why tropical mountain bird species live at specific elevations. They noted that when a mountain bird species was found in an area with many other bird species, it tended to inhabit much smaller geographic areas. It is thus likely that competition for resources with other species, not temperature, limits where these birds can live.

Based on the texts, both authors would most likely agree with which statement?

- A) Tropical mountain bird species are restricted in where they can live.
- B) Scientists have better tools to observe tropical mountain birds than they did in the past.
- C) Little is known about how tropical mountain birds build their nests.
- D) Tropical mountain bird species that live at high elevations tend to be genetically similar.

2. Text 1

A team led by Bernardo Strassburg has found that rewilding farmland (returning the land to its natural state) could help preserve biodiversity and offset carbon emissions. The amount of farmland that would need to be restored, they found, is remarkably low. Rewilding a mere 15% of the world's current farmland would prevent 60% of expected species extinctions and help absorb nearly 299 gigatons of carbon dioxide—a clear win in the fight against the biodiversity and climate crises.

Text 2

While Strassburg's team's findings certainly offer encouraging insight into the potential benefits of rewilding, it's important to consider potential effects on global food supplies. The researchers suggest that to compensate for the loss of food-producing land, remaining farmland would need to produce even more food. Thus, policies focused on rewilding farmland must also address strategies for higher-yield farming.

Which choice best describes a difference in how the author of Text 1 and the author of Text 2 view Strassburg's team's study?

- A) The author of Text 2 approaches the study's findings with some caution, whereas the author of Text 1 is optimistic about the reported potential environmental benefits.
- B) The author of Text 2 claims that the percentage of farmland identified by Strassburg's team is too low for rewilding to achieve meaningful results, whereas the author of Text 1 thinks the percentage is sufficient.
- C) The author of Text 2 believes that the results described by Strassburg's team are achievable in the near future, whereas the author of Text 1 argues that they likely aren't.
- D) The author of Text 2 focuses on rewilding's effect on carbon emissions, whereas the author of Text 1 focuses on its effect on biodiversity.

3. **Text 1**

In a study of insect behavior, Samadi Galpayage and colleagues presented bumblebees with small wooden balls and observed many of the bees clinging to, rolling, and dragging the objects. The researchers provided no external rewards (such as food) to encourage these interactions. The bees simply appeared to be playing—and for no other reason than because they were having fun.

Text 2

Insects do not have cortexes or other brain areas associated with emotions in humans. Still, Galpayage and her team have shown that bumblebees may engage in play, possibly experiencing some kind of positive emotional state. Other studies have suggested that bees experience negative emotional states (for example, stress), but as Galpayage and her team have acknowledged, emotions in insects, if they do indeed exist, are likely very rudimentary.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined portion of Text 1?

- A) By objecting that the bees were actually experiencing a negative feeling akin to stress rather than a positive feeling
- B) By arguing that some insects other than bumblebees may be capable of experiencing complex emotional states
- C) By pointing out that even humans sometimes struggle to have fun while engaging in play
- D) By noting that if the bees were truly playing, any positive feelings they may have experienced were probably quite basic

4. **Text 1**

Literary scholars have struggled with the vastness of Nigerian writer Wole Soyinka's collective works of drama (spanning over 20 plays in total). It is best, however, to understand Soyinka's body of work as a dramatist chronologically. Soyinka's progression as a playwright can be considered to fall into three periods, with each one representing a particular thematic and stylistic cohesion: the 1960s, the two decades between 1970 and 1990, and lastly, from roughly 1990 onwards.

Text 2

It is tempting to impose a linear sense of order on the expanse of Wole Soyinka's body of work as a dramatist. However, critics who have considered Soyinka's plays to fit neatly into three phases overlook potential commonalities in Soyinka's work that span across these phases. Additionally, this view may discount significant differences in the styles and content of plays written around the same time.

Which choice best describes a difference in how the author of Text 1 and the author of Text 2 view the study of Soyinka's works of drama?

- A) While the author of Text 1 believes that thinking about Soyinka's works of theater in phases is useful, the author of Text 2 views such an approach as limiting.
- B) Although the author of Text 1 claims that Soyinka's style as a dramatist has evolved over time, the author of Text 2 argues that Soyinka's style has remained consistent throughout his career.
- C) The author of Text 1 considers Soyinka's plays to showcase his strongest writing, whereas the author of Text 2 believes that Soyinka's poetry is where he is most skilled.
- D) The author of Text 1 argues that Soyinka's early plays were his most politically charged, whereas the author of Text 2 claims that Soyinka's most recent plays are the most politicized.

5. **Text 1**

Many studies in psychology have shown that people seek out information even when they know in advance that they have no immediate use for it and that they won't directly benefit from it. Such findings support the consensus view among researchers of curiosity: namely, that curiosity is not instrumental but instead represents a drive to acquire information for its own sake.

Text 2

While acknowledging that acquiring information is a powerful motivator, Rachit Dubey and colleagues ran an experiment to test whether emphasizing the usefulness of scientific information could increase curiosity about it. They found that when research involving rats and fruit flies was presented as having medical applications for humans, participants expressed greater interest in learning about it than when the research was not presented as useful.

Based on the texts, how would Dubey and colleagues (Text 2) most likely respond to the consensus view discussed in Text 1?

- A) By suggesting that curiosity may not be exclusively motivated by the desire to merely acquire information
- B) By conceding that people may seek out information that serves no immediate purpose only because they think they can use it later
- C) By pointing out that it is challenging to determine when information-seeking serves no goal beyond acquiring information
- D) By disputing the idea that curiosity can help explain apparently purposeless information-seeking behaviors

6. **Text 1**

Because literacy in Nahuatl script, the writing system of the Aztec Empire, was lost after Spain invaded central Mexico in the 1500s, it is unclear exactly how meaning was encoded in the script's symbols. Although many scholars had assumed that the symbols signified entire words, linguist Alfonso Lacadena theorized in 2008 that they signified units of language smaller than words: individual syllables.

Text 2

The growing consensus among scholars of Nahuatl script is that many of its symbols could signify either words or syllables, depending on syntax and content at any given site within a text. For example, the symbol signifying the word huipil (blouse) in some contexts could signify the syllable "pil" in others, as in the place name "Chipiltepec." Thus, for the Aztecs, reading required a determination of how such symbols functioned each time they appeared in a text.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely characterize Lacadena's theory, as described in Text 1?

- A) By praising the theory for recognizing that the script's symbols could represent entire words
- B) By arguing that the theory is overly influenced by the work of earlier scholars
- C) By approving of the theory's emphasis on how the script changed over time
- D) By cautioning that the theory overlooks certain important aspects of how the script functioned

7. Text 1

Microbes are tiny organisms in the soil, water, and air all around us. They thrive even in very harsh conditions. That's why Noah Fierer and colleagues were surprised when soil samples they collected from an extremely cold, dry area in Antarctica didn't seem to contain any life. The finding doesn't prove that there are no microbes in that area, but the team says it does suggest that the environment severely restricts microbes' survival.

Text 2

Microbes are found in virtually every environment on Earth. So it's unlikely they would be completely absent from Fierer's team's study site, no matter how extreme the environment is. There were probably so few organisms in the samples that current technology couldn't detect them. But since a spoonful of typical soil elsewhere might contain billions of microbes, the presence of so few in the Antarctic soil samples would show how challenging the conditions are.

Based on the texts, Fierer's team and the author of Text 2 would most likely agree with which statement about microbes?

- A) Most microbes are better able to survive in environments with extremely dry conditions than in environments with harsh temperatures.
- B) A much higher number of microbes would probably be found if another sample of soil were taken from the Antarctic study site.
- C) Most microbes are probably unable to withstand the soil conditions at the Antarctic study site.
- D) Microbes are likely difficult to detect in the soil at the Antarctic study site because they tend to be smaller than microbes found in typical soil elsewhere.

8. Text 1

Stage lighting theorist Adolphe Appia was perhaps the first to argue that light must be considered alongside all the various elements of a stage to create a single, unified performance. Researcher Kelly Bremner, however, has noted that Appia lacked technical expertise in the use of light in the theater. As a result of Appia's inexperience, Bremner argues, Appia's theory of light called for lighting practices that weren't possible until after the advent of electricity around 1881.

Text 2

Adolphe Appia was not an amateur in the practice of lighting. Instead, it is precisely his exposure to lighting techniques at the time that contributed to his theory on the importance of light. When working as an apprentice for a lighting specialist in his youth, Appia observed the use of portable lighting devices that could be operated by hand. This experience developed his understanding of what was possible in the coordination of elements on the stage.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the claim about Appia's level of technical expertise made by Bremner in Text 1?

- A) Many lighting technicians dismissed Appia's ideas about light on the stage.
- B) Appia likely gained a level of technical expertise during his time as an apprentice.
- C) Theater practitioners who worked with Appia greatly admired his work.
- D) Appia was unfamiliar with the use of music and sound in theater.

9. **Text 1**

Philosopher G.E. Moore's most influential work entails the concept of common sense. He asserts that there are certain beliefs that all people, including philosophers, know instinctively to be true, whether or not they profess otherwise: among them, that they have bodies, or that they exist in a world with other objects that have three dimensions. Moore's careful work on common sense may seem obvious but was in fact groundbreaking.

Text 2

External world skepticism is a philosophical stance supposing that we cannot be sure of the existence of anything outside our own minds. During a lecture, G.E. Moore once offered a proof refuting this stance by holding out his hands and saying, "Here is one hand, and here is another." Many philosophers reflexively reject this proof (Annalisa Coliva called it "an obviously annoying failure") but have found it a challenge to articulate exactly why the proof fails.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 1 most likely respond to proponents of the philosophical stance outlined in Text 2?

- A) By agreeing with those proponents that Moore's treatment of positions that contradict his own is fundamentally unserious
- B) By suggesting that an instinctive distaste for Moore's position is preventing external world skeptics from constructing a sufficiently rigorous refutation of Moore
- C) By arguing that if it is valid to assert that some facts are true based on instinct, it is also valid to assert that some proofs are inadequate based on instinct
- D) By pointing out that Moore would assert that external world skepticism is at odds with other beliefs those proponents must unavoidably hold

10. **Text 1**

Polar bears sustain themselves primarily by hunting seals on the Arctic sea ice, but rising ocean temperatures are causing the ice to diminish, raising concerns about polar bear population declines as these large predators' seal hunting habitats continue to shrink. A 2020 study examining polar bear populations across the Arctic concluded that populations affected by sea-ice loss are at great risk of extinction by the end of the twenty-first century.

Text 2

Monitoring carried out by researchers from the Norwegian Polar Institute shows that the polar bear population on the Arctic archipelago of Svalbard remains stable and well nourished despite rapidly declining sea ice in recent years. The researchers attribute this population's resilience in part to a shift in feeding strategies: in addition to hunting seals, the Svalbard polar bears have begun relying on a diet of reindeer meat and birds' eggs.

Based on the texts, how would the researchers in Text 2 most likely respond to the conclusion presented in the underlined portion of Text 1?

- A) By noting that it neglects the possibility of some polar bear populations adapting to changes in their environment
- B) By suggesting that it is likely incorrect about the rates at which warming ocean temperatures have caused sea ice to melt in the Arctic
- C) By asserting that it overlooks polar bear populations that have not yet been affected by loss of seal-hunting habitats
- D) By arguing that it fails to account for polar bears' reliance on a single seal-hunting strategy

11. Text 1

Growth in the use of novel nanohybrids—materials created from the conjugation of multiple distinct nanomaterials, such as iron oxide and gold nanomaterials conjugated for use in magnetic imaging—has outpaced studies of nanohybrids’ environmental risks. Unfortunately, risk evaluations based on nanohybrids’ constituents are not reliable: conjugation may alter constituents’ physiochemical properties such that innocuous nanomaterials form a nanohybrid that is anything but.

Text 2

The potential for enhanced toxicity of nanohybrids relative to the toxicity of constituent nanomaterials has drawn deserved attention, but the effects of nanomaterial conjugation vary by case. For instance, it was recently shown that a nanohybrid of silicon dioxide and zinc oxide preserved the desired optical transparency of zinc oxide nanoparticles while mitigating the nanoparticles’ potential to damage DNA.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the assertion in the underlined portion of Text 1?

- A) By concurring that the risk described in Text 1 should be evaluated but emphasizing that the risk is more than offset by the potential benefits of nanomaterial conjugation
- B) By arguing that the situation described in Text 1 may not be representative but conceding that the effects of nanomaterial conjugation are harder to predict than researchers had expected
- C) By denying that the circumstance described in Text 1 is likely to occur but acknowledging that many aspects of nanomaterial conjugation are still poorly understood
- D) By agreeing that the possibility described in Text 1 is a cause for concern but pointing out that nanomaterial conjugation does not inevitably produce that result

12. Text 1

Africa’s Sahara region—once a lush ecosystem—began to dry out about 8,000 years ago. A change in Earth’s orbit that affected climate has been posited as a cause of desertification, but archaeologist David Wright also attributes the shift to Neolithic peoples. He cites their adoption of pastoralism as a factor in the region drying out: the pastoralists’ livestock depleted vegetation, prompting the events that created the Sahara Desert.

Text 2

Research by Chris Brierley et al. challenges the idea that Neolithic peoples contributed to the Sahara’s desertification. Using a climate-vegetation model, the team concluded that the end of the region’s humid period occurred 500 years earlier than previously assumed. The timing suggests that Neolithic peoples didn’t exacerbate aridity in the region but, in fact, may have helped delay environmental changes with practices (e.g., selective grazing) that preserved vegetation.

Based on the texts, how would Chris Brierley (Text 2) most likely respond to the discussion in Text 1?

- A) By pointing out that given the revised timeline for the end of the Sahara’s humid period, the Neolithic peoples’ mode of subsistence likely didn’t cause the region’s desertification
- B) By claiming that pastoralism was only one of many behaviors the Neolithic peoples took part in that may have contributed to the Sahara’s changing climate
- C) By insisting that pastoralism can have both beneficial and deleterious effects on a region’s vegetation and climate
- D) By asserting that more research needs to be conducted into factors that likely contributed to the desertification of the Sahara region

13. **Text 1**

Soy sauce, made from fermented soybeans, is noted for its umami flavor. Umami—one of the five basic tastes along with sweet, bitter, salty, and sour—was formally classified when its taste receptors were discovered in the 2000s. In 2007, to define the pure umami flavor scientists Rie Ishii and Michael O’Mahoney used broths made from shiitake mushrooms and kombu seaweed, and two panels of Japanese and US judges closely agreed on a description of the taste.

Text 2

A 2022 experiment by Manon Jünger et al. led to a greater understanding of soy sauce’s flavor profile. The team initially presented a mixture of compounds with low molecular weights to taste testers who found it was not as salty or bitter as real soy sauce. Further analysis of soy sauce identified proteins, including dipeptides, that enhanced umami flavor and also contributed to saltiness. The team then made a mix of 50 chemical compounds that re-created soy sauce’s flavor.

Based on the texts, if Ishii and O’Mahony (Text 1) and Jünger et al. (Text 2) were aware of the findings of both experiments, they would most likely agree with which statement?

- A) On average, the diets of people in the United States tend to have fewer foods that contain certain dipeptides than the diets of people in Japan have.
- B) Chemical compounds that activate both the umami and salty taste receptors tend to have a higher molecular weight than those that only activate umami taste receptors.
- C) Fermentation introduces proteins responsible for the increase of umami flavor in soy sauce, and those proteins also increase the perception of saltiness.
- D) The broths in the 2007 experiment most likely did not have a substantial amount of the dipeptides that played a key part in the 2022 experiment.

14. **Text 1**

Astronomer Mark Holland and colleagues examined four white dwarfs—small, dense remnants of past stars—in order to determine the composition of exoplanets that used to orbit those stars. Studying wavelengths of light in the white dwarf atmospheres, the team reported that traces of elements such as lithium and sodium support the presence of exoplanets with continental crusts similar to Earth’s.

Text 2

Past studies of white dwarf atmospheres have concluded that certain exoplanets had continental crusts. Geologist Keith Putirka and astronomer Siyi Xu argue that those studies unduly emphasize atmospheric traces of lithium and other individual elements as signifiers of the types of rock found on Earth. The studies don’t adequately account for different minerals made up of various ratios of those elements, and the possibility of rock types not found on Earth that contain those minerals.

Based on the texts, how would Putirka and Xu (Text 2) most likely characterize the conclusion presented in Text 1?

- A) As unexpected, because it was widely believed at the time that white dwarf exoplanets lack continental crusts
- B) As premature, because researchers have only just begun trying to determine what kinds of crusts white dwarf exoplanets had
- C) As questionable, because it rests on an incomplete consideration of potential sources of the elements detected in white dwarf atmospheres
- D) As puzzling, because it’s unusual to successfully detect lithium and sodium when analyzing wavelengths of light in white dwarf atmospheres

15. **Text 1**

Fossils of the hominin *Australopithecus africanus* have been found in the Sterkfontein Caves of South Africa, but assigning an age to the fossils is challenging because of the unreliability of dating methods in this context. The geology of Sterkfontein has caused soil layers from different periods to mix, impeding stratigraphic dating, and dates cannot be reliably imputed from those of nearby animal bones since the bones may have been relocated by flooding.

Text 2

Archaeologists used new cosmogenic nuclide dating techniques to reevaluate the ages of *A. africanus* fossils found in the Sterkfontein Caves. This technique involves analyzing the cosmogenic nucleotides in the breccia—the matrix of rock fragments immediately surrounding the fossils. The researchers assert that this approach avoids the potential for misdating associated with assigning ages based on Sterkfontein’s soil layers or animal bones.

Based on the texts, how would the researchers in Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined portion in Text 1?

- A) They would emphasize the fact that the *A. africanus* fossils found in the Sterkfontein Caves may have been corrupted in some way over the years.
- B) They would contend that if analyses of surrounding layers and bones in the Sterkfontein Caves were combined, then the dating of the fossils there would be more accurate.
- C) They would argue that their techniques are better suited than other methods to the unique challenges posed by the Sterkfontein Caves.
- D) They would claim that cosmogenic nuclide dating is reliable in the context of the Sterkfontein Caves because it is applied to the fossils directly.

Chapter 15: Structure

Structure questions give you a short passage and ask you to describe the overall structure of the passage.

Structure questions are already easy to spot because the question always looks like this:

1. Which choice best describes the **overall structure** of the text?

To understand the structure, we must consider the passage as a whole. The good news is that structure questions are generally one of the easier types of reading comprehension questions on the SAT.

How To Approach Structure Questions

For Structure we recommended using the approach below:

1. **Read the question and recognize that it is a Structure question.** Since Structure questions always includes the words “overall structure,” this step is easy.
2. **Read the entire passage.** If the passage includes a description above the passage, make sure to read that as well. As you read the passage, focus on the understanding the passage as a whole. It is good to take note of the overall structure as you read, but **you should NOT try to come up with your own answer for the structure** of the passage.
3. **Reread the passage (if necessary).** If you feel like you do not fully understand the passage on your first read, reread the passage before reading the answer choices.
4. **Read the answer choices.** As you read each answer choice, look for details that make the answer incorrect. Answer choices for these questions most commonly include statement with multiple parts and can look like this:
 - A) It describes the goal of a particular study, then highlights a characteristic about the participants in the study.
 - B) It defines a particular type of study, then outlines under what situations that type of study should be used.

Whenever the answer choices have multiple parts, we can assess each part of the answer choice independently. **If any part of the answer choice is incorrect, eliminate that entire answer choice!**

5. **Reread the parts of the passage (if necessary).** As you assess each answer choice, you may have to go back to the corresponding parts of the passage to see if the statements in the answer choices match the structure of the passage.
6. **Select the correct answer.** At this point, you should hopefully be confident in your answer. If you are still unsure, mark the question for review. You can always come back to revisit the question if you have time left over at the end.

Many answer choices on Structure questions are clearly incorrect, so using this method and working backwards with the answer choices makes these questions much easier to answer correctly.

Let's apply this approach with the practice question below:

1. The following text is adapted from the 1928 novel *The Sea Mystery* by Freeman Willis Crofts. Mr. Morgan and his son are out fishing in the sea.

Mr. Morgan was a small, clean-shaven man in a worn and baggy Norfolk suit which was the bane of Mrs. Morgan's existence, but in which the soul of her lord and master delighted as an emblem of freedom from the servitude of the office. He leaned back in the sternsheets, gazing out dreamily on the broad sweep of the Inlet and the lengthening shadows ashore. At times his eyes and thoughts turned to his son, Evan, the fourteen-year-old boy who was rowing. A good boy, thought Mr. Morgan, and big for his age. Though he had been at school for nearly three years, he was still his father's best pal. As Mr. Morgan thought of the relations between some of his friends and their sons, he felt a wave of profound thankfulness sweep over him.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It describes Mr. Morgan's demeanor, illustrates how that his demeanor affects how he interprets his surroundings, and highlights why he is thankful for his son.
- B) It depicts what delights Mr. Morgan, describes Mr. Morgan's lack of focus on his son, and compares Mr. Morgan and his son's relationship to those of his son's classmates.
- C) It describes Mr. Morgan's appearance, depicts his behavior on the boat, and discusses his relationship with his son.
- D) It emphasizes what Mrs. Morgan does not like about her husband, illustrates how he enjoys spending time fishing, and discusses why fishing is so important to him and his son.

The text begins with a description of Mr. Morgan's appearance, describing what he looks like and the clothing that is he wearing, and information about something Mrs. Morgan does not like about Mr. Morgan, saying the suit he wears was the bane of her existence. Based on the start of the text, we can eliminate A as incorrect, as the text never discusses Mr. Morgan's demeanor, and B as incorrect, as it does not describe what delights Mr. Morgan. Answer choices C and D could both be correct based on the start of the text.

Next, the text next describes what Mr. Morgan is doing on the boat and then moves on to discuss Mr. Morgan's relationship with his son. Answer choice C matches this description, so it could still be correct. Answer choice D says he enjoys fishing, but there is no evidence in the passage that shows Mr. Morgan enjoying fishing, so answer choice D looks to be incorrect. At this point, we are pretty sure that C is correct, but we should always make sure the entire answer is correct.

The text finishes with Mr. Morgan describing his relationship with his son and focuses on how thankful Mr. Morgan is to have such a good relationship with his son. This matches answer choice C, so C is correct. For answer choice D, the passage never says that fishing is important to Mr. Morgan or his son, so D is incorrect.

2 Tips for Success on Structure Questions

Whenever you see a Structure question on the SAT, make sure that you use the following 2 tips:

1. **Evaluate the answer choices in pieces.** Most answer choices for Structure questions have multiple parts that correspond to separate portions of the passage, as we saw in the example above. Whenever you see answer choices with multiple pieces, you should evaluate each piece separately. All pieces must match the passage for the correct answer, so **if one piece of the answer choice is incorrect, eliminate the entire answer choice as incorrect.**

2. **Beware of partly correct answer choices.** Many incorrect answer choices on Structure questions are partly right. It can be tempting to select an answer choice that matches part of the passage perfectly, but the entire answer must be correct! **Make sure the answer you select matches the entire passage.** The SAT commonly writes partly correct answer choices on Structure questions to try to trick you.

Let's apply everything we have learned on 2 more practice questions below:

- Colombian artist Fernando Botero is celebrated for his unique style of depicting figures and objects in exaggerated, voluminous forms. His 1991 painting *The Musician* exemplifies this style, where each of the six plump members of the band hold oversized instruments and take up nearly the entire canvas. His use of exaggerated proportions is not just a stylistic choice to make his paintings more whimsical but also helps to let the viewer reexamine commonplace people and objects as extraordinary.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- It presents an interpretation of Fernando Botero's artwork, then gives a specific example supporting that interpretation.
 - It describes what styles of art influenced Fernando Botero, then discusses how and why those styles appear in many of his pieces of art.
 - It provides a detailed analysis of *The Musician*, then describes what works it later influenced.
 - It introduces Fernando Botero's signature style, then discusses a piece of his art that exemplifies that style.
- The following text is adapted from Rainer Maria Rilke's 1903 poem "The Panther"

His weary glance, from passing by the bars,
Has grown into a dazed and vacant stare;
It seems to him there are a thousand bars
And out beyond those bars the empty air.

The pad of his strong feet, that ceaseless sound
Of supple tread behind the iron bands,
Is like a dance of strength circling around,
While in the circle, stunned, a great will stands.

But there are times the pupils of his eyes
Dilate, the strong limbs stand alert, apart,
Tense with the flood of visions that arise
Only to sink and die within his heart.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- It presents the confinement of the panther, then it focuses on the psychological impact of the confinement on the panther.
- It focuses on the fatigue of the panther, then it focuses on the deterioration of the panther's body.
- It considers why the panther wants to escape its confinement, then it discusses the panther's acceptance of its new reality.
- It describes the physical state of the panther, then it highlights the strength of the panther's will.

Structure Practice:

- 1) Many films from the early 1900s have been lost. These losses include several films by the first wave of Black women filmmakers. We know about these lost movies only from small pieces of evidence. For example, an advertisement for Jennie Louise Touissant Welcome's documentary *Doing Their Bit* still exists. There's a reference in a magazine to Tressie Souders's film *A Woman's Error*. And Maria P. Williams's *The Flames of Wrath* is mentioned in a letter and a newspaper article, and one image from the movie was discovered in the 1990s.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) The text identifies a complex problem, then presents examples of unsuccessful attempts to solve that problem.
 - B) The text summarizes a debate among researchers, then gives reasons for supporting one side in that debate.
 - C) The text describes a general situation, then illustrates that situation with specific examples.
 - D) The text discusses several notable individuals, then explains commonly overlooked differences between those individuals.
- 2) Michelene Pesantubbee, a historian and citizen of the Choctaw Nation, has identified a dilemma inherent to research on the status of women in her tribe during the 1600s and 1700s: the primary sources from that era, travel narratives and other accounts by male European colonizers, underestimate the degree of power conferred on Choctaw women by their traditional roles in political, civic, and ceremonial life. Pesantubbee argues that the Choctaw oral tradition and findings from archaeological sites in the tribe's homeland supplement the written record by providing crucial insights into those roles.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It details the shortcomings of certain historical sources, then argues that research should avoid those sources altogether.
- B) It describes a problem that arises in research on a particular topic, then sketches a historian's approach to addressing that problem.
- C) It lists the advantages of a particular research method, then acknowledges a historian's criticism of that method.
- D) It characterizes a particular topic as especially challenging to research, then suggests a related topic for historians to pursue instead.

- 3) Works of moral philosophy, such as Plato’s Republic or Aristotle’s Nicomachean Ethics, are partly concerned with how to live a morally good life. But philosopher Jonathan Barnes argues that works that present a method of living such a life without also supplying a motive are inherently useful only to those already wishing to be morally good—those with no desire for moral goodness will not choose to follow their rules. However, some works of moral philosophy attempt to describe what constitutes a morally good life while also proposing reasons for living one.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It provides a characterization about a field of thought by noting two works in it and then details a way in which some works in that field are more comprehensive than others.
 - B) It mentions two renowned works and then claims that despite their popularity it is impossible for these works to serve the purpose their authors intended.
 - C) It summarizes the history of a field of thought by discussing two works and then proposes a topic of further research for specialists in that field.
 - D) It describes two influential works and then explains why one is more widely read than the other.
- 4) The following text is adapted from Gwendolyn Bennett’s 1926 poem “Street Lamps in Early Spring.”

Night wears a garment
 All velvet soft, all violet blue...
 And over her face she draws a veil
 As shimmering fine as floating dew...
 And here and there
 In the black of her hair
 The subtle hands of Night
 Move slowly with their gem-starred light.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It presents alternating descriptions of night in a rural area and in a city.
- B) It sketches an image of nightfall, then an image of sunrise.
- C) It makes an extended comparison of night to a human being.
- D) It portrays how night changes from one season of the year to the next.

- 5) The following text is from Charlotte Perkins Gilman’s 1910 poem “The Earth’s Entail.”

No matter how we cultivate the land,
Taming the forest and the prairie free;
No matter how we irrigate the sand,
Making the desert blossom at command,
We must always leave the borders of the sea;
The immeasurable reaches
Of the windy wave-wet beaches,
The million-mile-long margin of the sea.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) The speaker argues against interfering with nature and then gives evidence supporting this interference.
 - B) The speaker presents an account of efforts to dominate nature and then cautions that such efforts are only temporary.
 - C) The speaker provides examples of an admirable way of approaching nature and then challenges that approach.
 - D) The speaker describes attempts to control nature and then offers a reminder that not all nature is controllable.
- 6) In the *Here and Now Storybook* (1921), educator Lucy Sprague Mitchell advanced the then controversial idea that books for very young children should imitate how they use language, since toddlers, who cannot yet grasp narrative or abstract ideas, seek reassurance in verbal repetition and naming. The most enduring example of this idea is Margaret Wise Brown’s 1947 picture book *Goodnight Moon*, in which a young rabbit names the objects in his room as he drifts off to sleep. Scholars note that the book’s emphasis on repetition, rhythm, and nonsense rhyme speaks directly to Mitchell’s influence.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) The text outlines a debate between two authors of children’s literature and then traces how that debate shaped theories on early childhood education.
- B) The text summarizes an argument about how children’s literature should be evaluated and then discusses a contrasting view on that subject.
- C) The text lists the literary characteristics that are common to many classics of children’s literature and then indicates the narrative subjects that are most appropriate for young children.
- D) The text presents a philosophy about what material is most suitable for children’s literature and then describes a book influenced by that philosophy.

- 7) Mathematician Claude Shannon is widely regarded as a foundational figure in information theory. His most important paper, “A Mathematical Theory of Communication,” published in 1948 when he was employed at Bell Labs, utilized a concept called a “binary digit” (shortened to “bit”) to measure the amount of information in any signal and determine the fastest rate at which information could be transmitted while still being reliably decipherable. Robert Gallager, one of Shannon’s colleagues, said that the bit was “[Shannon’s] discovery, and from it the whole communications revolution has sprung.”

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It presents a theoretical concept, illustrates how the name of the concept has changed, and shows how the name has entered common usage.
 - B) It introduces a respected researcher, describes an aspect of his work, and suggests why the work is historically significant.
 - C) It names the company where an important mathematician worked, details the mathematician’s career at the company, and provides an example of the recognition he received there.
 - D) It mentions a paper, offers a summary of the paper’s findings, and presents a researcher’s commentary on the paper.
- 8) According to Indian economist and sociologist Radhakamal Mukerjee (1889–1968), the Eurocentric concepts that informed early twentieth-century social scientific methods—for example, the idea that all social relations are reducible to struggles between individuals—had little relevance for India. Making the social sciences more responsive to Indians’ needs, Mukerjee argued, required constructing analytical categories informed by India’s cultural and ecological circumstances. Mukerjee thus proposed the communalist “Indian village” as the ideal model on which to base Indian economic and social policy.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) The text recounts Mukerjee’s early training in the social scientific disciplines and then lists social policies whose implementation Mukerjee oversaw.
- B) The text mentions some of Mukerjee’s economic theories and then traces their impact on other Indian social scientists of the twentieth century.
- C) The text presents Mukerjee’s critique of the social sciences and then provides an example of his attempts to address issues he identified in his critique.
- D) The text explains an influential economic theory and then demonstrates how that theory was more important to Mukerjee’s work than other social scientists have acknowledged.

Part 3:

Maximize Your Score

In Part 3 of this course, we focus on how to maximize your Reading and Writing score on test day. Getting your best score ever requires effective time management, applying advanced skills and tips to approach the test as effectively as possible, and most importantly practice!

Chapter 16: Pacing and Time Management

Proper time management is critical to success on the SAT Reading and Writing Test. The Reading and Writing Test is a section on the SAT that students can struggle finishing, especially if you get the harder Module 2. It is important that you not only know your pacing but also understand some skills and tips to improve your time management skills.

Pacing

The SAT Reading and Writing Test consists of two 32-minute modules (regular time) or two 48-minute modules (extended time) with 27 questions in each module. **On average, you have 1 minute and 11 seconds per question, but the amount of time you take per question will vary depending on the question type.** Remember, we always see the following 5 types of questions in each Reading and Writing Module in the order they are listed below:

1. Words in Context (4-7 questions per module)
2. Reading Comprehension (8-12 questions per module)
3. Conventions of Standard English (6-8 questions per module)
4. Transitions (1-4 questions per module)
5. Notes (1-5 questions per module)

As you can see, the exact number of each type of question is not fixed. The exact breakdown on the digital SATs released so far vary from test to test, so you do not know the exact number of each type of question. However, the breakdown between the Reading and Writing questions is always as follows:

Structure of Reading and Writing Module			
	Question Type	Question Number	Total Questions
Reading	Words in Context	1 to 14, 15, 16, or 17 depending on the test	14-17
	Reading Comprehension		
Writing	Conventions of Standard English	14, 15, 16, or 17 to 27 depending on the test	10-13
	Transitions		
	Notes		

Each Reading and Writing module usually has 52-60% Reading questions and 40-48% Writing questions.

Words in Context, Conventions of Standard English, Transitions, and Notes questions are all faster to answer. Reading Comprehension questions will take you much longer, as you need to take more time to read and understand longer passages.

Our Recommended Time Management

Remember, **you should skip the Reading Comprehensions questions and answer them last.** Our recommendations for general time management are below:

1. **Spend the first 12-17 minutes (regular time) or 18-25 minutes (extended time) answering the 17-21 Words in Context, Conventions of Standard English, Transitions, and Notes questions.** The goal is to be confident and fast on these questions. With that being said, make sure you do not rush and make silly mistakes. With practice, you will find the right pace for you.
2. **Spend the last 15-20 minutes (regular time) or 23-30 minutes on the 8-12 Reading Comprehension questions.** You want as much time banked as possible for the Reading Comprehension questions, as they take much longer to complete.
3. **With any additional time, go back and review any questions you marked for review.** If you are going to change your answer, make sure you have a good reason to do so!
4. **If you still have time left over, check your work.** Start by checking Conventions of Standard English. Make sure you did not miss any commas or other punctuation and that you read the entire sentence. Next, check transitions questions. Make sure you identified the relationship between the sentences properly. If you still have time, check Notes questions and Words In Context questions.

Below is a table show a more specific breakdown by question type to help you keep pace on test day.

Normal Time				
Question Type	Number of Questions		Estimated Time Per Question	Estimated Total Time
Words in Context	4-7	14-17	20-45 seconds	2-5 minutes
Reading Comprehension	8-12		1.5-2 minutes	15-20 minutes
Conventions of Standard English	6-8	10-13	20 seconds – 1 minute	4-6 minutes
Transitions	1-4		30 seconds – 1 minute	1-3 minutes
Notes	1-5		30 seconds – 1.5 minutes	1-4 minutes

These timing breakdowns are general estimates and should not be treated strictly! Your exact pace will depend on your reading speed and aptitude for each type of question. Additionally, every test is different and has different numbers of questions in each category. You should never get too far behind the pace breakdown in the tables. **With practice you will find the timings that is best for you.**

If you have extended time, you can use the breakdowns in the table below:

Extended Time				
Question Type	Number of Questions		Estimated Time Per Question	Estimated Total Time
Words in Context	4-7	14-17	30 seconds – 1 minute	4-7 minutes
Reading Comprehension	8-12		2-3 minutes	23-30 minutes
Conventions of Standard English	6-8	10-13	30 seconds – 1.5 minutes	6-9 minutes
Transitions	1-4		45 seconds – 1.5 minute	2-5 minutes
Notes	1-5		45 seconds – 2 minutes	2-6 minutes

10 Time Management Tips

To score your best, you need to make sure that you have time to answer all 27 questions on the Reading and Writing Test. What follows are some tips that will help you learn to manage your time more effectively on the SAT Reading and Writing.

1) Save the Reading Comprehension Questions for Last.

We cannot stress this enough! You need to skip the Reading Comprehension questions and save them for last. Doing so make time management much easier and ensure you will not mismanage time and have to rush the easier questions that appear later on the Reading and Writing Test.

2) Don't waste time on vocab words you don't know.

When you see a vocabulary word, you either know it or you don't. Do not waste time trying to figure out the definition of a word. If you don't know a word, do the best you can with the words that you know, select an answer choice, and move on.

3) Do not read the passage more than twice before reading the answer choices.

For many passages, you will read the passage twice: one for a general understanding a second time to further understand the passage. **If you do not understand the passage after your 2nd read, do not keep rereading the passage over and over again!** Instead, go to the answer choices. Once you read the answer choices, you can reread the passage. Knowing the answer choices can make it easier to understand the passage and, more importantly, makes it easier to eliminate incorrect answer choices.

4) Get to Know the Pace

It is important to really get to know the pace, so you can tell when you are on pace, ahead or pace, or behind pace without having to constantly check the clock. Once you know the pace, you will have an internal voice in your head tell you when you have more time on a question or when you need to move on. The only way to accomplish this is practice, practice, practice!

5) Do Not Get Stuck

One of the most common mistakes students make is getting stuck on a question for too long. **If you get stuck on a question for too long, mark the question for review, select your best guess, and move on.** It is far better to take your best guess on any question(s) that give you trouble and finish than it is to run out of time and completely guess on a bunch of questions as time is running out. **If you finish the Reading Test with time left, go back to any questions you marked for review.**

The goal is that with practice you will have a sense of when you have time to stick with a question and when you need to move on. Again, the only way to get this sense is with practice!

6) Work Backwards

You will get stuck between answer choices on test day. Even the strongest readers do! **Whenever you get stuck between answers, look for what could be wrong with each answer choice.** Working backwards and eliminating answer choices is often a much easier and faster way to find the correct answer than finding the evidence in the passage that supports the correct answer.

7) Know When To Guess And Move On

There will likely be some questions where you are not 100% confident in your answer. Make sure that you are mentally prepared for this to happen on test day. If you are not 100% confident in your answer, you need to know when to select your best answer and move on.

Of course on hard question you should take more time to try to be as confident as possible, but there is still a limit! You cannot take so much time on these questions that you have to rush or guess on other questions. **If you are truly stuck between two answer choices, it's better to guess, mark the question for review, and move on quickly than it is to take another 1-2 minutes to try to figure it out.** Moving on quickly makes sure that you do not run out of time on other questions. You can always come back at the end if you have time left over.

8) Do Not Freak Out If You Fall Behind the Pace

This is a very important one. **If you check the clock and see that you are behind the pace, do not freak out!** In this situation, most students panic, start to rush, and answer questions too quickly, which usually leads to a bunch of incorrect answers. Do not let this be you!

When you notice that you are behind the pace, make minor adjustments to your approach. **Try to read a little bit more quickly but do not read so fast that you cannot understand what you are reading.** This will help you catch up a little bit. More importantly, **make quicker decisions when answering the questions.** If you read a question and the answer choices and think you know the answer right away, bubble in that answer and move on. You may have to answer some questions before you are 100% sure of your answer. That is okay. A 75% sure answer and finishing all the questions is still better than having to guess on a bunch of questions at the end.

9) Hide The Timer If It Stresses You Out

If the clock ticking down at the top of the screen stresses you out, get rid of it! All you have to do is click “hide” below the time to hide the timer. Whenever you want to check your time, click “show” to check on how much time is left.

10) Be More Mindful of Time on Module 2

If you do well on Module 1 (hopefully all of you will!), module 2 will be more difficult. You will deal with more difficult passages, harder vocabulary words, advanced grammar rules, and harder questions overall. **Time management will be more difficult in Module 2**, so it is important to be even more careful with your time management when completing the harder Module 2 to make sure you can finish all 27 questions.

Chapter 17: Advanced Tips and Skills to Maximize Your Score

Before you start working through some practice Reading sets and full practice SATs, let's discuss some advanced tips and skills that can help you maximize your score. Some of these will be review from what we have already covered in this course while others will be brand new tips and skills that you can use to further improve your scores. Try to use these tips and skills on the mixed Reading practice passages in the next chapter and on practice SATs. If you understand and use these tips, you will be prepared for your best SAT Reading and Writing score ever!

7 Advanced Skills

Advanced Skill #1 – Know Your Strengths and Weaknesses

Look back through the chapters in this course and **identify your favorite and least favorite types of Reading Comprehension questions**. Knowing your own strengths and weaknesses will help you be better prepared for test day. For questions you are strong in, answer those questions more quickly and confidently. For questions you are weaker in, be prepared to take more time on those question or to have to select your best guess and move on.

Also, **write down a list of the common mistakes you make and how you can avoid those mistakes on test day**. The better you know your personal pattern of mistakes, the better prepared you are to not make those mistakes on the real SAT!

Advanced Skill #2 – You Don't Have to do Reading Comprehension Questions In Order

While most students complete the 8-12 Reading Comprehension questions in each module in order, you do not need to do it this way! **If you are tight on time, it can be effective to answer the questions out of order!** At this point, you likely know which types of Reading Comprehension questions are your favorites and least favorite. Generally speaking, most students are faster on their favorite types of questions and slower on their least favorites.

If you are running low on time, skip your least favorite types of Reading Comprehension questions or any questions that you know will take you a long time. For example, if you know that passages with poems or Cross Text Connections questions always take you a long time, save these questions for last. Answer all other question types first. This strategy will help you answer as many questions as possible correctly and will help maximize your score.

Advanced Skill #3 – Have A Plan If You Get Low On Time

It's important to plan ahead for any test day scenarios, so you know exactly what to do! What should you do if you have 6 minutes left and have 4 Reading Comprehension questions left? Well, you should skip any questions you recognize will take you a long time and should start with questions you can answer more quickly. Answer questions as quickly as possible and be prepared to select an answer before you are 100% confident in your answer choice. We will want to at least be able to make an educated guess on each question and not entirely guess.

Advanced Skill #4 – Don’t Second Guess Yourself

If you have time to go back and revisit questions you marked for review, only change your answer if you have a good reason! You are usually correct on your first attempt. However, if you realize you misread the question, did not notice a detail in the passage, or notice something that makes the answer choice you selected incorrect, change your answer.

Advanced Skill #5 – Work Backwards On Poems

Many students find poems more difficult to understand on your own. If you find poems hard to interpret, let the answer choices to help out! After reading the answer choices, it can be easier to reread the poem, better understand the meaning, and work backwards and eliminate incorrect answer choices.

Advanced Skill #6 – Beware of Inverse Evidence

For challenging questions, the evidence in the passage may be the inverse of what is stated in the correct answer choice.

Cormorants’ diets generally are around 95% fish, with the last 5% consisting of insects, crustaceans, and amphibians. However, one group of cormorants in this study took advantage of a recent increase in the amphibian population. As the cormorants increased the proportion of amphibians in their diets, the levels of mercury in their blood decreased 18% below baseline levels.

1. What does the passage most strongly suggest about cormorants that have a diet that is exclusively fish?
 - A) They have higher levels of mercury in their blood than do cormorants that consume a higher proportion of amphibians.
 - B) They experience an 18% decrease in the level of mercury in their blood.
 - C) They dislike the taste of tree frogs.
 - D) They are unaware of the increases in the tree frog population.

For this question, the correct answer is A. The evidence in the passage states, “as the cormorants increased the proportion of amphibians in their diets, the levels of mercury in their blood decreased 18% below the baseline levels.” In short, as the cormorants eat more amphibians (and thereby less fish), the mercury level in their blood decreases. The inverse must also be true. Cormorants that eat fewer amphibians (and thereby more fish) will have a comparably higher mercury level in their blood. The question asks about cormorants that eat exclusively fish, so we can infer that the levels of mercury in these birds are higher than cormorants that consume a higher proportion of amphibians based on the evidence we found in the passage.

The other answer choices are all incorrect because they are not in the passage (C and D) or the opposite/slant of what the evidence in the passage (B).

Inverse evidence can appear on Specific Detail Inference questions, Claims questions, Data questions, Complete The Text Questions, and Cross Text Connections questions. These questions are often some of the more advanced and challenging questions on the test.

Advanced Skill #7 – Use the Differences in the Answer Choices to Your Advantage

When you find yourself stuck between two answer choices that seem very close to one another, focus on the differences between the answer choices instead of the similarities. In this situation, students usually focus on the portion of the answer choice that they find to be correct. This approach can make it very difficult to pick an answer confidently because the correct portion can be extremely similar in multiple answer choices. Often, there may be different wording that has the same general message, making it impossible to pick an answer choice that is more correct since the portion you are focusing on is actually correct in both answer choices.

So how can you tell which one is correct? Let the answer choices help you out! Find the differences between the answer choices you are stuck between. Then, focus on the differences as you assess each answer choice. Look for any details in an answer choice that makes it incorrect. Or find which answer choice is 100% correct and is entirely supported by the passage. Either way, focusing on the differences instead of the similarities helps you more clearly understand what you are looking for and more confidently (and quickly) select the correct answer.

8 Tips To Maximize Your Score

Test day is stressful. Questions feel harder. Time seems to go by faster. And there is the pressure to perform well. Of course, all of this makes scoring well on the real SAT even more difficult!

You have done all of this SAT prep and studying and now you have to show what you have learned. **The following tips will help manage the added pressure and stress of the real SAT and be prepared to achieve some great SAT scores!**

Tip #1 – Keep it Moving

Time management is critical for success on the Reading and Writing Test. Remember, **you should take 12-17 minutes on all other questions and save 15-20 minutes for the 8-12 Reading Comprehension questions.** To do this consistently, it is important to **know when to guess and move on to the next question.**

In general, **you should not spend more than 1-1.25 minutes on any single non-reading comprehension question (1.5-2 minutes for extended time) and no more than 2 minutes on most Reading Comprehension questions (3 minutes for extended time).** At first, it may be hard to manage time and know when to move on, but you will get a better sense of time management as you complete practice SATs. With practice, you will develop a voice in your head saying, “It’s time to select your best guess and move on.”

We know it feels weird moving on without being confident in your answer choice but **knowing when to move on will increase your score.** You will answer more questions and avoid guessing as time is running out.

Tip #2 – Mark Guesses and Non-Confident Answers For Review

If you guess on a question or are not confident in your answer, mark that question for review. If you finish with time left, go back to the questions you marked for review. The question may seem easier when you come back to it a second time. You may also think more clearly without the pressure of needing to finish the test.

Tip #3 – Never Worry About Patterns in the Answer Choices

“I selected in A for the last 4 questions. There is no way this one can be A again, right??” WRONG! **When answering a question, only focus on that question. Never let any pattern in the answer choices affect which answer choice you pick.** Sometimes, the same answer is correct 4 or even 5 times in a row on the SAT. It is also possible that you answered one of the previous questions incorrectly, and there are not supposed to be 4 or 5 in a row. There is no way for you to know on test day, so just focus on selecting what you think is correct for each question.

Tip #4 – Boring is Better on Reading Comprehension Questions

Boring answer choices are usually better on Reading Comprehension questions. **If you are ever between two answer choices, always pick the more boring answer choice!** The more specific an answer choice is, the more likely something in that answer choice is incorrect. Remember, an answer choice must be 100% correct to be correct on the Reading Test.

The challenge is that we do not like to pick boring answer choices, especially on challenging questions. An answer choice with more details is much easier to come up with a story as to why the answer could be correct, which makes you feel better bubbling it in. Your job is to pick the answer choice that is supported by the passage, not the one that feels best to you. So again, when you are between two answer choices, pick the boring one with fewer details.

Tip #5 – Beware of Keyword Matching on Reading Comprehension Questions

Anytime you see words in an answer choice that directly match words from the passage, proceed with caution. Make sure the entire answer choice is correct. Matching keywords may be in the correct answer choice, but they are also often in incorrect answer choices that are half-truths, where part of the answer choice perfectly matches the passage but another part is incorrect. Students often mistakenly pick these incorrect answer choices because the keywords match. **Never just match keywords; always make sure the answer choice you select is 100% correct.**

Tip #6 – Track Your Mistakes

As you complete practice problem sets and practice SATs, **we recommend keeping a mistake log.** If you answer a question incorrectly, there is a reason why and always something you can learn from that mistake. A reason like “I misread the passage” is not going to help you improve. Instead, **try to identify why you answered the question incorrectly and how you can avoid that mistake in the future.**

For any question you answer incorrectly in this course and on practice tests, **write down the question number, question type, why you made the mistake, and what you need to learn from this question.** Over time, you will learn the types of questions that challenge you the most and the types of mistakes you most commonly make. Knowing this will help you know which questions to be more careful with and catch potential mistakes on test day.

Tip #7 – Make the Most of Practice SATs

Practice SATs are the best way to improve...if you are using and reviewing them properly. Here are some tips for how to make the most of your practice SATs:

1. **Always time practice SATs strictly.** Never pause the test or give yourself extra time to finish the section and see how you would have scored. It will give you false confidence for how much you are improving.
2. **Review your mistakes thoroughly.** Whenever you answer a question incorrectly, go back to the passage and find why your answer was incorrect and why the correct answer was correct. For Reading Comprehension questions, make sure you find the evidence in the passage that supports the correct answer. It is critical to learn from every single mistake you make to continuously improve.
3. **Be obsessive about improving.** Students who improve the most on the SAT are the ones who are most obsessive about learning from their mistakes. After each question, try to figure out why you missed the question. Did you not read the question, passage, or answer choices closely enough? Did you not recognize the type of question? Did you apply the correct strategy/approach for this type of question? Once you figure out why you made the mistake, think about how you can avoid the mistake in the future. If necessary, go review any topic(s) from the chapters we have already covered.

Tip #8 – Practice Like It's Your Real SAT!

Treat your practice SATs like the real thing! If possible, **take your practice SATs in the morning around 8:30am and complete the test in 1 sitting. Follow the timing guidelines and breaks strictly.** Make sure you **take practice SATs in a quiet, focused environment free of distractions and interruptions.**

Before taking a practice SAT, make sure that you do the following to be ready for the Reading questions:

1. **Review all the vocabulary words you have memorized to date.**
2. **Know your approach for each Reading Comprehension question type.** To do this, you will likely need to review chapters 7-15.
3. **Know how to spot each question type.** There is a list of all 9 types of Reading Comprehension questions on p. 32. We learned how to spot each type of question at the start of chapters 7-15.
4. **Review tips for success and mistakes to avoid for each question type.** The tips for success and mistakes to avoid are in chapters 7-15.
5. **Review your mistake log.** Look back at all the questions you have missed in practice and on previous practice SATs.

The list above is focused on the Reading course. Of course, **you should review the grammar rules you have learned in Writing course, all chapters you have covered in the Math Course along with your math mistake log, and any other practice SATs you have completed** as well before taking your practice SATs.

Final Tip For Success!

Review Your Practice SAT using videos in the Practice SAT Explanation right away! We recommend that you review the practice SAT the same day that you complete it. By reviewing the practice SAT right away, you will more likely remember exactly what you were thinking as you answered each question. As you watch the video explanations, you can identify exactly what you did correctly, where you made any mistakes in your thinking, and make notes on how you can improve on your next SAT.

Answer Key

Chapter 1: Words In Context

Completes The Text Practice (p. 6):

1. C
2. D

Most Nearly Means Practice (p. 8)

1. A
2. C

Clue Words Drill (p. 13)

Example word to plug into the blank are listed first.
The clue words are underlined.

1. subtle, lifeless, dull (or a similar word)

In traditional Japanese woodblock prints, the portrayal of human emotions is _____. Yet, the elements of nature, such as waves and trees, are rendered with dynamic movement and energy, giving them a vibrant, almost animated character.

2. limited (or similar word)

Contemporaries of American novelist F. Scott Fitzgerald praised only his two novels about the flamboyance and excess of the Jazz Age taking _____ view of his work. However, he wrote four novels, story collections, and 164 short stories about a broad range of topics.

3. predicts, hypothesizes (or similar word)

Computer scientist Guido Van Rossum _____ that in the next 15 years artificial intelligence will replace many entry level computer programmers. This possibility is alarming and concerning for many studying computer sciences, but Van Rossum still believes that humans will be necessary to check the code and fix errors artificial intelligence will create.

4. a sustainable, an environmentally friendly, a better (or similar word/phrase)

According to many environmentalists, disposing of organic waste in landfills is a damaging practice because organic waste decomposes into methane gas, which is a significant contributor to global warming. Maggots may provide _____ alternative: maggots consume organic waste before it can decompose into methane gas and become a protein source for livestock and pets.

5. perceptible, discernable, observable, noticeable (or similar word)

Within the coral reefs of the Great Barrier Reef, marine biologists are studying the clownfish (Amphiprioninae) to assess if the type of anemone it calls home has _____ effect on the clownfish's behavior – that is, to observe if there are notable changes in behavior between clownfish living in different types of anemones.

6. sensitivity (or similar word)

Although Killer Whales are well known for their ability to hunt as a pack, their true advantage in the ocean is their incredible ability to detect the species of a fish by echolocation. Marine biologists believe this heightened _____ to the echo of their sounds allows the Killer Whales to only exert energy when a hunt will be worthwhile to them.

7. universal (or similar word)

While the majority of flowering plants rely on insect pollination to reproduce, this requirement is not _____. For example, the common dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*) is well adapted for wind pollination, allowing it to propagate even in environments without pollinators.

8. similar, analogous (or similar word)

Bioluminescence is a common nocturnal defense strategy employed by deep-sea creatures such as jellyfish and certain fish species. Recent studies by marine biologists of the mid-ocean depths have uncovered _____ ability in Dinoflagellates, a species of algae, that also emit light, which startled and deterred deep-sea predators from feeding on them.

9. eminent, notable, well-know (or similar word)

_____ mathematician Andrew Wiles is most famous for his proof of Fermat's Last Theorem, which went unsolved for more than 300 years. After years of hard work, Wiles published the proof in 1994, marking a significant achievement in the field of mathematics.

10. stripped, bereft (or similar word)

During the French Revolution, many pieces of art were seized or destroyed, including many masterpieces. Due to the political upheaval, many private collections and royal repositories became _____ of their invaluable pieces.

Chapter 1 Practice (pp. 14-18)

1. D
2. B
3. A
4. A
5. A
6. C
7. D
8. C
9. D
10. A
11. C
12. A
13. B
14. D
15. B
16. C
17. B
18. C
19. B
20. A
21. C
22. C
23. B
24. B
25. D
26. D
27. B
28. A
29. B
30. C

Chapter 5: Correct vs. Incorrect Answers

Not in the Passage Practice (p. 39):

1. D
2. A

Too Specific Practice (p.41)

1. D
2. B

Too Narrow Practice (p. 43):

1. B
2. A

Opposite or Slant of the Passage Practice (p. 45):

1. A
2. C

Could Be True Practice (p. 47):

1. C
2. D

Chapter 7: Specific Detail

Breaking Down Specific Details Questions Practice (p. 58):

1. Clear Evidence
Keywords: residents, orange county, 1950s
Rephrase: What is true about residents of Orange County?
2. Inference
Keywords: Aliana, walnut oil, Da Vinci
Rephrase: Not necessary
3. Clear Evidence
Keywords: why, slighted, graduation ceremony
Rephrase: Not necessary
4. Clear Evidence
Keywords: Ahora, distinction, Māori, Samoan
Rephrase: What is the distinction between the Māori and Samoan nations?
5. Clear Evidence
Keywords: why, Sarah, return, Kansas
Rephrase: No
6. Inference
Keywords: farmers' views, Populist movement, 1890s
Rephrase: What do the farmers think about the Populist movement?
7. Inference
Keywords: Rylee, wrong guitar, onstage, Summertime Blues
Rephrase: why does Rylee have the wrong guitar on Stage?
8. Clear Evidence
Keywords: Miller, consequence of the distortion of images in a lower magnification mirror
Rephrase: Not necessary

9. Inference

Keywords: arctic fox, locate, lemmings, snowpack, windstorm

Rephrase: How can an arctic fox locate lemmings?

10. Inference

Keywords: dolphins strategize with other dolphins, hunting

Rephrase: What shows that dolphins with other dolphin while hunting?

Specific Detail Practice (pp. 59-62):

1. B
2. B
3. C
4. A
5. D
6. A
7. D
8. D
9. B
10. D

Chapter 8: Main Idea

Practice Questions (pp. 65-66):

1. A
2. B

Main Idea Practice (pp. 68-71):

1. A
2. D
3. D
4. C
5. B
6. B
7. D
8. C
9. B
10. C

Chapter 9: Purpose

Practice Questions (p. 75):

1. C
2. C

Purpose Practice (pp. 77-80):

1. D
2. A
3. A
4. D
5. D
6. D
7. C
8. D
9. B
10. D

Chapter 10: Function

Practice Questions (p. 83)

1. C
2. D

Function Practice (pp. 85-88)

1. C
2. C
3. D
4. D
5. D
6. B
7. A
8. A
9. A
10. C

Chapter 11: Claims

Illustrates The Claim Practice (pp. 90-91):

1. C
2. D
3. A

Supports/Weaken The Claim Practice (pp.92-93):

1. C
2. D
3. B

Claims Practice: (pp. 94-101):

1. B
2. B
3. D
4. C
5. D
6. A
7. A

8. D
9. B
10. B
11. B
12. D
13. C
14. A
15. C
16. B
17. D
18. B
19. A
20. C

Chapter 12: Data

Complete The Example Practice (p. 104):

1. C

Support/Weaken The Claim Practice (pp. 106-107):

1. B
2. A

Data Practice (pp. 108-115):

1. C
2. A
3. C
4. D
5. B
6. B
7. A
8. A
9. D
10. B

Chapter 13: Completes The Text

Practice Questions (p. 120):

1. B
2. C

Completes The Text Practice (pp. 121-124):

1. A
2. A
3. C
4. A
5. D
6. B
7. A
8. B

9. B
10. A

Chapter 14: Cross Text Connections

Both Text Agree Practice (p. 126):

1. C

Most Likely Respond Practice (pp. 127-128):

1. A
2. A

Describes A Difference Practice (p. 131):

1. C

Cross Text Connections Practice (pp. 132-139):

1. A
2. A
3. D
4. A
5. A
6. D
7. C
8. B
9. D
10. A
11. D
12. A
13. D
14. C
15. C

Chapter 15: Structure

Practice Questions (p. 142):

1. D
2. A

Structure Practice (pp. 143-146):

1. C
2. B
3. A
4. C
5. D
6. D
7. B
8. C